

Portland City Council Agenda Written Testimony
Document Number 2026-270

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
1	Nate Stewart with IATSE #28	Support	I support the new theater at PSU. This is the best option to support workers, fuel economic growth, and serve the community. The Portland State University Performing Arts Center / Keller Auditorium renovation project provides the best plan for preserving Broadway, opera, and ballet for future generations.	No	07/24/26 9:42 AM
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4	Lee Newberry, IATSE Local 28	Support	To the folks of the Portland City Council, I'm writing in support of the new theater at PSU to serve the current function of the Keller, and allow for its reimagining as an 1800 seat venue. As someone who has been making theater in Portland for two decades, from Shakespeare in shoebox venues to full-scale Broadway productions at the Keller Auditorium, I can attest to the vibrant interest that our city holds for the performing arts. The plan under discussion would allow us to maintain our momentum as a top tier arts destination while growing our capacity for more rich, diverse, and entertaining public performance. This is the best option to support workers, fuel economic growth, and serve the community. The public theaters of Portland are an institution of public good, and need to be protected by the City. Our theaters enrich our communities, create stable, fulfilling jobs, and inspire us to make our city better. The arts are deeply at risk in these uncertain times, and the Portland State University Performing Arts Center / Keller Auditorium renovation project provides the best plan for preserving Broadway, opera, and ballet for future generations. Thank you for your time.	No	07/24/26 9:53 AM
5	Bonnie Henderson-Winnie	Support	Good morning fellow Portlanders, I am writing in support of agenda item 2026-270, which seeks approval for a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. I live in Portland and am a full time arts worker. I have worked in wardrobe, wigs, and makeup for more than 30 years and am a member of IATSE Local 28, the theatrical and stage workers' union. In that time I have seen many changes in the arts ecosystem here, and the most recent years have been some of the roughest. I believe that the proposed Arts and Culture Center at PSU is an excellent remedy to several ongoing problems with our aging venues, improve accessibility to patrons from all over the city, and provide equitable access to suitable performance spaces for some of our smaller local nonprofit performing arts organizations. Once built, it would preserve and even create more living wage jobs and while operating, it would allow the Keller Auditorium to be renovated or reimagined without disruption of employment or of the significant revenue from the touring shows, concerts, and other productions that currently come to the Keller. Contrary to what some reports have stated, Portland is more than capable of supporting a new Arts Center. More urgently, it is needed as the aging venues in town are badly in need of updating for safety and accessibility, and this cannot be put off much longer. Portland also cannot afford a 3 to 5 year cessation of the touring shows and concerts that come through the Keller. Much of that revenue would simply disappear in the gap as would too many living wage jobs. That cost is too high. I urge you to support this agenda item and vote to advance this plan for a new Arts and Culture Center at PSU. Thank you for your time and attention, Bonnie	No	07/24/26 11:28 AM
6	Nathaniel Glasgow	Support with changes	The intent here seems to be to kick the can down the road re Keller Auditorium. Any plan should include a firm funding commitment to preserving Keller and of course the iconic fountain.	No	07/24/26 6:38 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
7 Marc Melo - stagehand - IATSE 28		Portland is a town that refuses to support the arts. From the schools, the community and the government, support for the arts is the last thing on the agenda, and the first to be cut. So.. I propose demolishing the Keller and replace it with a parking lot. A parking lot would at least add an economic boost to the area. The arts?? Let's just be honest, no one cares anymore. Opera struggles. Ballet struggles. Children's theater struggles. Why put money into a dying arts world. Then afterwards, when Portland is flavorless and dull, we'll know why. When art organizations die off, the artists that were once employed, die off too. So, what stopping you??? Entertainment is now TV or the internet. Live shows?? Ha!! You might read this as sarcasm? Don't know why?? This is how the arts world responds after years of abuse and neglect. The Keller should be demolished. Ignore the history of the venue. Ignore the current shows and staff. Ignore the profit or economic push the theater gives the community. Ignore the future of show, both music and Broadway. The Keller is a burden on the city. Demolish it!!! We are a horrible city and we don't deserve nice things.	No	07/24/26 6:40 PM
8 Dana West	Support	As an executive board officer of IATSE Local 28, I am concerned about the future of the arts in our city. The Keller Auditorium has long been the cornerstone of the performing arts in Portland, and while it is not in immediate jeopardy it is nonetheless overdue for upgrades and refurbishment. We have the perfect opportunity to construct a new Broadway capable venue at Portland State University to maintain and expand Portland as a prime touring destination, rather than losing that massive economic benefit by shuttering the Keller for renovations without an adequate replacement available. Building a large scale venue at PSU and then renovating the Keller into a modern, intermediate sized venue creates the maximum benefit for the largest number of people in our community.	No	07/24/26 6:42 PM
9 Summer "Panda" Turpin, IATSE Local 28	Support	Greeting Portland City Life Committee members. I am providing this written testimony as a member of IATSE Local 28, regarding the future of the Keller Auditorium and of Broadway in Portland. My union, IATSE Local 28 voted to endorse the Portland State University Performing Arts Center / Keller Auditorium renovation project. We support the new theater at PSU to serve the current function of the Keller, and allow for its reimagining as an 1800 seat venue. This is the best option to support workers, fuel economic growth, and serve the community. The public theaters of Portland are an institution of public good, and need to be protected by the City. Our theaters enrich our communities, create stable, fulfilling jobs, and inspire us to make our city better. The arts are deeply at risk in these uncertain times, and the Portland State University Performing Arts Center / Keller Auditorium renovation project provides the best plan for preserving Broadway, opera, and ballet for future generations. On a personal level, I have been in favor of this plan since the beginning of these talks. Every other option just seems half baked, and lacks in some way or another that will hurt Portland's workers and businesses. Building a 3000 seat theater on the PSU property, along with other facilities that PSU will have in addition to the 3000 seat Broadway capable theater will be the best way to modernize the Broadway experience in Portland. After that theater is complete, after it is up and running, we then have the opportunity to renovate the Keller Auditorium into an 1800 seat theater that will be perfect for rock shows, comedians, and for local arts groups to have shows that are too big for the Newmark, but not right for a 3000 seat theater. This option keeps Broadway coming to Portland, and allows room for local theater groups to grow in addition. Thank you Summer "Panda" Turpin IATSE Local 28 Member	No	07/24/26 8:07 PM

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10	Kate Mura	Support	Two years ago, I submitted an opinion piece to Oregon ArtsWatch on remembering stagehands when contemplating the fate of the Keller Auditorium. What I wrote then remains true now: "Broadway in Portland must always have a good, appropriate home. Just ask a stagehand." Reading through Hunden Partner's feasibility study, I agree that focusing on maximizing Broadway content and maintaining theatre-style commercial content, while also being an accessible home to resident companies and nonprofits, is important. The PSU construction and Keller renovation plan provides this, including a full performing arts campus and support amenities achievable at PSU, no downtime in hosting large scale shows (which support the other Portland's venues), as well as opportunities for audience and subscription growth. I am concerned by a gap in the same Hunden Partner's feasibility study, which primarily focused on audiences, and existing rentals, while ignoring another revenue driver: A second Broadway capacity house would be a prime location for upcoming Broadway tours to rehearse and prepare, and existing tours to repair and update equipment, as we were able to do for The Lion King. Numerous tours have wished they could prep their shows in Portland due to our highly skilled stagehands and lack of sales tax. Producers can save money and time working here while spending money locally, and it is unfortunate that formal research on this subject seems not to have happened, either via contacting tours or speaking with local stagehands. This study also did not investigate how many tours have been unable to come to Portland due to the limited availability of the Keller. Thank you for your kind attention. Please support & advance the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. Sincerely, Kate Mura Theatre professional and constituent in 97215 Full opinion piece is here: https://www.orartswatch.org/opinion-when-deciding-the-fate-of-keller-auditorium-think-of-the-people-who-work-there/	No	07/24/26 10:44 PM
11	Twila Petrie	Oppose	The present Keller Auditorium needs updating, yes, but it is still a fine place to attend shows. There is no need to remove it as it serves the public well and it is set in a beautiful setting with the waterfall and park to enhance its appearance. The public parking is convenient and never too full. Why spend so much money to remove and replace this great historical building when we don't have the funds or shouldn't use the funds in the proposed way?	Yes	07/25/26 10:25 AM
12	Anonymous	Oppose	We can't afford this	No	07/25/26 11:24 AM
13	Peggy McDaniel	Oppose	As a fervent Broadway supporter and someone that attends multiple venues, frequently I urge the City to NOT mover forward with this expensive project. Would I love to see a state of the art venue here in Portland hosting all the big shows, of course! That said, City Leadership spent much energy settling on where the City would CUT SERVICES and PROGRAMS. Why in the world would we commit to a new, very expensive project without studying more first and figuring out where the money would come from. The City owns the Keller now and it is making money. Keep it going until other issues are sorted out. We cannot afford such an expenditure at this time.	No	07/25/26 1:10 PM
14	Janet Guggenheim		Renovate the Keller and continue to utilize PSU's Lincoln Hall to full capacity (which might include two performances daily) !	No	07/25/26 3:11 PM

Argument in opposition of razing the Keller Auditorium and building a new venue

Facts: (as supplied by “Save Portland’s Keller Auditorium”)

- **No plan.** The recommendation relies on major assumptions that have never been studied.
- **No funding.** There is no financing plan for a project that could approach \$1 billion.
- **No guarantee.** There is no commitment, timeline or funding source ensuring the Keller renovation ever happens.

This is an historical site in Portland. Americans are too fast to remove anything that has history connected to it and Portland is right up there with the worst offenders.

We have no need to remove this building when it only needs upgrading and updating. Putting the maintenance funds to work when we should have been doing this years ago and all along is the right thing to do. Don’t raze and rebuild. That is expensive and unnecessary.

Invest in the “affordable fix” instead of committing to a much larger project.

Our current building which does well showcasing the arts in our city is very functional and attractive. Keep it and make it more beautiful if you want, but don’t throw money away where it is needed more in other areas when what we have is working and meaningful to our city’s history.

--T. Petrie

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
15	Carl M Halvorson	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the Committee on City Life: For the record, my name is Carl Halvorson. I am testifying in support of the resolution to advance a new Broadway-capable venue at PSU. After a long career performing as tenor soloist around the world in many of the greatest concert halls and opera houses, I have long bemoaned the Keller Auditorium. In fact, I've been going to it since it was remodeled in the 60s, I've sung on its stage numerous times with Portland Opera, and I've always seen it as a cultural blight on our city. I have so often seen the disappointed looks on guest artists' faces when they first work on the Keller stage - to say nothing of the audience members straining to see and hear them! The flaws with the hall are too numerous to mention here, and I mean flaws that would not be addressed in original proposed remodel. Very poor acoustics, football field-length sight lines, and that tiny 200'x200' lot are just a few. It's no surprise to me that the experts have all solidly backed the PSU proposal. We would finally have a normally-shaped hall purpose-built with current advanced acoustical expertise, boxes and balconies that are closer to the stage and with improved sight lines, state-of-the-art equipment in a generous backstage with excellent loading docks, a full-sized rehearsal stage (this is so needed), and much more. I believe that making the Keller into a much smaller hall would mitigate its inherent flaws, some left over from the old Auditorium. I note that Avery Fisher Hall, where I sang many times, has finally become a wonderful hall after the New York Philharmonic changed its interior shape in a remodel. Losing that top balcony and narrowing the hall would vastly improve the Keller. I have witnessed that all major American cities have heavily invested in wonderful performing arts complexes, with many halls of different sizes. After sixty years, Portland finally deserves the same. I thank you very much for your service to our city.	No	07/25/26 5:03 PM
16	Craig Loftin	Oppose	Portland already has a Broadway Show capable venue that has been serving this purpose well for years and, in fact, served the Portland community for many many decades. This venue, once known as the City Auditorium, and now known as the Keller Auditorium, should be upgraded according to well known plans at a much lower cost than building a totally new structure in an undeveloped lot in an underdeveloped location of the city. One of Mayor Wilson's stated objectives of his candidacy was that he would help revitalize downtown Portland. What better way to revitalize downtown than to upgrade the Keller and maximize the utilization of existing infrastructure to strengthen civic participation and local business to do so. In this time of critical budget shortfalls in Portland, to do otherwise would be tantamount to political malfeasance. Thank you.	No	07/25/26 5:39 PM
17	Suzanne Bishop	Oppose	Our city leaders avoid maintaining our assets yet continue to commit to massively expensive new projects - that we don't have the money to maintain. We cannot afford this any longer.	No	07/26/26 8:27 AM
18	Fred Wearn	Oppose	We cannot afford his plan and it puts the performing arts center in the wrong place. An empty Keller would be terrible for this part of downtown. It is a much greener approach to renovate the Keller. And it is much more affordable.	No	07/26/26 12:01 PM
19	Fred Wearn	Oppose	We cannot afford his plan and it puts the performing arts center in the wrong place. An empty Keller would be terrible for this part of downtown. It is a much greener approach to renovate the Keller. And it is much more affordable.	No	07/26/26 12:01 PM
20	Annie Bosworth Foley	Support	The new venue at PSU will be a great addition to the Portland entertainment scene and I really hope that the city council does everything it can to support it. Right now the Keller auditorium is equipped with what it needs to support large Broadway shows but if it is remodeled before a new theatre is constructed many people will be out of work, including me. The PSU proposal is strong and will be a great venue for bringing in larger shows. That combined with an 1800 seat Keller auditorium will make Portland arts community strong.	No	07/26/26 5:22 PM
21	Representative Rob Nosse	Support		Yes	07/27/26 9:46 AM
22	Jan Castle	Oppose		Yes	07/27/26 12:59 PM
23	Chris Finks, Board Member, Halprin Landscape Conservancy	Oppose	Please see my attached written testimony outlining my opposition to the proposed recommendation and my support for preserving and renovating the Keller Auditorium through a fiscally responsible, evidence-based approach.	Yes	07/27/26 1:12 PM



***From the Desk of Rob Nosse, State Representative
1712 SE 47th Avenue, Portland, Oregon 97215***

July 26, 2026

Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the City Life Committee:

As one of the leader of the Arts & Culture Caucus in the Oregon Legislatures and as a long-time supporter of the Portland arts community, I am writing to urge you to support the resolution to "Accept the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts recommendations to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University, and at the same time initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium."

During COVID, the arts community experienced unprecedented challenges. Venues went dark, backstage crews and creative workers faced extended hardship due to loss of work, and our cultural ecosystem suffered many financial shocks. As we work to revitalize downtown Portland, we cannot afford to take steps backward or put our region's primary performing arts engine on ice.

Developing a new Broadway-capable venue at Portland State University is the way to go. It is the clearest, most economically responsible path forward for our city. A purpose-built venue integrated with an urban university opens doors for local, emerging, and culturally diverse arts groups that have historically lacked affordable access to world-class facilities.

Portland stands at a pivotal moment. With momentum building across public leadership, philanthropic partners, and community stakeholders, we have an incredible opportunity to anchor our city's creative identity for the next century.

I strongly urge you to vote YES on this resolution to keep our stages lit, protect our cultural workforce, and invest in a thriving downtown. Together, we can do big things for Portland.

I am sorry I cannot be with you in person but if you need to talk with me about this I can best be reached at 971-235-9342 or by email at rep.robnosse@oregonlegislature.gov.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Rob Nosse", with a period at the end. The signature is fluid and cursive.

Rob Nosse
State Representative

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Keller Testimony

My name is Jan Castle, I am a native Portlander, and as of one year ago, a downtown resident. I live in the South Auditorium District very close to the Keller Auditorium and Fountain.

I am unable to address you personally because of illness, but if I were, I would speak from the heart about the profound experience I had yesterday re-reading the Minority Report to the Ex-Officio Table Recommendation of June 3, 2026, which speaks to the recommendations made by Deputy City Administrator Donnie Oliveira.

What really got through to me in this reading was how severely this two-venue option would weaken the financial underpinnings of the entire performing arts ecosystem, perhaps permanently. It would also double or triple the amount the City would have to spend on subsidizing the P5 complex.

You are all aware that the Keller generates a surplus of \$1.2 million a year, a million of which it contributes to the City's subsidization of the P5 complex, reducing the City's expenditure from \$5 million to \$4 million.

If a new venue at PSU takes the Broadway series and the Keller retains the opera, ballet and White Bird series, as is recommended in the latest proposal, the performances will be spread too thin for either venue to be able to cover their expenses. Even if they were all at one or the other of these venues, the competition from the other venue would weaken their take enough that they still wouldn't be profitable. The revenue the Keller generates only works at one venue. Competition from another venue destroys the profit, eliminating the extra million the City has to spend supporting the smaller P5 venues.

While either venue would scramble to generate new business, comments in both Hunden reports and the article Mike Rogoway wrote for the Oregonian both cast doubt on those efforts' ability to fully fill the gap.

I see no documented evidence that Portland needs a 1200-1800 seat venue. To the contrary, the Hunden Partners Dec. 2025 Venue User Survey showed a need for 300-600 and 500-1400 seat venues. No respondent asked for a 1200-1800 seat venue.

I appreciate that you are very busy and must rely on staff to bring you information to consider. Please note that all of the information you have been provided supports the venue at PSU. There has been no attempt to provide you with anything that would support the renovation of the Keller and some creative thinking about how to provide space for Broadway productions while it is under construction. Unless you want your legacy to be the dismantling of the successful and low cost support of the performing arts ecosystem and the increase of the City's subsidization, I'm afraid you are going to have to do your own homework. I would recommend that you review two documents, which hopefully you have already seen. One is the Keller Feasibility Study and the other is the Minority Report to the Ex-Officio Table Recommendation of June 3, 2026.

The real problem to be solved is where to house Broadway productions during a Keller renovation. Please, spend money on that. Do not spend any more money on studies to justify something that makes no sense.

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July 27, 2026

**Mayor Keith Wilson
Council President Jamie Dunphy
Council Vice President Olivia Clark
Councilor Candace Avalos
Councilor Loretta Smith
Councilor Dan Ryan
Councilor Elana Pirtle-Guiney
Councilor Sameer Kanal
Councilor Angelita Morillo
Councilor Steve Novick
Councilor Tiffany Koyama Lane
Councilor Eric Zimmerman
Councilor Mitch Green**

Portland City Hall
1221 SW Fourth Avenue
Portland, OR 97204

RE: Keller Auditorium Renovation and Preservation

Dear Mayor Wilson and Members of the Portland City Council:

My name is Chris Finks. I am the Founder and Principal of FinksCo, a longtime Portland small business owner, experiential marketing and placemaking professional, Executive Producer of community events and public-private partnerships, and a Board Member of the Halprin Landscape Conservancy.

For more than three decades, my career has focused on bringing people together through experiences that strengthen communities, support small businesses, celebrate culture, and activate public spaces. Whether producing events, building partnerships, or working alongside civic organizations, I have learned that successful cities invest wisely in the assets they already possess while creating confidence for future investment.

That is why I am deeply concerned that Portland taxpayers and the Portland City Council are being asked by the Mayor to advance a proposal that could ultimately approach \$1 billion without a defined financing plan, without committed funding, and without certainty that the Keller Auditorium itself will ever be renovated or replaced.

This is not simply a discussion about a theater.

The Keller Auditorium is one of downtown Portland's most important economic and cultural anchors. More than 400,000 visitors each year support nearby restaurants, hotels, retailers, parking facilities, and countless small businesses because of the activity generated by performances at the Keller. As someone who has spent decades producing events, developing destination experiences, and creating partnerships that bring visitors into downtown Portland, I understand how difficult those audiences are to replace once they disappear.

As a Board Member of the Halprin Landscape Conservancy, I also recognize that the Keller Auditorium and Ira Keller Fountain Park are not isolated public assets. Together they are the centerpiece of the internationally significant Halprin Sequence, one of Portland's defining civic places and among the most important examples of integrated architecture, landscape architecture, urban design, and public life in the United States. Preserving that relationship should be a central consideration in any decision affecting this site.

I am not here to oppose the arts. In fact, my career has been built around supporting arts, culture, hospitality, tourism, placemaking, and community experiences that strengthen our city.

I am asking for something much simpler.

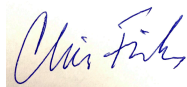
Before committing Portland taxpayers to an unfunded project of this magnitude, the City should complete the work that every responsible public agency should expect: establish a credible financing plan, fully evaluate the affordable renovation alternative, understand the long-term impacts on downtown businesses and our cultural district, and make a decision grounded in evidence rather than assumptions.

Good stewardship requires discipline. Good leadership requires transparency. Good planning requires facts before commitments.

I respectfully urge the Council to preserve and modernize the Keller Auditorium, protect the vitality of downtown Portland, safeguard the internationally recognized Halprin Sequence, and ensure that any decision of this magnitude is supported by sound planning, fiscal responsibility, and public accountability.

Thank you for your thoughtful consideration and for your service to the people of Portland.

Respectfully,



Chris Finks
Board Member
Halprin Landscape Conservancy

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
24	Julie Feely	Support	I am writing to express my strong support for locating the new Portland Performing Arts Center on the PSU campus. This is a once-in-a-generation opportunity to invest in Portland's future and help revitalize our downtown. Portland is ready for renewed energy and momentum. A world-class performing arts center would bring people from across the region into the heart of the city, creating a vibrant destination for residents and visitors alike. The economic impact would extend far beyond the venue itself, supporting restaurants, local businesses, hotels, housing, and retail while creating new opportunities for growth and investment downtown. The arts have always played an important role in bringing communities together, and this project has the potential to be a catalyst for the kind of thriving, connected city we all want Portland to become again. The time to act is now. This is the right choice for Portland. We can build an extraordinary new performing arts center while also reimagining the Keller. Rather than viewing these as competing priorities, we should see them as complementary investments in our future. Together, they can help shape a bold vision for what is possible for Portland for generations to come.	No	07/27/26 3:21 PM
25	Robert Edmiston	Support	I support the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center to be located at Portland State. I believe the center will help to reenergize downtown Portland and will prove to be an engine of Portland's arts economy. The proposed center will provide space for more national and local arts shows in addition to support arts education at Portland State. Thank you for your support.	No	07/27/26 3:25 PM
26	Kailin Anne Mooney	Support	I support advancing Portland State University's Performing Arts and Culture Center because I believe it represents an investment in both Portland's economic future and its cultural identity. As a public high school student in the Seattle area, I experienced firsthand the impact of the community's investment in Benaroya Hall, where my school and countless nonprofit arts organizations had opportunities to perform, learn, and be inspired in a world-class venue. While Benaroya Hall is not Seattle's Broadway theater, I see Portland's proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center as a similarly transformative investment—one that will strengthen our arts ecosystem by creating opportunities for students, nonprofit organizations, community partners, and professional artists alike. Although I now live in Milwaukie, I work in downtown Portland and ride the MAX every day, and I see tremendous value in creating a world-class arts destination that is easily accessible by transit. A performing arts center located directly on the MAX line would make it easier for people across the region to experience Broadway productions, community performances, and cultural events without relying on a car. The project would also strengthen south downtown by bringing visitors who support local restaurants, shops, hotels, and other small businesses. Portland has an opportunity to build an arts ecosystem that serves both today's audiences and the next generation of creative professionals. I respectfully encourage the Committee to support the recommendation and help advance a vision that will benefit Portland and the entire region for decades to come.	No	07/27/26 3:32 PM
27	Nikki Dennis	Oppose	As an arts tax-paying citizen, a patron of the arts, and a resident of District 4, I am testifying to show my support that the historical and long-standing Keller Auditorium be preserved and improved which, to date, has no guarantee in place. If the large-scale performing arts center project goes forward, I feel it is likely that the Keller renovation will be dismissed due to a lack of funding. We are in the midst of budget cuts and downsizing. Since the Keller Auditorium venue is meeting the current need for arts lovers, I see no justification for a new auditorium project when there is a cost-effective solution available. There are improvements that can be made to the Keller that do not burden taxpayers or take away Broadway from that section of downtown that has embraced it lovingly for decades. The Keller Auditorium, along with the majestic Keller Fountain, is an icon and it matters to the people who live there or visit as well as many businesses in that area. You are entrusted with making feasible economic decisions for this community that acknowledge our current financial situation and respect the voices of the community being affected. The decision whether or not to respect and renovate Keller Auditorium over an unrealistic two-theater vision is the time when I feel this will be put to the test.	No	07/27/26 3:57 PM

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28	Anonymous	Oppose	TESTIMONY; Moving forward on the selection of the PSU “concept” investment is short sighted and poor planning. This is not a clear plan or complete proposal. -taking on a new expensive project, in the face of the huge investment on updates to Trailblazer home is not appropriate and not professional -PSU option is not a complete proposal--it is a concept -why waste a facility the city already owns -businesses at RiverPlace, part of District 4, struggle to stay alive. Three major business places have been vacant for years. People attending the Keller would come to RiverPlace to eat and shop. We need the Keller in our community, we are struggling.	No	07/27/26 3:58 PM
29	Katherine Hartner	Support	As a lifelong Portlander who attends many performances at the Keller throughout the year, I’m a strong supporter of the Performing Arts & Culture Center. I’m excited about the opportunity to attract larger Broadway productions and enhance every aspect of the experience—from improved acoustics and a more modern venue to an even better experience for audiences and performers alike.	No	07/27/26 4:10 PM
30	Marge Abbott	Support	The Portland State Performing Arts plus Culture Center is a win in for the City.	No	07/27/26 7:00 PM
31	Corinne Beauvais	Support	First: the Keller, a study has determined, will not survive a major earthquake. A danger to patrons, it is unreinforced masonry, meaning that bricks could tumble on patrons as they exit, possibly injuring or killing them. The new Keller at PSU will be built with the latest standards. Next: The next generation is growing up in the digital age, representing a rapidly challenging audience for the arts. They have expectations of musical experiences being multi-sensory, active, social, customizable and casual. If Portland wants to attract them to its concerts, then it must change the experience of attending for them. Ultimately, the challenge for music with this audience is to reconceive the entire experience to make it entertaining for them – a new model of the concert experience for the 21st century, one that programming, facilities, hospitality all deliver upon. The Performing Arts + Culture Center can deliver on that, the Keller cannot. Thank you, Corinne Beauvais	No	07/27/26 7:16 PM
32	Helen Westbrook	Support	This proposal presents an opportunity for Portland to begin the creation of a wonderful performing arts complex on Lincoln Street. PSU has proposed a development that will lift Portland’s spirit and make Portland a leader nationwide in support of the performing arts. Please give our community this opportunity. Thank you.	No	07/27/26 8:32 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
John Doe, Portland State University	Oppose	Testimony in Opposition to Resolution 2026-270 Chair Pirtle-Guiney and members of the City Life Committee: My name is John Doe, and I am a student at Portland State University. I am using an alias because I fear retaliation. PSU has pushed students aggressively to support this project, and I do not feel comfortable opposing it publicly under my real name. I urge you to oppose Resolution 2026-270, or postpone action until the complete financial, operating, maintenance, and fundraising plans are public and independently reviewed. I value the performing arts and understand that the Keller Auditorium has serious problems. But PSU is already struggling to balance its budget. The university has eliminated positions, reduced academic programs, and asked students, faculty, and staff to accept painful cuts. It also has substantial deferred maintenance and modernization needs across its existing campus. Against that background, how can PSU responsibly take on a large, specialized performing arts complex? Construction funding is not the same as a sustainable operating plan. A new center will require permanent funding for staffing, utilities, security, insurance, technology, repairs, and capital renewal. Students deserve to know who will pay if ticket revenue, parking income, philanthropy, or private development falls short. The project will also consume the attention and fundraising capacity of the PSU Foundation. A campaign of this size will divert staff time, leadership attention, and donor interest from student scholarships, emergency aid, endowed professorships, graduate fellowships, research, and existing facilities. Those priorities directly strengthen PSU. Scholarships improve access, enrollment, and retention. Endowed professorships support teaching and research while reducing pressure on the operating budget. A performing arts center could instead create a permanent new expense. There is also a real risk that future students will pay for shortfalls through higher tuition, fees, parking charges, reduced services, or additional academic cuts. Even without a dedicated student fee, money used for operating losses, maintenance, security, or utilities is money that cannot support instruction, advising, scholarships, or faculty. Without binding protections, this project could become an anchor around the university's neck and effectively tax future generations of students. Before approving this resolution, the City and PSU should publish an independently reviewed life-cycle financial plan and guarantee that tuition, student fees, academic budgets, and general university funds will not be used to cover construction overruns, operating losses, or maintenance shortfalls. A polished rendering is not an operating plan. A fundraising goal is not an endowment. Portland should address the Keller's problems without creating a new financial burden for a university that is already struggling to support its students, employees, and existing buildings. Please oppose Resolution 2026-270 until the full costs, obligations, fundraising consequences, and financial risks are publicly disclosed.	No	07/27/26 10:27 PM
Anita Davidson	Oppose	Timing is wrong for the PSU proposal--reject it and renovate the Keller. Drama and costly upgrades at the Moda Center did not exist when the PSU reports and studies were done. But Moda on top of roads, parks, the Schnitz and Keller--all with deferred maintenance and begging for updates--has sunk citizen trust that the City can manage the big assets we already own. Good grief, the City does not need to add another venue at PSU that is unfunded and envisions an untested co-op of operations--yes, taxpayers in a co-op could have to bail out a new PSU hotel someday. Further, impact of the two large commercial venues already in process (Lloyd Center and Live Nation) is not considered enough in the PSU proposal; not only will they take away demand, they can also provide alternate jobs if some are lost at the Keller temporarily during renovation. FIRST prove to citizens that our government can take care of the assets we have. THEN dream big.	No	07/27/26 10:29 PM

35

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Angela Jackson	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the Committee on City Life: For the record, my name is Angela Jackson. I am writing to testify in support of the resolution to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. While I hold a part-time position at PSU, my opinions are my own, from my perspective as a former Oregon Ballet Theatre teacher, entrepreneur, engaged citizen and long-time District 3 resident. As a developer of potential in people and places, I know this is a critical time to invest in Downtown Portland's future, in a manner that will retain and expand downtown visits as we shift to an attraction economy. We cannot risk a downtown recovery by shutting down a facility for renovation (Keller) for multiple years without a replacement. Nor can we shut the door on the future by failing to accommodate current and future Broadway-scale shows. The two Committee recommendations, and the recommendation advanced by Mayor Wilson, reflect that with data and analysis, as well as thoughtful discussion and engagement, from key stakeholders. The PSU project elegantly addresses this opportunity in a manner that also serves adjacent performing artists, students, and arts-adjacent workforce. PSU's deep experience as a developer of downtown properties gives me confidence that the planned performing arts venue, along with adjacent development of currently underutilized parcels, will activate an area of downtown for decades to come, providing much-needed foot traffic, vibrancy, economic impact for local businesses, and a fresh brand identity at the south end of our central city. As a "city geek," I am also personally excited about the potential to reimagine the Keller Auditorium and the connected Halprin sequence of pathways and parks that lead south. It is an urban oasis that has been underutilized for years. I hope you will support this resolution to advance the new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State. Thank you for your service to our city. Sincerely, Angela Jackson District 3 resident	No	07/28/26 7:30 AM
36 State Representative Dacia Grayber, Oregon Legislature	Support		Yes	07/28/26 8:21 AM
37 Jeff Soulages	Support		Yes	07/28/26 9:05 AM

For the attention of:

Portland City Life Committee
Re: Portland State University PACC Project



From the office of:

State Representative Dacia Grayber
House District 28 - SW Portland & E Beaverton

Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the City Life Committee:

My name is Dacia Grayber, I have the honor of serving as State Representative for House District 28, which includes Southwest Portland and the future site of the Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University.

I am writing in support of your resolution to “Accept the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts recommendations to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University, and initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium.”

This visionary project has the potential to revitalize what is currently a quieter corner of downtown Portland. Beyond the brick and mortar, this center is fundamentally about people and workforce stability. A multi-venue, continuous strategy ensures that our highly skilled stagehands, technical workers, and production crews—members of IATSE Local 28 and our broader labor family—do not face years of displacement or dark stages.

Furthermore, integrating this facility into Portland State University's campus will activate South Downtown, connect students with world-class

cultural experiences, and generate needed foot traffic for neighboring small businesses and restaurants.

We have a rare, generational opportunity to act with vision and momentum. With state bonds secured and key regional partners aligned, we are choosing to boldly implement a vision of who we can be as a city.

I strongly urge you to pass this resolution and accept the committee's recommendations to advance the City-owned Broadway capable venue as part of the Performing Arts + Culture Center.

Thank you for your leadership and commitment to Portland's future.

Best,

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Dacia J. Grayber". The signature is fluid and cursive, with a long horizontal stroke at the end.

Dacia Grayber

State Representative, House District 28 (SW Portland & E Beaverton)

Rep.DaciaGrayber@OregonLegislature.gov

Office Phone: (503) 986-1428

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Chair Pirtle Guiney and City Life Committee Members,

I am a recently retired Intel principal engineer who oversaw seismic design and construction for facilities around the world and a former chair of the Oregon Seismic Safety Commission (OSSPAC). Throughout my career, I helped organizations make long-term infrastructure decisions that balanced safety, risk, and value.

I am writing because seismic safety should remain at the center of the discussion about Keller Auditorium.

The Keller was built in 1917, almost 100 years before modern seismic standards existed. Unreinforced masonry buildings like the Keller are some of the most dangerous buildings in the City's inventory and given that there is a 37 percent chance of a major earthquake on the Cascadia Subduction Zone in the next 50 years, there is no time to lose.

The City has rightly been searching for a long-term solution to these challenges. What concerns me is the recent suggestion that an "affordable fix" is spending \$10-\$15 million on deferred maintenance of the current Keller facility. Maintaining the Keller is important, but maintenance alone does not solve the underlying seismic challenges that have driven this conversation for years. Deferred maintenance is not a seismic retrofit.

At the same time, our region has been presented with a significant opportunity through Portland State University's proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center. The City can be a partner in a purpose-built performing arts complex designed to modern standards and built for the next century.

There are many cultural benefits to this proposal that others are better positioned to discuss. For me, one advantage rises above the rest: it solves the long-term seismic challenge the City has struggled to address for years. It also offers a level of predictability that major renovations rarely can. New construction on a large, unconstrained site provides far greater certainty around costs, schedule, and outcomes than work on a century-old building, where major surprises often emerge only after construction begins.

This is not a choice between maintaining the Keller and building the Center. The Keller can continue serving Portland while the Center is developed and Broadway performances continue uninterrupted. The Keller site's long-term future should be determined through a City-led public process that centers on both civic benefit and seismic concerns.

I urge the Committee to prioritize the safety of Portland residents and support the Performing Arts + Culture Center which will not only create an exceptional cultural asset but will be resilient to future devastating seismic events in our region.

Thank you for your consideration and leadership,

Jeff Soulages

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Julie Vigeland	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Committee Members: I am a South Waterfront resident and a lifelong advocate, patron, volunteer, and supporter of arts and culture in Portland. I wish to thank you for the extraordinary work you have done. The recommendations before you are the result of years of study, public engagement, and thoughtful deliberation. The public conversation has at times been passionate and challenging—as conversations about the future of important cultural institutions often are. Through it all, I appreciate Council's collective commitment to looking beyond individual interests and focusing on what will best serve Portland for generations to come. I have spent much of my life championing and supporting the arts because I believe they are essential to the health of a city. They inspire us, challenge us, enrich our neighborhoods, strengthen our economy, and create the shared experiences that help communities thrive. That is why I am encouraged by such a clear recommendation to move forward with a Performing Arts + Culture Center with a Broadway theater at its heart. What excites me is not simply the prospect of a new venue. It is the opportunity to think more expansively about what arts and culture can mean for future generations: a place that welcomes new audiences, connects students and educators with the performing arts, strengthens artists and arts organizations across our region, and inspires philanthropy. I know from personal experience that donors are drawn to bold visions, strong partnerships, and projects that can make a lasting difference. The Performing Arts + Culture Center is the kind of truly unique opportunity that will bring people together to invest in Portland's future. As someone who has spent decades championing the arts, today I find myself thinking less about what my generation enjoyed and more about what we will leave behind. At some point, every generation becomes a steward rather than a beneficiary. Our responsibility is not only to preserve what we inherited but to widen the circle of opportunity—to create a cultural future that includes more artists, more audiences, and stronger pathways for the small, community-based, and culturally specific organizations that make Portland's arts scene so vibrant and distinctive. I know the Performing Arts + Culture Center can do that. My hope is that future Portlanders will look back and say we had the vision to invest not only in what Portland was, but in what it could become. Thank you for your time and for your service to our city. Julie Vigeland	No	07/28/26 9:43 AM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Carole Morse	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the City Life Committee: I want to thank you for your service to Portland and for the thoughtful work that has gone into this process. The resolution you are now considering reflects years of study, public engagement and careful deliberation – and I am both delighted and encouraged to see such a strong path forward emerging. I am the retired president of the PGE Foundation. In that capacity I had the privilege of helping direct significant investments in arts and culture across our region. That experience taught me that transformative civic projects share one important characteristic: They inspire people to invest. Not just governments. Not just municipalities. Not just philanthropists. Not just corporations. But all of us together. The strongest projects create a sense of shared ownership and shared possibility. That is what I find compelling about the Performing Arts + Culture Center. Even at this very early stage, the project has attracted support from public entities, institutional partners, private developers, and private philanthropy. As someone who has worked closely over decades with donors and corporate leaders, I can tell you that matters profoundly. People invest when they see momentum. They invest when they see credible partnerships. And they invest when they believe a project has the potential to make a lasting difference. This project has that potential. It is an investment not only in a venue, but in artists, students, audiences, economic vitality, and the cultural life of our city. Most cities spend generations working with decisions made long ago. Portland has been given the chance to make a decision that will shape its cultural life for the next century. Those opportunities are rare. They deserve vision, partnership, and leadership. I encourage you to continue moving this conversation forward to the full City Council. Thank you for your service and for your consideration, Carole Morse	No	07/28/26 9:46 AM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
40 Leroy Bynum	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the Committee, As Dean of PSU's extraordinary College of the Arts, I am beyond excited to speak to you about the Performing Arts + Culture Center and, most specifically, the large performance hall, and how it will most assuredly elevate performance experiences in Portland for decades to come. I'm equally excited to share how I envision this project igniting and uniting Portland's arts community. As a performing artist and lifelong lover of the stage, and everything that takes place upon it, the process of developing this proposal has been all about serving and uplifting Portland's entire performing arts ecosystem. At the same time, the arts educator and arts administrator in me is keenly aware of the power of venues like the proposed large performance hall to elevate the arts and the artists while bringing cultural, economic, and social vibrancy to the communities they serve. As part of PSU's action team working on this project, I've had hundreds of animated conversations with arts and culture organizations of all shapes and sizes about their ideas for dream venues. I've heard from patrons of Keller shows, as well as the artists and technicians who make those shows happen. It's been a tremendous learning experience. As an artist myself, there are two certainties I've always known, both of which were affirmed in every conversation I've had: First, artists need venues that allow them to look and sound their best. Second, audiences need to see and hear clearly what is being presented on the stage. That requires the intentional creation of state-of-the-art tunable acoustics and complementary sightlines, achievable with certainty only when a performance hall is built from the ground up with adequate space. PSU excels at training amazing performing artists. Imagine the synergy generated from curated and chance interactions between PSU's stars of tomorrow and music's and theater's stars of today. We are also eager to help build the jobs and talent pipeline for the backstage professionals Portland so desperately needs. Thank you for asking us, three years ago, to offer a proposal to create space for Portland's Broadway theater on campus. Then and now, we remain honored to partner with you in creating a Center for everyone, with exceptional venues, strong educational and cultural connections, and the flexibility to better serve more of the local arts community. I urge you to move this resolution forward and give Portland the opportunity to build the world-class performing arts destination our artists, audiences, students, and communities deserve. Leroy Bynum Dean, PSU College of the Arts	No	07/28/26 9:49 AM
41 Mark Stevenson	Oppose	I am opposed to embarking on expenditures related to a new theater at PSU until a fully vetted budget is completed. I understand that no such budget is in place for the PSU theater project. I was CEO for 10 years of Portland-based Capital Pacific Bank (a Certified B-Corp) and 7 years as CFO for Craft3, the nonprofit CDFI providing capital to small businesses and individuals lacking access to traditional capital. In banking and at Craft3, it would be unacceptable and unheard of to commit and allocate funds towards a capital or construction project without first having a complete and vetted budget in place. Bank regulators would severely criticize any such action as it irresponsibly puts the institution at high risk as there is no identification of how increased costs would be financed nor of whether or not the project will be economically viable. I can't speak to how City Council would feel in answering to voters, but I know that I would never want to be in a position of having to advise a bank regulator or my board of directors that my institution had been so irresponsible.	No	07/28/26 9:57 AM
42 Josh Hecht, Profile Theatre	Support		Yes	07/28/26 10:11 AM



July 28, 2026

Good afternoon, Council-members. My name is Josh Hecht. I'm the Artistic Director of Profile Theatre, which, at 29 years old, is one of the longest-running theaters in the state of Oregon and a cultural anchor in Portland's theater community.

I cannot tell you how excited I am at the prospect of the Performing Arts + Culture Center at PSU. Three things that excite me:

First: Embedding Portland's Broadway-capable venue within the region's public university dramatically expands its civic and cultural impact. Placing a major cultural asset at the heart of a university with a profoundly diverse student body, including a high percentage of first-gen college matriculants, creates opportunities for students, artists and indeed the city that is unique in the country.

Second: As a director and producer working across the country, I have seen firsthand how powerful the relationship between universities and major arts organizations can be, creating opportunities for collaboration, resource-sharing and education that neither can do alone. That's what I see in this proposal, which will elevate both PSU, attracting students *and faculty* from across the country, and Portland's arts ecosystem with a state-of-the-art, multi-stage, world-class venue.

At Profile, we don't just produce plays. We bring Tony Award, Pulitzer, and Obie winning playwrights to Portland to develop and premiere new work with local artists. A world-class facility like the one proposed by PSU would enhance our ability to attract world-class artists, while creating more opportunities for Portland-based performers, designers, technicians, and arts organizations.

Third: Third, I'm especially encouraged by what this means for the next generation. Profile is partnering with PSU to develop a two-year post-bacc Certificate Program in Theatre Design and Production that will help train emerging technical talent right here in Portland. The Center would create a direct connection between education and practice, strengthening the workforce that arts organizations throughout our region depend on.

This project is about more than a theater. It's about what becomes possible when Broadway, higher education, and Portland's arts community are all connected in one place, providing extraordinary opportunities for artists, arts organizations, arts lovers, and most of all students— the artists and patrons of tomorrow. And I am convinced that a project of this scope will only elevate Portland's reputation as a major center for the arts in this country.

Thank you,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Josh Hecht".

Josh Hecht
Artistic Director

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Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Max Herrera - PSUF	Support	Hello, my name is Maximus Herrera, and I am a proud supporter of the development of the Performing Arts and Culture Center at PSU. I currently serve as the Alumni and Community Engagement Coordinator at the Portland State University Foundation, but my strong support for the PACC goes far beyond my role or title here at PSUF. To begin, this project will not only be an economic driver for downtown Portland and Portland State University, it will also show Portland's commitment to investing in theater, the creative arts, and our own downtown revitalization. This project would mean creating more classrooms, rehearsal spaces, and performance venues for Portland State, as well as a Broadway capable auditorium for touring productions and audiences to enjoy. It would mean creating an accessible, multimodal venue that would give everyone more reason to come visit and enjoy what downtown Portland has to offer. My attachment to this project is rooted in my own appreciation and understanding of how important theater and the arts are to any community, given my participation in theater from a young age. It's also rooted in my firm belief that we can build a better Portland if we invest in what already makes us great: namely our creative ingenuity and spirit. But at the end of the day, the ability to manifest this project into reality rests in your hands, and I humbly implore you to consider the value in bringing this project to life... not only for PSU, but for the greater Portland Metro region. It would be an economic driver for downtown, a significant investment in the arts and culture community, and a boon to PSU and all the students it serves in the region. Thank you, and please vote yes on the development of this new project.	No	07/28/26 10:57 AM
Christine and David Vernier	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the City Life Committee: As co-founders of Vernier Science Education and long-time supporters of education and the arts, David and I are writing to strongly support this Committee advancing the resolution to relocate Portland's Broadway theater to the dynamic Performing Arts + Culture Center complex proposed by Portland State. We appreciate the thoughtful work of this committee, City Council, and City staff in evaluating this unique opportunity. Projects of this scale require rigorous study, broad public engagement, and sustained collaboration. We are particularly encouraged that after years of review, all City-initiated studies and advisory groups endorse this direction. As people who value sound civic process, we believe that work matters and should not be set aside. We think this proposal represents far more than a new home for our region's Broadway theater. At a time when Portland is working to revitalize downtown, the Performing Arts + Culture Center offers a catalytic opportunity to support artists, students and the entire arts ecosystem; to spark economic and cultural activity; and to bring new energy to the urban core long into the future. Future-forward projects of this scope require philanthropic and private investors to stand alongside public agencies. In our experience, investment follows vision, momentum, and civic commitment. City Council's public commitment is necessary to provide the clarity needed to attract additional philanthropic and community support. Finally, we believe that Portland State, as downtown's public university, is uniquely positioned to partner with the City to make this vision a reality. PSU brings to the table demonstrated expertise in planning and capital development, a large plot of no-cost land, millions in state and private funding already secured, and expertise in workforce development and fund-raising. We are fortunate that PSU is willing to place those assets in service to our city's shared future. We encourage you to advance this resolution to the full City Council. Thank you for your commitment and leadership. Sincerely, Christine and David Vernier Co-founders, Vernier Science Education	No	07/28/26 11:06 AM
Cynthia Carmina Gomez	Support		Yes	07/28/26 11:20 AM

44

45



**Written Testimony in Support of the Performing Arts
+ Culture Center**
July 28, 2026

Council President and Members of the Council,

I write in strong support of the Performing Arts + Culture Center proposed for Portland State University's campus.

I know firsthand what Portland's performing arts community can produce when given even modest support. I co-wrote *Voz Alta: Generaciones* with Joaquin Lopez, the City of Portland's Creative Laureate. The play dramatizes the lives of two Latino artists, Rodolfo

Serna and Jesus Torralba, whose own healing through art now shapes the mentorship work they do with at-risk youth across Multnomah and Washington counties. We staged the production at both Miracle Theatre and Portland State, and that partnership between a professional Latino theater company and a public university campus is exactly the kind of model PSU's project would make routine instead of rare.

Students attended a panel discussion at PSU with the artists themselves. They sat with a military veteran turned youth mentor, a director working from a queer-identified activist space, and the city's Creative Laureate, and came away with a real, human sense of what a life in the arts looks like. That's the kind of experience PSU's PA+CC would offer as a matter of course, not a special occasion.

By putting students at the center of a working performing arts venue, this project builds a direct bridge from the classroom into the profession. Students would get paid work, technical training, and mentorship alongside touring productions and working artists, the kind of experience no classroom can fully replicate on its own.

But this isn't only about arts students. The stories we tell, and the partnerships that make them possible, teach and move everyone they reach. Bringing a professional theater company onto a public campus, and bringing students into a room with working artists, is cross-boundary work. It makes us better neighbors and better listeners. It makes us a better Portland.

Portland's performing arts community is resilient. But resilience isn't the same thing as sustainability. PSU's PA+CC project is an investment in the infrastructure and the people that keep this city's cultural life alive.

I respectfully urge the Council's support.

Attentamente,
Cynthia Carmina Gómez

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
46	Portland Historic Landmarks Commission	Oppose	See attached letter from the Portland Historic Landmarks Commission in support of renovating the Keller Auditorium.	Yes	07/28/26 12:10 PM
47	Daniel Pollack-Pelzner	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney and Members of the Committee on City Life: For the record, my name is Daniel Pollack-Pelzner. I am testifying in support of the resolution to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center at Portland State University. I was born and raised in Portland. After graduate school, my wife and I returned to Portland because we wanted to raise our children here. I have fond memories of my parents taking me to shows at the Civic Auditorium. Now they take their grandkids to Broadway shows for their birthday. It's a tradition we all love. But the reason I really love Portland is not because of a building. It's because of a community. It's because we have the shared imagination to support an entire ecosystem that blossoms from the performing arts. I teach theater at Portland State. My kids take classes at Oregon Children's Theater and Northwest Children's Theater. My mom sings in a community choir that rehearses in PSU's Cramer Hall. My father is an artist who shows his paintings and teaches across town. I work with arts organizations around the city like Profile Theater, Artists Repertory Theater, and Portland Experimental Theater Ensemble. I know that's true for many of us in this room. We want the whole ecology of the arts to thrive. That's why I support this resolution. I write about the performing arts across the country for publications like The New York Times and The New Yorker. The arts centers that transform an entire city are the ones that are built on partnerships. They're not stand-alone structures. They are collaborations between universities, nonprofit arts organizations, commercial theater, private philanthropy, business groups, and government bodies. That's what galvanizes a community. And that's what can change the story. We need a new story for our city. For the last few years, when editors ask me for a Portland arts story, there's one question they're always posing: What went wrong? But this is a chance—maybe a once-in-a-generation chance—to flip that question. If we move forward with a center that lifts up students, that lifts up local organizations, that lifts up arts education, and that joins the power of Portland with the thrill of Broadway, our grandkids can tell the story of what went right. Thank you for your service to our city. I hope you will support this resolution to advance the new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center at Portland State.	No	07/28/26 12:29 PM
48	Amanda Gabriel-Landis	Support	I strongly support the resolution to move forward with a new city-owned Broadway-capable venue as part of the Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. I believe in the future of Portland. Investing in a large-scale theater as part of the PACC complex is an investment in our city's long-term vitality. This project can strengthen our entire arts ecosystem, attract world-class performances, create opportunities for students and artists, and establish downtown Portland as a premier destination for arts, entertainment and education in the Pacific Northwest. This is the right move for our arts community, for workers, for local businesses and for the continued revitalization of downtown Portland. I encourage the committee to support this resolution and help move this transformational project forward.	No	07/28/26 12:31 PM
49	Sarah Schwarz, Portland State University Foundation	Support		Yes	07/28/26 12:36 PM



City of Portland
Historic Landmarks Commission

1900 SW Fourth Ave., Suite 5000
Portland, Oregon 97201
Phone: (503) 823-7300
TTY: 711
www.portland.gov/ppd/landmarks

Date: July 27, 2026
To: City Council City Life Committee
From: Historic Landmarks Commission
Re: City Council City Life Committee 7/28/26 Agenda
Document Numbers 2026-269 and 2026-270

The Historic Landmarks Commission **urges the renovation of the Keller Auditorium to support a large-scale performing arts venue.** Reuse of this important building, which is eligible for the National Register for Historic Places, will:

- Create a cultural destination in the heart of downtown that connects with and revitalizes the adjacent Keller Fountain, a contributing and significant resource within the Halprin Open Space Sequence Historic District.
- Practice sustainability by saving tons of carbon emissions and limiting landfill waste.
- Leverage existing infrastructure.
- Support existing businesses.

Sincerely,

The following Members of the Historic Landmarks Commission

Peggy Moretti (Chair)
Hugo Agosto (Vice Chair)
Susie Trexler
Cleo Davis
Hannah Bronfman
Jonah Jensen

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PSU
Foundation
PORTLAND STATE UNIVERSITY

P.O. BOX 243
PORTLAND, OR 97207
1600 SW 4TH AVE, STE 730
PORTLAND, OR 97201

psuf.org
503-725-4478

July 28, 2026

Dear Chair Pirtle-Guiney and City Life Committee Members,

Three years ago, the City of Portland invited Portland State University to explore what a Broadway-capable theater at PSU might make possible for our city. We embraced that opportunity because we believed PSU was uniquely positioned to help advance a project that could serve Portland and Portland State far into the future.

What emerged was a bold vision about our broader arts, culture and education ecosystem. We envision a place where arts, education, community, and economic activity come together in ways that can strengthen the city. In continuing to refine this vision, we have learned from artists, arts organizations, Broadway presenters, business leaders, students, educators, public officials, donors and many others who care deeply about the arts and our city.

The potential of a Performing Arts + Culture Center lies in its ability to bring together arts, education, workforce development, and economic activity in one place. Located on the PSU campus, it will connect students to hands-on learning and pathways into Portland's creative workforce. It will support artists and arts organizations large and small, attract audiences and visitors downtown, strengthen local businesses, and generate significant cultural and economic activity for our region.

From the beginning we have approached this work as a committed City partner — contributing resources, relationships, and institutional capacity to advance the work, while helping engage stakeholders, explore development opportunities, and cultivate philanthropic and private-sector interest. Meanwhile, City Council has commissioned meaningful studies and convened two independent advisory groups that have both recommended moving forward with the Center.

As president of the PSU Foundation, I know that transformational civic projects require broad partnerships. Continued engagement and a clear commitment to build the City-owned Broadway theater at PSU will help unlock significant new support and create confidence for the coalition assembling around this effort.

Portland State is a solutions-oriented partner. We stand ready to help develop the comprehensive funding strategy and philanthropy needed to advance a future-forward Broadway theater on our downtown campus.

Sincerely,

Sarah Schwarz
President, PSU Foundation

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
50	Gemanereida Barragan Cruz	Support	Chair Pirtle-Guiney, Vice Chair Zimmerman, and Members of the Committee, My name is Gemanereida Barragan Cruz and I am a PSU student and a singer here in support of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University I am entering my third year at PSU, studying Music Education with an emphasis in voice and perform as a mariachi singer across Oregon. Music isn't just my major; it is my life's work. Singing mariachi allows me to keep my cultural traditions alive and share my heart directly with our community, while my studies at PSU are preparing me to guide our next generations. As a music student at PSU, I see firsthand how desperately our performing arts programs need modern, functional space. Right now, students are constantly competing for limited, outdated practice space. As a member of the chamber choir, we practice in a classroom in the same building as the geology and history departments. The Jazz Choir practices in a stairwell in Lincoln Hall. Our students deserve better. This project promises a direct bridge to the professional world. Training alongside touring productions and industry professionals gives student artists, technicians, and musicians invaluable real-world experience, mentorship, and networking opportunities outside our classrooms. I urge the city to support the new Broadway-capable venue at PSU. This commitment from the city will be a generational moment for our region, our community, our programs, and our students. Mil gracias.	No	07/28/26 12:38 PM
51	Cate Soulages	Support	I am writing today in strong support of continued exploration of the Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. My family moved to Portland from California because of this city's extraordinary creative culture. We were drawn by Portland's artists, theaters, musicians, and the belief that arts and culture are not an amenity here—they are part of the city's identity. That is why I have been so pleased about the potential development of a Performing Arts + Culture Center on the PSU campus. A true arts and culture center with a Broadway theater at its core, surrounded by smaller theaters, classrooms and community gathering spaces, has enormous potential to strengthen the many arts groups that have been struggling in recent years, support emerging artists, attract visitors, and create new opportunities for students across our region. As a parent of an artsy child, I am especially delighted that this vision gives Portland a way to continue Broadway programming uninterrupted while creating new possibilities for young people. I'm very excited that students of all ages will have opportunities to learn, perform, compete, create, and connect with arts and cultural experiences that may help shape their futures. Like many families, we look forward to bringing friends and relatives downtown to see blockbuster shows – and to watch our children in recitals, competitions, performances, and plays. The Performing Arts + Culture Center offers the possibility of creating a place where those moments can happen while strengthening the city we all love. I also appreciate that this proposal is rooted in partnership. City Council and Portland State have committed years of work, planning, and resources to exploring what is possible, and I believe the City should continue that conversation. Your diligence is commendable. Keep going! Cate Soulages	No	07/28/26 1:01 PM
52	Broadway Across America	Support		Yes	07/28/26 2:46 PM



July 28, 2026

Portland City Council
City Life Committee
Document Number: 2026-270

Chair Pirtle-Guiney, Vice-Chair Zimmerman, and Councilors Avalos, Morillo, and Ryan,

On behalf of Broadway Across America/Broadway in Portland, I am writing in support of the proposed 3,200-seat Performing Arts & Culture Center (PACC) at Portland State University (PSU) and of a process to begin planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium.

As the presenter of Broadway shows in Portland for 30 years, and a leader in the performing arts industry, with experience as a theater operator and/or presenter in more than 45 markets across the country, we know how the arts can transform downtowns and the lives of individuals. Portland has a unique opportunity with this new theater, as only a few new venues of the scale and scope proposed by PSU have been developed in the U.S. over the last decade. A performing arts center of this kind will not only give Portland a competitive advantage among its West Coast peers, making it a highly desirable stop for major touring shows, but it will also be a catalyst to increase visits to downtown Portland. This will create demand for more jobs and activate local and downtown businesses, delivering a direct public benefit through job creation and local tax revenue, and solidify the city's identity as a center for a creative economy.

Portland ranks among our top markets for subscriber base and is among the highest markets for subscriber retention, which helps drive sold-out performances. The expanded seating capacity in the PACC will allow for more ticket availability at a broader range of price points, creating more affordable access. The PACC will not only increase exposure to the arts but will also provide a safe, state-of-the-art workplace for the touring and local skilled workforce we employ to present our shows.

Lastly, I want to clarify that our support for the PSU theater is not in opposition to the Keller remaining a central part of Portland's arts ecosystem. We have presented at the Keller for 30 years and appreciate its significance to downtown culture and the economy. Through our active participation in the operations workgroup and the mayor's advisory group, and by serving as a resource for the steering committee and the Hunden Group, we have

always been, and remain, supportive of a broader vision for an arts district that includes the Keller.

However, programming continuity is essential to preserving the benefits of live performing arts as an economic and cultural asset for the city. Without an alternative venue for large-scale performances, closing the Keller for renovations could have a long-lasting, negative impact on downtown recovery. This joint project between the City and PSU would allow large events, such as Broadway shows, to continue at the Keller until the PACC opens, protecting jobs and economic activity downtown. Furthermore, once the new venue is operational, the City can strengthen downtown by addressing the unmet market needs identified by the user groups - including renovating the Keller into a 1200-seat to 1800-seat venue on the current site with increased lobby and rehearsal space and other audience amenities for a modern facility.

The Portland Open Space Sequence connects the two proposed venues. Imagine how that area of downtown could become alive with restaurants and bars.

We are excited about the future of this city and the opportunity these projects have to fuel a vibrant, active downtown culture and economy. We have been a partner for 30 years and hope to remain one for many years to come, helping carry out this vision for future generations. Please contact us if we can be helpful.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Rich Jaffe', with a stylized, cursive script.

Rich Jaffe

CEO, Broadway Across America

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
53 Katie Quick	Support	Dear Chair Pirtle-Guiney, Vice-Chair Zimmerman, and Members of the Committee, My name is Katie Quick, and I am a proud alumna of Portland State University. I am writing today in support of the resolution to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. I was a student at PSU from 2010 through 2014, and my focus wasn't music or the performing arts. But it's almost impossible to be a PSU student and not know about or be proud of musical and performing artists coming out of the university. For example, PSU has carried the legacy of the amazing Chamber Choir for several decades, winning recognition from around the world for musical excellence and artistry. I've been involved on the alumni side of PSU for the past 12 years; PSU's performing arts are always highly touted, and are a huge way that the university contributes to "Let Knowledge Serve the City." While my own background and career path lie outside the arts, my time at PSU taught me that a university's impact extends far beyond its specific degree programs. A thriving university requires a vibrant campus environment—one that attracts talent, fosters interdisciplinary collaboration, and serves as an economic and cultural engine for the surrounding city. A world-class, Broadway-capable venue on campus deeply enriches the daily university experience for all students, regardless of their field of study. As an urban university, PSU thrives when campus life is dynamic and active. Having a state-of-the-art facility in the heart of campus gives students access to premier cultural events, high-profile speakers, and national touring productions right at their doorstep. Prioritizing the collaboration of the Performing Arts Center with Portland State University will bring the best opportunities and innovation to our city, while growing our local communities, businesses, and artists. Supporting this Broadway-capable venue at PSU is a transformative, generational decision for our region, our community, and future students. I strongly urge you to pass this resolution and invest in this pivotal moment for Portland State University. Thank you for your time and leadership. Katie Quick	No	07/28/26 3:51 PM
54 Crystal Froembling	Support	Councilors, Every day that goes by without a vision for downtown Portland is a day that we have lost. I write to you in support of the agenda item to advance the PSU plan for the Performing Arts and Culture Center. As a lifelong Portlander, and a lover of the arts, we are far past due on investing in the cultural life of our region. Portland is special because of our values, and this project brings our best opportunities for revitalization to the table. While PSU might be a surprising partner, this is an example of innovative leadership and partnership. PSU has always been a part of the city, now is no different. As the largest holder of real estate in downtown Portland, and an institution that fosters creativity, engagement, and community - what better partner could be found? As a first-gen graduate of PSU with a Masters in Public Administration, I am part of the community of alumni of PSU that bring more diversity to the arts. I bring my civic values as well and ask that you do the right thing, not the easy thing. I have listened to testimony and process along the way, and admittedly, I had doubts as we faced severe budget impact over the last year. (Let us not forget these are entirely different sources of funding than what is needed to prevent staff and faculty layoffs. This is an opportunity to diversify and bring NEW money into collaborative partnership.) This project is an opportunity to build a future downtown Portland that is vibrant and full of life. Not just a re-creation of the past. My wife and I have been season ticket holders of Portland Opera in the past. The physical logistics of seeing a show at Keller have become nearly impossible to navigate as she lives with physical disabilities that make things like access to a bathroom a critical part of the experience. I'm personally tired of the mediocrity. I believe we can build a better future for both the PACC, and the Keller, but we can't hold back progress in the name of nostalgia. Thank you for your consideration. I know this will be a difficult decision for Councilors, and an emotional one for the ardent supporters of the Keller. Please make the right decision and move the PACC plan forward as quickly as possible, so we can get to work. Respectfully, Crystal Froembling, District 2 Constituent	No	07/29/26 10:38 AM

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
55	Helprin Landscape Conservancy and the Downtown Neighborhood Association	Oppose		Yes	08/07/26 10:12 AM
56	ramin farahmandpur	Oppose		Yes	08/10/26 10:09 AM
57	Mike Lindberg	Oppose	I am having challenges including my testimony . Can I submit it to you by e mail ? Mike	No	08/10/26 10:18 AM
58	Cynthia Hampton, Advisory Council for preservation of the Keller	Oppose	Please do NOT move forward with the PSU initiative. This is an educational institution, not a business entity. It is struggling at that, having laid off 52 people last month and dissolving some departments. The should be using any funds they have accrued for much needed improvements to their campus. Our existing hotels are too empty. There is no public transportation there. PSU is not downtown. Their project is \$200M more than the proposal to develop the Keller into a world class venue. Our city is now \$170M in the hole. The Keller provides Broadway income annually. With \$10 - 15M the Keller can be appropriately upgraded without closure. Thank you, Cynthia Hampton	No	08/10/26 2:33 PM
59	Terry Goldman	Oppose	Dear Members of the City Council, I am writing as the General Manager of The Porter Hotel to express my strong opposition to Portland State University's \$44 million funding request for a new venue and to advocate for the direct restoration and preservation of our historic Keller Auditorium. As detailed in a recent Oregon ArtsWatch article, Portland is already burdened with \$336 million in deferred maintenance across its existing Portland's Centers for the Performing Arts. Committing \$44 million to help spark a massive \$449 million new build is fiscally reckless when the city cannot afford its current infrastructure liabilities. Prioritizing renovations for the Keller Auditorium is a far more responsible choice for our city and local economy: Supporting Nearby Hospitality and Businesses: The 3,000-seat Keller Auditorium is a vital economic engine for neighboring hotels like ours, local restaurants, and retail shops. Major Broadway musical tours, the Oregon Ballet Theatre, and marquee cultural events generate a steady stream of patrons who stay, dine, and spend in downtown Portland. Abandoning or downsizing the Keller threatens the livelihoods of hospitality workers and small business owners who depend on this visitor traffic. Loss of City Lodging Tax Revenue: The thousands of overnight visitors drawn to downtown Portland by the Keller's high-capacity events generate essential Transient Lodging Tax (TLT) revenues for the City and County. Closing or downsizing the facility directly degrades hotel occupancy, stripping municipal coffers of critical tax dollars needed to fund municipal services, travel promotion, and regional recovery efforts. Fiscal Responsibility: Rather than committing tens or hundreds of millions in tax dollars toward a redundant new facility, the city can secure the Keller's future with a far more sensible investment of \$5 million to \$15 million in safety and amenity upgrades over the next five years. Protecting a Civic Landmark: The Keller has a proven track record as a high-volume, revenue-generating cultural hub. Upgrading the existing facility honors that legacy without saddling city taxpayers with unmanageable debt. I urge the City Council to exercise fiscal stewardship, protect municipal tax revenues and local downtown businesses, and fund the necessary upgrades to the Keller Auditorium. Sincerely, Terry Goldman General Manager, The Porter Hotel 1355 SW Second Ave Portland, OR 97201	No	08/10/26 2:42 PM
60	John Russell	Oppose	Surely the City Life Committee can't support a development at the farthest edge of the Central City, as opposed to supporting the Keller Auditorium that is surrounded by existing hotels, restaurants, abundant parking and significant residences, all within a block or two.	No	08/10/26 3:46 PM



August 4, 2026

City Life Committee
Portland City Council
City Hall
1221 SW 4th Ave
Suite 340
Portland, OR 97205

Dear Members of City Life Committee:

Thank you for the opportunity during last week's City Life Committee meeting to share our opposition to the resolution advancing the plan for two new city financed theaters in partnership with Portland State University, including a new 3000-seat Broadway theater, and renovating the Keller Auditorium into a smaller 1,200 to 1,800 seat theater. Taken together, the estimated price tag for this proposal is nearly \$1 billion dollars.

We urge you to oppose this plan for the following reasons. First, the city cannot afford, and has no clear plan, to fund any of this. Second, no studies exist that demonstrate a market need or demand for smaller renovated Keller theater nor a smaller theater at PSU. Third, the current resolution contains no guarantees that the promised Keller renovation will proceed in tandem with planning and funding for the new Broadway theater at PSU. Four, this plan commits taxpayers to fund three *new* theaters while ignoring the deferred maintenance needs of the Arlene Schnitzer Concert Hall and Hatfield Hall. Five, this plan fails to consider the market impacts on all city-owned venues by the arrival of two new private concert venues currently under construction.

Simply put, this proposal is too expensive, too financially risky and lacks adequate market analysis to justify the need to build multiple new venues (when current venues are already underutilized) and the extraordinary cost to Portland taxpayers during a city affordability crisis.

In addition to our July 28 testimony, we want to further emphasize two points prior to the scheduled August 11 committee action on the proposed resolution.

First, PSU is now hoping to attach a \$44 million dollar to this resolution with payment due on December 1. Supporting this resolution is not free. It puts the wheels in motion to spend nearly \$1 billion dollars, with the first payment due in a matter of months. This initial

\$44 million funding request from PSU is part of an ongoing lobbying and fundraising shell game and not a responsible public infrastructure financing plan. It is not the city council's responsibility to provide a \$44 million key to PSU to "unlock" state-bonding to pay for parking garages and classrooms. It may be politically expedient, but it is not fiscally responsible for the city to begin incrementally funding the multiple theater projects envisioned in this resolution.

Second, despite promises not to abandon the Keller, this resolution contains no guarantees to renovate the Keller. While we strongly oppose this proposal, if the city council decides to support it, the resolution must be amended to ensure that planning and funding for Keller renovations proceeds in tandem with a new Broadway theater at PSU, even with the knowledge that construction timelines will differ. To do otherwise, is to subject the Keller to the eventual wrecking ball. For example, if council proceeds with an initial \$44 million appropriation for the first phase of work on the PSU project, 50% should be dedicated to funding similar work for the Keller.

To that end, we proposed the resolution be amended to include the following requirements:

1. Planning work associated with renovating the Keller into smaller theater must occur simultaneously with planning work for the new theater near PSU.
2. A public oversight and advisory committee should immediately be created for the Keller project, similar to what is envisioned for the PSU project.
3. The City must appropriate funding for developing the Keller into a smaller theater venue concurrent with any funding for the new Broadway theater. Part of any funding package should also include dedicated dollars to once and for all properly and professionally study the feasibility of a temporary venue for Broadway shows in the event that the ultimate decision is to maintain and renovate the Keller for Broadway shows.
4. If and when the city and PSU seek funding sources for the new Broadway theater, those efforts must also include funding for renovation of the Keller into a smaller theater. This includes money sought from the city council, the state legislature, Metro, the federal government, and voters.

Councilor Clark has drafted an amendment to address these items. If the resolution is to move forward, we urge you to adopt that amendment prior to passage.

We understand that there is bureaucratic inertia driving this resolution forward. We understand legitimate concerns over the economic impacts of a pro-longed closure of the Keller for full-scale renovation, which is why we have suggested an affordable alternative.

We understand that PSU has received state bonding commitments contingent on securing city and private funding. We understand Keller is aging and needs repairs but also know the Keller is profitable and has recently signed a multi-year contract for Broadway shows to

continue performing through 2033. And we understand that elected officials are reticent to say no to competing constituencies. But none of these, either individually or collectively, are reasons for the City of Portland to commit itself to nearly \$1 billion in capital spending and/or risk abandoning the Keller Auditorium and the downtown neighborhood that was planned and has grown up around its signature fountain. This proposal is a well-crafted mistake.

On behalf of the majority of Portlanders who want to see the Keller renovated and the thousands of people who have sent emails to your offices in the past few weeks, we urge you to oppose this resolution and, should it proceed, make the amendments we have recommended.

Thank you.

Karen Whitman, Executive Director, Halprin Landscape Conservancy
LaJune Thorson, President, Downtown Neighborhood Association

Page intentionally blank to separate written testimony attachments

August 11, 2026

To: Portland City Council, City Life Committee

Re: Agenda Item 2026-270 — Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts; proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University and the future of the Keller Auditorium

Position: Oppose

Members of the Committee:

My name is Ramin Farahmandpur. I am a professor at Portland State University, and I write to oppose Agenda Item 2026-270.

This resolution would commit the City to a project it cannot yet afford. The Council is being asked to approve \$44 million by December 1 toward a city-owned venue estimated to cost as much as \$449 million, with no funding source identified. Portland State's state bonds fund the University's theater, academic space, and parking. None of that money can be used for the city-owned venue. The \$44 million—and the far larger sum behind it—would be the City's obligation.

The City's own studies project new spending, jobs, and lodging tax revenue. But those figures measure gross activity, not whether the City would recover what it spends. They also compare a new venue with a renovated Keller Auditorium rather than show that the City can afford either option. The City's own feasibility study found no market for two large halls, yet this resolution would build a second one while the Keller still stands. The popularity of touring Broadway is not in dispute; it shows the region needs one working large venue, not a second, and the Keller hosts those shows today.

Those projections also assume a downtown that can reliably fill seats. The evidence points in the opposite direction. Downtown office vacancy stood at 36.5 percent this spring, more than triple its level at the end of 2019. Oregon now closes more businesses than it opens, for the first time since the Great Recession, and the state forecasts slower growth and a nearly flat population through 2035. Higher-earning households are leaving Multnomah County for Clark County, Washington, which has no income tax, weakening the tax base that supports the region's hospitals, schools, and transit. A projection of new activity does not tell the Council whether a shrinking economy can carry new debt.

Across Portland, private developers are unwilling to build even on prime land at the Broadway Corridor, the Lloyd Center, and the OMSI district, and the projects that move at all now depend on public subsidy. A new performing arts venue faces the same market, and the City's \$44 million would not unlock private investment so much as replace it.

The City has just closed a record general-fund shortfall of \$170 million for the 2026–27 fiscal year. The University has pursued a major building project while declaring a fiscal emergency, and now asks the Council to take on a similar risk at even greater cost. A less costly path exists: redirect the University's state bonds to the academic hall and classroom renovations its own programs require, and fund the estimated \$236 million renovation of the Keller Auditorium, which the city already owns.

Before it commits the City to \$44 million, the Council should identify the actual funding source and ask whether that money is better spent on the services residents depend on.

Respectfully,

Ramin Farahmandpur, Ph.D.

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
61	Bill Foster	Oppose	Sometimes, one thing at a time makes sense. Until MODA funding is resolved, as well as a plan for hundreds of millions the city has in obligations for deferred maintenance and other capital projects, it is unrealistic - if not reckless - to fully fund or renovate a new performing arts facility, or to commit to such a path. Given The city's current financial challenges it's time for caution. To the immediate Keller question- which the city owns and is a NET PROFIT CENTER - the reasonable course of action is to invest modestly in capital upgrades over the next five-six years, keep the show running, and waiting for better days. Besides the wisdom of fiscal responsibility, the TRUE costs of fully remodeling the Keller , or building an entirely facility, appear to be guesstimates based on drawings with no hard numbers or the many costs that may arise from changing streets, streetcar routes and a host of other unexamined issues. So, tap the brakes. In a time of diminishing city/county services citizens will applaud a first-things-first approach.	No	08/10/26 4:51 PM
62	Stephen Brooks	Oppose	The proposal (Item 2026-270) for developing a performing arts center at PSU is not a good idea, for several reasons. First, PSU has no demonstrated experience managing large scale entertainment venues. Second, there is no way the current estimated budget is accurate; city council should assume that PSU is underestimating the actual cost by a minimum of 40%. Third, the city will be creating a dead zone around the Keller. Fourth, PSU is not in a good economic state, and it's generally difficult for large institutions to efficiently take on entirely new roles. A conceivable scenario is that (1) the final project exceeds the "projected" budget by a significant amount; (2) PSU struggles to manage the facilities properly, and loses money (requiring subsidies); and (3) meanwhile the city is forced to spend significant money doing triage, cleanup and rehab in the "entertainment district" in the city. City council should not move forward with the PSU option until, AT A MINIMUM, it has identified a real strategy for rebuilding the area around the Keller - it will be a huge burden on the City.	No	08/10/26 4:56 PM
63	Kate Dickson			Yes	08/10/26 5:39 PM
64	Mike Lindberg, Keller Advisory Committee	Oppose	Dear Mayor and members of the Civic Life Committee, I am asking that you take a moment to become familiar with the history surrounding the current dilemma about which performing arts project to support. I suggest this as a member of the Keller Advisory Committee. In 2018 there was an International Design Competition for the next version of the Keller. It was won by Stufish Entertainment Architects of London and Michael Curry (who does work for the Walt Disney Corporation Entertainment Facilities). Context – When the Keller Fountain first opened, Ada Louise Huxtable of the New York Times wrote that it “may be one of the most important urban spaces since the Renaissance.” The Keller is not in a dead district. Thousands of people live nearby. Tens of millions of public and private dollars have been invested in Parks, hotels, restaurants, housing, parking and offices. The “Fountain District” is alive and well, even more so with a street closure between the Keller and the fountain with programmable activities similar to those at Pioneer Courthouse Square. The project resulting from the design competition solves problems expressed by patrons, producers and employees. With multiple new food and beverage outlets, improved restrooms, and accessibility, plus a new auditorium with improved sightlines and acoustics, the Keller will be a state-of-the-art facility. The estimated costs are \$267 million, maybe even half the cost of constructing a new facility. Further efforts were made to phase the construction process to address the issue of disruptions to the event schedule and the loss of jobs. The previous City Council enthusiastically embraced the renovated Keller until some staff members several levels down advocated for a competition among several developers like OMSI, the Lloyd Center, and PSU. This group of staff have strongly advocated for PSU, even if funds for construction are not available or identified. As a former city commissioner in charge of arts facilities and as the former Director of Planning and Development for the city, I strenuously object to what is, in effect, abandoning the Keller and the Fountain District. I ask the City Council to revisit the plan for the Keller not only for the arts community and members of the Fountain District, but also for the entire city of Portland. Sincerely, Mike Lindberg Former City Commissioner	No	08/10/26 5:51 PM
65	Richard Toscan	Oppose	I would urge Council to avoid rushing into the PSU Broadway proposal, fraught as it is with numerous financial mine fields in adding to a very poor location in terms of parking logistics for a 3000 seat house with overlapping programming at the adjacent 1200-seat venue. I say this as a past Advisory Board member of what was then called the Portland Center for the Performing Arts incorporating the Keller and the South Park Blocks theatres.	No	08/10/26 6:19 PM

Invest in the Keller Auditorium and the Revitalization of Downtown Portland

Dear Mayor Wilson and City Councilors,

As Portland's leaders and residents work together to **revitalize our beloved city**, we must look carefully at investments that can accomplish several important goals at the same time.

Renovating the Keller Auditorium is exactly that kind of investment.

The Keller is a key Portland asset and an integral part of Portland's downtown arts and cultural hub and an important contributor to the economic and civic vitality of our central city.

Its location matters.

The Keller is within easy reach of Portland's performing arts venues, the Portland Art Museum, the Oregon Historical Society, City Hall, Waterfront Park, Pioneer Place, Pioneer Courthouse Square, hotels, restaurants, and numerous small and large businesses. Together, these institutions and businesses create a cultural and economic ecosystem that cannot simply be recreated by constructing a new auditorium elsewhere.

The Keller brings people downtown. Those visitors don't just attend a performance. They eat in our restaurants, stay in our hotels, shop in our businesses, walk our streets, use our public spaces, and contribute to the energy and vitality that Portland is working so hard to restore.

This is why City leaders must prioritize **renovating and modernizing the Keller Auditorium rather than investing additional public resources in the development of a new auditorium at Portland State University.**

Portland has an extraordinary civic asset in the Keller. Our challenge should be to preserve it, improve it, and ensure that it can serve Portland for generations to come.

There is also tremendous value in preserving the relationship between the Keller Auditorium and the nationally recognized Keller Fountain. Together they represent an important part of Portland's architectural, cultural, and civic history.

Of course, renovation must address the Keller's significant needs. We should create a **modern, safe, accessible, seismically resilient, and welcoming performing arts venue** that can accommodate today's productions and audiences. We should also ensure that the renovated Keller serves the entire community through a diverse, equitable, and inclusive lens.

At a time when Portland is searching for effective ways to bring people back downtown, support local businesses, strengthen our arts community, and restore confidence in our central city, why would we walk away from an established cultural anchor when we have the opportunity to reinvest in it?

Public dollars are limited. We should invest them where they can provide the broadest community benefit.

Renovating the Keller is not simply an investment in an auditorium. It is an investment in downtown Portland.

Let's honor our past while building Portland's future as a vibrant arts and cultural center. I urge you to make renovation of the Keller Auditorium the City's priority.

Thank you for your leadership and your consideration.

Kate Dickson

Portland, Oregon

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
66	Rhonda Barton	Oppose	It is fiscally irresponsible for the City Council to provide a \$44 million payout to PSU when they have not been transparent about the real costs of funding a theater in a location that is not supported by needed infrastructure. Allocating \$10-15 million to address structural needs of the Keller makes so much more sense and keeps a vital part of downtown from dying.	No	08/10/26 7:38 PM
67	Rudolph Barton	Oppose	PSU's request for \$44 million should not be approved. It is fiscally irresponsible for the City to support such an amount at this point when there has been NO details as to how such money would be spent nor how the city would have oversight. Please vote NO on this proposal.	No	08/10/26 7:44 PM
68	Mark Stevenson	Oppose	I oppose committing funds without a detailed and vetted budget for what the total project will cost and how it will be funded. As I testified in last session on this topic, I was CEO for 10 years of Capital Pacific Bank, a Portland-based, B-Corp community bank. In the final 7 years of my career I was CFO of Craft3, the Oregon and WA nonprofit community lender and CDFI that lends to small businesses and individuals that lack access to traditional sources of capital. In any financial institution, it would be unconscionable to commit funds to a project without a fully vetted budget and understanding of how to be financed. Bank regulators and boards of directors would view it as a material transgression. As mentioned before, I cannot speak to how Portland City Commissioners would explain this to voters after \$40M+ of funds spent you learn that the actual project costs exceed by a wide amount the amount of funding coming from the State without any identified source of funding from the city. I can say, though, that it would be a bad day as CEO of a bank or a CDFI that did that. It would be a termination event and a career and reputation destroyer. I ask you to consider this when you cast your vote.	No	08/11/26 7:15 AM
69	Lynda Moss	Support	I was one of the twelve members of the Steering Committee and I testified in support of Mayor Wilson's resolution on August 28, 2026. The Steering Committee's recommendation was unanimous and was based on detailed review, dialog, presentations and analysis by 12 Portland residents. The PSU proposal and partnership with the City creates a dynamic opportunity to access private, government and corporate support. The Keller does not meet current seismic codes that are in place for public safety in event of an earthquake. As we all witness restructuring in all areas - corporate, education, government - collaboration and partnerships are critical for the economic and city life we all enjoy and desire to improve and enhance. I am attaching a copy of our recommendations for you. i served eight years as a Montana State Senator, I moved to Portland four years ago and as the former Chair Emeritus of the Northwest Area Foundation, I have been working in philanthropy in Oregon and the Pacific Northwest. The Steering Committee's recommendation reflects how strong partnerships grounded in facts and data can transform and build vibrant communities. I urge you to support Mayor Wilson's resolution. Lynda Moss	Yes	08/11/26 8:12 AM
70	Peggy	Oppose	Hello, I support revitalizing the Keller and stopping the forward motion on the PSU option. Our city cannot afford to do both, even a scaled down version of the Keller. The new music venue in the Inner East Side will pull a lot of music options from a similar sized. venue and the Keller's location is ideal as our leading performance venue for Broadway, etc. Let's support the Keller and make sure it is a beautiful robust space for years to come. Thanks!	No	08/11/26 11:22 AM
71	Brian Auriti	Support	I am skeptical of the new venue because hundreds of millions of dollars of construction costs must materialize from donors who thus far are unidentified. In the current budgetary environment, the last thing PSU or the City of Portland needs is to be expected or required to cover significant funding shortfalls related to this venue. However, I would like to be wrong, and donors will not get a chance to prove me wrong unless the City Council passes the current proposal.	No	08/25/26 1:04 PM

Donnie Oliveira
Deputy City Administrator
Community & Economic Development
City of Portland
1120 SW 5th Ave
Portland OR 97204

June 24, 2026

Dear DCA Oliveira,

Thank you for the opportunity to serve on the Steering Committee for the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts project. We have weighed the technical, economic, social, philanthropic, and cultural dimensions of the important choices the City faces. Please accept this letter which outlines our collective vision and recommendations as the City makes critical decisions related to Portland's cultural ecosystem and economy.

A Vision for Transformative Impact

The steering committee's unanimous recommendation sets forth a cohesive vision for the transformation of performing arts in Portland. We support the pairing of a bold, creative investment in the new Portland State University Performing Arts + Culture Center along with civic stewardship and reinvention of the Keller Auditorium and/or site. Together, the investments will protect the economic engine of Broadway touring productions, support nonprofit arts organizations, strengthen the academic mission of Portland State University (PSU) and revitalize a key area of downtown Portland that includes the historic Ira Keller Fountain and Portland Open Space Sequence. By acting decisively now, the City can seize a once-in-a-generation opportunity to build a performing arts ecosystem that is more resilient, inclusive, and vibrant.

Recommendation

Build a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University (PSU). Simultaneously, create an actionable plan to reimagine the Keller Auditorium and/or site based on Portland's historic, cultural, and civic values in accordance with passionate public support expressed by the community.

This unanimous committee recommendation supports a forward-thinking vision that expands the arts ecosystem and redefines Portland's place on the nation's cultural map for generations to come.

A New Broadway-Capable Venue at PSU

After comprehensive review, the steering committee's recommended approach avoids the catastrophic economic and employment impacts that would accompany a multi-year Keller

Auditorium shutdown—estimated at two years of closure and 3–5 years without touring Broadway shows. These losses would be an extremely difficult recovery for Portland’s arts ecosystem and downtown businesses.

Although considered by the committee, a temporary venue is not a viable option if the Keller is renovated to continue as a Broadway-capable facility. There are no existing venues in Portland or proven temporary venue models that could meet the needs of Broadway-scale seating capacity, audience experience, and technical requirements.

In contrast, PSU’s proposed complex delivers substantial immediate and long-term advantages. PSU already holds \$157.6 million in committed funding from the State of Oregon, Prosper Portland, and private donors, with potential for further philanthropic investment due to the project’s scale and ambition. It will also leverage substantial private investment. The project meets the city’s need for a large modern auditorium, while enhancing the university’s academic mission and advancing training in all aspects of the performing arts. The new complex will also provide essential affordable rehearsal and performance space for small arts organizations—an ongoing gap in the city’s arts infrastructure. PSU has a stated intent to raise funds for this supportive role and for long term maintenance.

The Essential Future of the Keller Auditorium

The committee emphasizes in the strongest possible terms that the City must not allow the Keller Auditorium to sit unused or deteriorate but rather be reimaged and continue to provide public benefit. Its location, cultural significance, and relationship to the Keller Fountain make it a uniquely valuable civic asset. The site links to the existing cultural institutions and open spaces along the Broadway-South Park Blocks corridor and to new destinations such as the James Beard Public Market and Performing Arts + Culture Center. Furthermore, given its seismic condition, investment is mandatory even if it is not redeveloped as a large-scale theater.

Multiple ideas have emerged from community and stakeholder feedback. While the steering committee does not endorse a single option, it unanimously recommends that the City begin an inclusive and immediate process to explore a major public space that honors the arts, the cultural landscape, and has public benefits. That process should include a committee to study options and budget, and community engagement to explore future concepts for the Keller Auditorium and/or site. The goal is to ensure that a plan is ready to implement when the new PSU theater opens.

Additional Considerations

Operating Agreements and Civic Accountability

A new venue at PSU represents a major shift in Portland’s performing arts ecosystem. Currently, the Keller Auditorium functions as a financial engine for Portland’s, subsidizing other venues used heavily by nonprofit arts organizations. To ensure continued system-wide financial stability, the committee recommends a formal operating agreement between the City and PSU that secures a dedicated funding stream from PSU venue revenues to support Portland’s and

the broader arts sector. In addition, the committee recommends PSU and the City develop strategies to expand and grow public and private investments in Portland's arts organizations and cultural corridors.

Because the City and State will be major funders of the new facility, they also bear responsibility for establishing development criteria that maximize public benefit and ensure the interests of Portland's performing arts community are incorporated into the facility's design and operations.

Touring Broadway Partnership

Portland is a high-performing and important market for touring Broadway producers. Given the significant public and private investments planned to ensure uninterrupted Broadway programming, the committee encourages PSU and the City to explore opportunities for touring Broadway producers to contribute financially to the Performing Arts + Culture Center and the ecosystem it will support. The City may have reasonable leverage to request such a partnership.

Call to Action

It is imperative that the City move forward in the most expeditious manner and commit the staff resources necessary to implement the committee's recommendation.

Sincerely,

Brad Demby, RA, Brad Demby Architect

Brianna McCoy, Saturday Academy

Carl Abbott, Author, Urban Historian

Carol Mayer-Reed, FASLA, Founding Partner Emeritus, Mayer/Reed

Christopher McVoy, Co-founder, O'Neill McVoy Architects and Partner Emeritus Steven Holl Architects

Edwina Kane, Portland Center Stage

Helen Ying, Community and Cultural Leader

Jim Brunberg, Mississippi Studios, Revolution Hall

Lynda Moss, Moss Consulting

Nick Schwartz-Hall, Independent Producer

Sara Vonde Veld, Oregon Health & Science University

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
72	Ron Mansolilli	Support	Council President Dunphy and Members of Council: For the record, my name is Ron Mansolilli and I am a resident of Portland. I am testifying in support of the resolution to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. I strongly believe that a new Performing Arts Center at PSU is a worthy investment in our city, both economically and in strengthening Portland's identity. Portland's community support for the arts is amazing, and we should build on that reputation with the ambition of becoming a true destination for the performing arts. This project is a wonderful opportunity to invest in our community, strengthen the connection between City of Portland and one of its flagship institutions, PSU, and create a cultural destination that brings people downtown, supports local businesses, and gives residents and visitors another reason to experience Portland. Thank you for your service to our city. I hope you will support this resolution to advance the new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State.	No	08/26/26 11:07 AM
73	Carl Abbott	Support	It's time for Portland to think big. The Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University is an exciting project that will enhance the arts in Portland. It will bolster downtown, support the city's university, provide employment and training for skilled theater professionals, and create new opportunities for small as well as large performing arts organizations. Portland has a long history of settling for half measures. At a time when we are looking to the arts to help revitalize downtown, we need to invest in purpose-built, world class facilities. Too often, we've gone small, or cheap, or convenient. The PSU proposal keeps Portland's highest goals and aspirations for the arts and for the audience clearly in view. When Portland has taken risks and embraced innovation, we have all benefited. For example, swapping a bigger Harbor Drive for Tom McCall Waterfront Park, building the Halprin Fountain Open Space Sequence, cancelling the ill-conceived Mount Hood Freeway, and turning a parking structure into Pioneer Courthouse Square - all these projects brought this entire city critical acclaim and new energy. Central Portland does not need more of the same. It needs a project that will bring new activity, new visitors and new excitement. Portland State University's proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center has what it takes to do just that	No	08/27/26 9:10 AM
74	Robert Hastings FAIA (emeritus), HLC Board member	Oppose	Do not approve any funding for the PSU proposal to create a performing arts center at the University Inn site. Instead, approve the interim modest funding for the Keller Auditorium to help with its current maintenance needs. Approve the long-range solution to revitalize the Keller Auditorium, preserve the employment it provides, the positive stimulation it gives to the neighborhood and the city. Do this good stewardship of the public's trust and financial health.	No	08/28/26 11:24 AM
75	Marianne Sweeney	Oppose	I know the Keller inside and out. I performed there, I've attended theater and opera there. It is a marvelous venue, right-sized for audiences and performers alike. I knew Loretta, Ira's wife. Though retired from teaching, from the Urban Tour Group, from the Civics Learning Project, and from the Portland Symphonic Choir, I am a tax-paying resident of Portland. I care about the buildings that reflect the best of this city. The Keller is such a building. This proposal is a waste of money. The Council should look at safety updates to the Keller, period. This venue along with the fountain across the way is a tribute both to the philanthropy of Ira Keller, and to the thoughtful way that the city of Portland developed. The proposal before you is piecemeal and wasteful. Please vote it down.	No	08/28/26 11:27 AM
76	Faith Danforth	Oppose	I oppose this recommendation until there is a study on the viability of 2 venues in Portland. I strongly prefer that we update and expand the Keller given it's location downtown and its long history. I ask that city council study this more and work to invest in the downtown core.	No	08/28/26 12:02 PM

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
77	Bob Speltz	Support	Council President Dunphy and Members of Council: For the record, my name is Bob Speltz. I am testifying in support of the resolution to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University. I truly believe Portland's renewed spirit and sustained economic vitality will be fueled by unique places across our city where people come together to share meaningful educational and cultural experiences. When fully realized, The Performing Arts + Culture Center will be a remarkable, multi-faceted downtown arts complex supporting our region's entire arts ecosystem. It will be a spectacular new center of gravity for patrons, performers, presenters, artists, visitors and students of all ages to joyfully engage with the performing arts — and for Portland to reclaim center stage in our region's cultural life and national story. Thank you for your service to our city. I hope you will support this resolution to advance the new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State.	No	08/28/26 12:57 PM
78	Jan Castle	Oppose	Dear mayor and councilors, PSU and President Cudd have presented you with a compelling vision which I know many of you are very drawn to. God knows, in my five decades of social activism I've initiated and supported many bold ideas. I've also learned that not all bold ideas can or should be implemented. Brainstorming big ideas is how the creative process works when you're trying to solve a problem. Hopefully, the best ideas rise to the top and the rest are discarded. This vision could be a best idea in different times when the economy is booming, but it is not the best one for the unprecedented economic and social upheaval we're facing. The external forces causing this upheaval are the same ones causing the existential crisis that PSU faces and they are looking for support from the city to build their way out of it. Sadly, the city is being buffeted by the same forces and does not have the resources to respond. PSU should go back to their brainstorming and find a different focus, one that is actually achievable. The City of Portland should concentrate on its own bold experiment, remaking the city government. That's your job, to find better ways to take care of the business the city is already responsible for, not get distracted by the latest shiny object that comes before your eyes. That's how Portland has functioned many times before, leaving us with a backlog of previous bold ideas that we can't adequately support. The establishment of the Portland Center for the Performing Arts is one bold idea that we got lucky on. The building of the Antoinette Hatfield Hall was approved by council despite their not knowing just where the money was going to come from. We do not have the luxury of taking that gamble now. Money was found to build that one, but the maintenance of the Hatfield Hall, the Schnitzer Concert Hall and the Keller Auditorium were never properly provided for, leaving a large backlog for you to deal with now. When money does become available to maintain performing arts facilities, it should be spent on the plan to renovate the Keller which has already been paid for. The Keller Feasibility Study is detailed enough to give you a pretty accurate idea of how much it will cost. There is no such study for the proposed auditorium at PSU, only guestimates based on general knowledge. Add in the cost for the educational building with the small theater and rehearsal spaces which has not even been guessed at, and you have no idea how much this will eventually cost the city. The main reason to even consider this is to provide a place for Broadway shows to play while the Keller undergoes renovation. Alternative locations have been dismissed out of hand without even taking a serious look at the options. One of those options, as described in the Keller Feasibility Study, is to build a temporary auditorium, which is not as crazy as it sounds. It has been done successfully in other markets and is not cheap, but the estimated \$50-60 million it could cost would be far cheaper than the hundreds of millions you would spend if you take on the PSU project. The other reason given for a new auditorium is the assumption that you simply can't get the benefits in a renovation that you could in a new build. If you take the time to give a thorough read of the Keller Feasibility Study you will find that every single issue with the Keller can be resolved. It is a very impressive and inspiring plan which demonstrates clearly that the city has no need for a new auditorium. If you haven't read it, you really don't have the full picture for this vote. Please vote no on this proposal and prioritize renovating the Keller when funds allow. The Keller and its fountain were once a bold idea that worked, and which the public still loves. Let's keep it going!	No	08/28/26 3:23 PM
79	Ken Klos, Architect	Oppose	Flagrant spending of money we don't even have, and I detest paying for someone's vanity project with increased taxes!	No	08/28/26 3:53 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
80 Amy Lynn	Oppose	I fully support renovating the Keller to make it quake safe and modern. It makes zero sense to have two venues so close together AND it makes no sense to have a Keller Fountain without a Keller Auditorium. What would be built in place of the Keller? Downtown already has too many vacancies leading to urban blight. We don't need this area of downtown to fall into further blight with lack of businesses, restaurants, and services.	No	08/28/26 3:56 PM
81 Amber Elliott	Support	Dear Portland City Council, I'm writing in support of PSU's vision for a new performing arts venue in Portland. I've spent many evenings at the Keller Auditorium over the years, and while I'm grateful for what it's given this city, it shows its age. Renovating the existing Keller would mean closing it for two years, at real cost to the artists, technicians, and organizations who depend on it. A new, purpose-built theater with the production capabilities that today's performers and audiences expect can help this city attract more of the productions and performers we all want to see here. Portland deserves a venue that meets audiences and performers where they are today, and one that's seismically safe for the next 50+ years. I'd rather see Portland invest in a long-term solution than keep patching a facility that was never designed for today's needs. Renovating the Keller on its current, constrained site comes with real unknowns in cost and schedule. A new building on a larger site means the scope is clearer from the start, and the result is designed for the way performing arts actually work now. A project like this is also a rare chance to create a genuine civic landmark, one that can bring new life and foot traffic to downtown for decades to come. I hope the Council will support PSU's vision. Thank you, Amber Elliott Portland Resident	No	08/28/26 4:17 PM
82 J. Van Wess	Oppose	This debate has dragged on for years. It is time for certain council members to drop their righteousness,, stop prioritizing personal loyalty to their alma mater, and look at the facts. I strongly urge you to oppose funding the passion project that is the PSU Performing Arts Complex. It is a catastrophic mistake for Portland: Unfunded and Volatile: PSU is already struggling financially and lacks the budget or academic infrastructure to support this complex. Structural Nightmare: Civil engineers have warned the site will severely disrupt surrounding rail lines, local streets, and highways. Public Opposition: Polls clearly show that Portlanders want to renovate the Keller Auditorium instead. As a union member and arts educator, I know we can manage a temporary Keller closure. Portland has multiple other union houses. We can book innovative programming there to keep our union brothers and sisters fully employed during renovations. The 21st Century Keller maintains local pride, utilizes existing hotel and parking infrastructure, and preserves the Keller Fountain. (As a member of the tribe displaced during the original razing of those blocks, I urge you to look forward, not backward—displacement is the historical reality of urban progress). Listen to the engineers, the taxpayers, and the data. Trade the hubris for fiscal reality, vote to renovate the Keller, and help Portland "come back."	Yes	08/29/26 11:42 AM

To the Members of the Portland City Council:

This debate has dragged on for years. It is time for certain council members to drop their righteousness,, stop prioritizing personal loyalty to their alma mater, and look at the facts.

I strongly urge you to **oppose funding the passion project** that is the PSU Performing Arts Complex. It is a catastrophic mistake for Portland:

- **Unfunded and Volatile:** PSU is already struggling financially and lacks the budget or academic infrastructure to support this complex.
- **Structural Nightmare:** Civil engineers have warned the site will severely disrupt surrounding rail lines, local streets, and highways.
- **Public Opposition:** Polls clearly show that Portlanders want to renovate the Keller Auditorium instead.

As a union member and arts educator, I know we can manage a temporary Keller closure. Portland has multiple other union houses. We can book innovative programming there to keep our union brothers and sisters fully employed during renovations.

The 21st Century Keller maintains local pride, utilizes existing hotel and parking infrastructure, and preserves the Keller Fountain. (As a member of the tribe displaced during the original razing of those blocks, I urge you to look forward, not backward—displacement is the historical reality of urban progress).

Listen to the engineers, the taxpayers, and the data. Trade the hubris for fiscal reality, vote to renovate the Keller, and help Portland "come back."

Respectfully submitted,

J. Van Wess

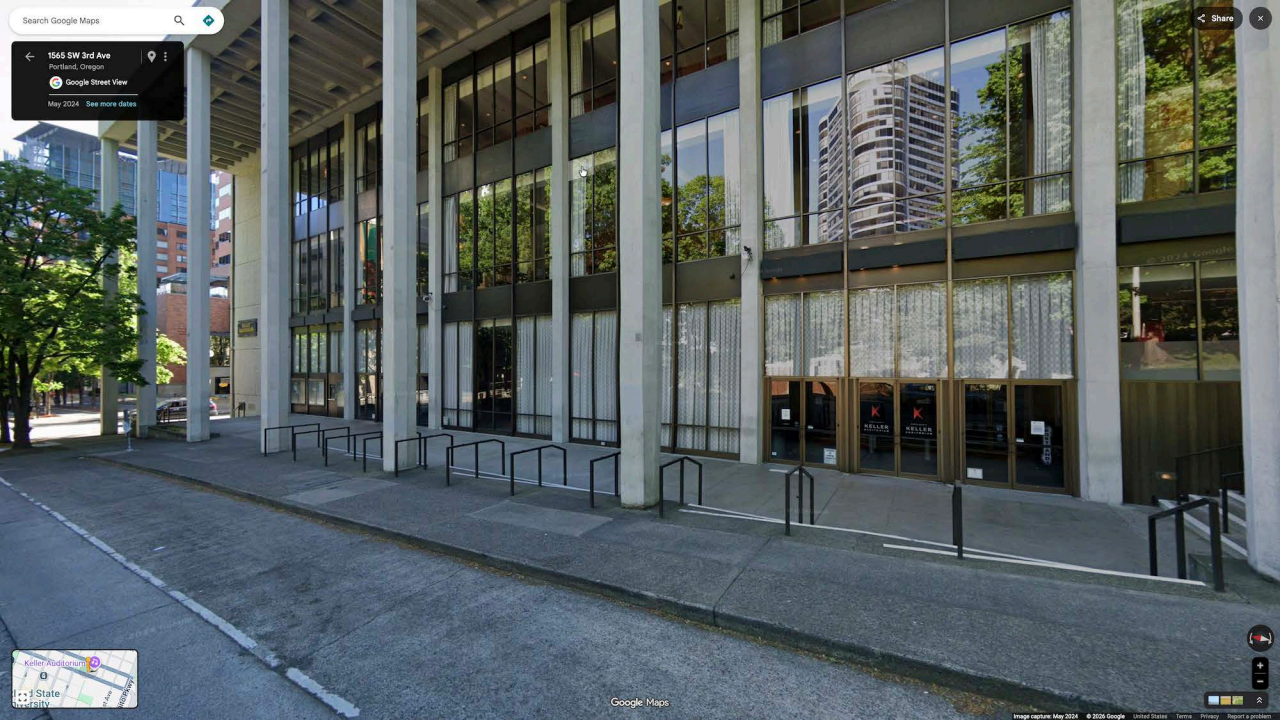
Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
83 Mike Lindberg	Oppose	Dear Mayor and members of the Civic Life Committee, I am asking that you take a moment to become familiar with the history surrounding the current dilemma about which performing arts project to support. I suggest this as a member of the Keller Advisory Committee. In 2018 there was an International Design Competition for the next version of the Keller. It was won by Stufish Entertainment Architects of London and Michael Curry (who does work for the Walt Disney Corporation Entertainment Facilities). Context – When the Keller Fountain first opened, Ada Louise Huxtable of the New York Times wrote that it “may be one of the most important urban spaces since the Renaissance.” The Keller is not in a dead district. Thousands of people live nearby. Tens of millions of public and private dollars have been invested in Parks, hotels, restaurants, housing, parking and offices. The “Fountain District” is alive and well, even more so with a street closure between the Keller and the fountain with programmable activities similar to those at Pioneer Courthouse Square. The project resulting from the design competition solves problems expressed by patrons, producers and employees. With multiple new food and beverage outlets, improved restrooms, and accessibility, plus a new auditorium with improved sightlines and acoustics, the Keller will be a state-of-the-art facility. The estimated costs are \$267 million, maybe even half the cost of constructing a new facility. Further efforts were made to phase the construction process to address the issue of disruptions to the event schedule and the loss of jobs. The previous City Council enthusiastically embraced the renovated Keller until some staff members several levels down advocated for a competition among several developers like OMSI, the Lloyd Center, and PSU. This group of staff have strongly advocated for PSU, even if funds for construction are not available or identified. As a former city commissioner in charge of arts facilities and as the former Director of Planning and Development for the city, I strenuously object to what is, in effect, abandoning the Keller and the Fountain District. I ask the City Council to revisit the plan for the Keller not only for the arts community and members of the Fountain District, but also for the entire city of Portland. Sincerely, Mike Lindberg Former City Commissioner	No	08/29/26 12:06 PM
84 Michael Starosciak	Oppose	As President of our the 195 unit Harrison West tower, three block south of the Keller Auditorium, I have had a number of conversations with our residents regarding the PSU project at 3rd and Lincoln. We are uniformly opposed to this project. A Keller upgrade is a much more popular solution. A long construction project on the PSU proposed site seems misguided. That location is noisy, will obstruct light rail traffic, access to parking and semi-trucks will be nightmare. Thinking a little outside the box, in all your deliberations, have you considered renaming or rebranding the Keller to raise money? Keep the Keller name on the fountain but find some “old money” from a Portland benefactor who is a fan of the arts and, like the Schnitzers, who would like the legacy of restoring the current Keller site to earthquake standards so it would last long into the future. Someone like my old boss, Hank Swigert. Respectfully, Mike Starosciak	No	08/31/26 9:09 AM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
85 Stan Penkin	Oppose	Dear Councilors, The Keller Auditorium is a significant landmark in downtown Portland and must be preserved. It is a major cultural asset of the city, a source of downtown activation, and its connection to the world-renowned Keller fountain is an urban planning success. While the Keller is old and in need of renovation, there is still much planning needed to determine the best future for the Keller. In the meantime, passing a resolution to expend a \$44 million down payment on a PSU facility, money the city does not have, would be folly and irresponsible at this time. Making that commitment to PSU could be a death knell for the Keller as there is no certainty that the city can sustain two such venues and there is currently no overall funding plan for either. In this time of much uncertainty for our city, there is much more analysis and planning necessary before any commitments are made. That is the responsible thing to do. I urge you to vote NO on the proposed two-theater resolution.	No	08/31/26 11:10 AM
86 Richard Bosch Architect (emeritus)	Support	I am an architect and a musician, and I have been a resident of the South Auditorium District for over 31 years. I support the two-part resolution presented as Agenda item 2026-270, and I feel that the Agenda description itself, also offers my own summary: 1) to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University, and to 2) initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium I believe it is foremost an issue of fulfilling the goals of the urban renewal district created in 1959, which certainly were more lofty than simply having an attractive, but lifeless, residential neighborhood with virtually no commerce and no sense of its own historic and cultural significance within the larger city. I have provided three attachments: 1) A pdf prepared a few years ago, but that best represents my observations as an urbanist and would-be concert goer 2) A detailed map of that same pdf, demonstrating how the new PSU center and the Keller Auditorium should be considered as complementary cultural amenities, that define the neighborhood and might finally create a sense of identity 3) An image that underscores that for the greatest majority of the time, Keller Auditorium is a lifeless hulk, contributing nothing to the street scene, due to its singular programming—it simply needs more diverse uses I believe the second part of the resolution— initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium—is often deliberately overlooked by opponents of the resolution, as though it's an all-or-nothing proposition, and who see this issue solely from the perspective of enhancing the Keller Fountain. Ironically, a Keller with all-day programming would provide a much more lively interface. Richard Bosch 255 SW Harrison Street, TH11 Portland 97201	Yes	08/31/26 7:33 PM

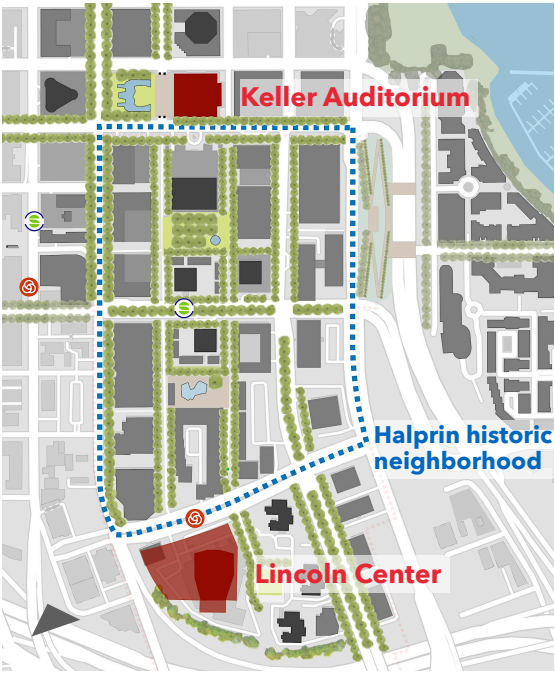
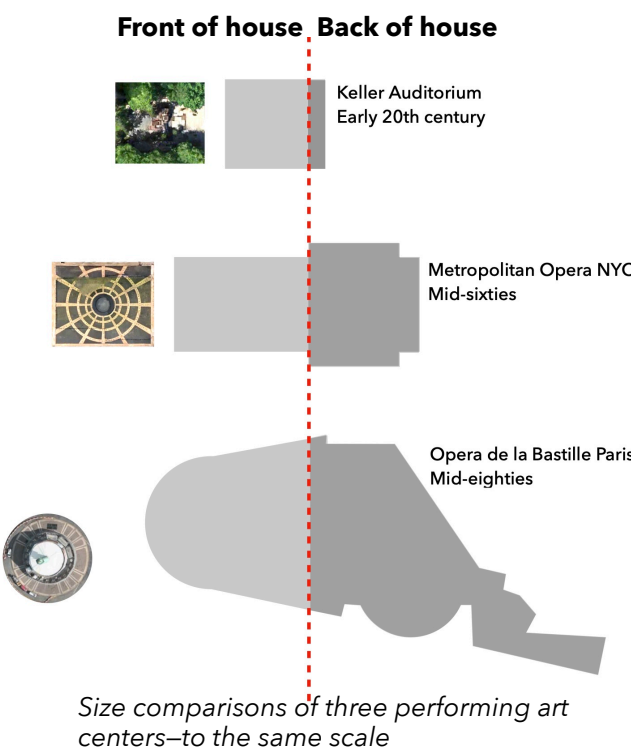
← 1565 SW 3rd Ave
Portland, Oregon

 Google Street View

May 2024 See more dates



Richard Bosch is a retired City of Portland architect and a longtime resident of the Halprin historic district. He is an opera and classical music fanatic. Since retirement, he now assists other architects in the publishing of books on architecture and urbanism.



Plan of historic district with proposed sites

Let’s build the PSU performance center and find a more appropriate use for ‘The Keller.’

As a longtime resident of the Halprin historic neighborhood, I support the efforts being made to find a more compatible use to complement the iconic Keller Fountain. But I question why the dreary Keller Auditorium is seen as integral or even related to that solution. One doesn’t need to presume the other. Lets keep the two evaluations separate.

To expend years of effort and millions of City dollars to salvage a 100-year old, poorly-functioning facility, that was never intended for its current use, would miss two, incredible opportunities: to revitalize the Halprin historic neighborhood and to create a world-class performance center within that neighborhood.

The problem with the Keller Auditorium is not simply about the auditorium space—the public side of the facility—which admittedly could be tweaked for better sightlines and various other nominal improvements. The problem is about the back of house, or rather the lack thereof.

For contemporary music theater—complex productions such as opera and musicals—roughly the same amount of space is required back of house as in front of the stage. Keller’s vaudeville era roots simply cannot provide the storage and maneuverability for contemporary theater, nor even decent facilities for the hundreds of performers and production staff that make up a typical behind the scenes musical production. (See the diagram to the left comparing the size of Keller Auditorium in relation to two other more contemporary facilities.)

Besides its cramped back of house, the other problem with the Keller is that it is used for one purpose only—large-scale productions. It has no other capability. For the remainder of the time it is a dark and lifeless hulk. The auditorium is used for roughly 28% of the year, but only for about four hours per day, and then mostly at night—400 hours of use out of 8760 hours per year—4.5% of the year. For the remainder, the lights are off.

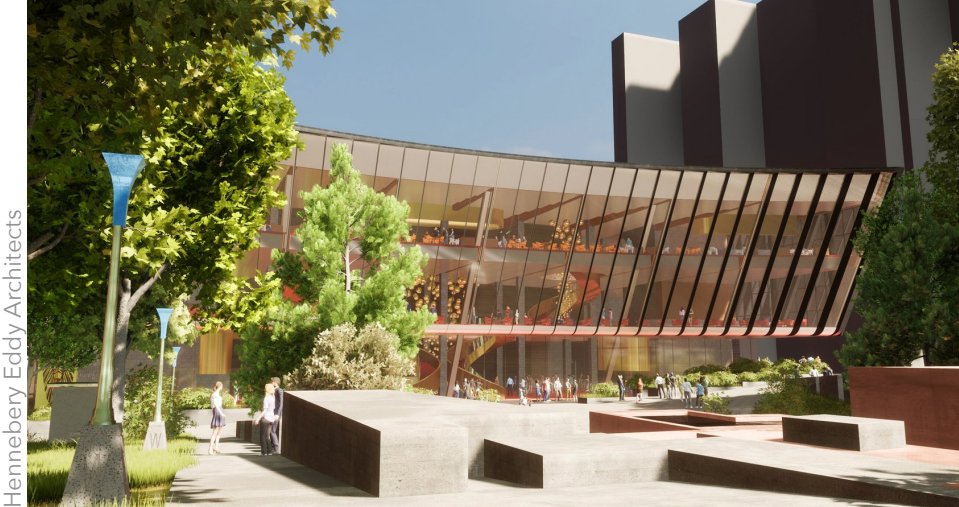
For these reasons alone the PSU proposal is a breath of fresh air. Not only because of more realistic and humane back of house provisions, and a state of the art auditorium, but because it proposes varied auditorium sizes and more diverse uses that will allow other types of performance —chamber music and dance—and bring constant activity to the facility.

But, there is yet another significant reason to favor the PSU proposal—it would finally resolve a long-standing urban flaw within the historic neighborhood. The site proposed for the performance center was part of the same urban renewal district (created around 1960) as the remainder of the “South Auditorium” neighborhood. But because the site was developed as a dreary motel with an expansive parking lot (ironically, both considered state-of-the-art at the time) the site has been neglected, as though beyond the urban limits of the city.

The PSU proposal would finally anchor the south boundary of the district just as the the Keller Fountain and its new complement anchor the north boundary. This would provide better definition to the historic district and bring some life to an attractive, but mostly lifeless neighborhood. (See the neighborhood diagram to the left locating Keller auditorium and the proposed PSU facility.)

Back to the search for a Keller Auditorium replacement, the handsome renderings prepared by Hennebery Eddy best capture the spirit of what the new Keller ought to be—a lively place used throughout the day and throughout the year, a destination for the entire community.

Footnote: the Metropolitan Opera produced a surprisingly (shockingly?) candid documentary—*The Opera House*—about its own painful (and often vituperative) process switching from the old Metropolitan Opera House to Lincoln Center. It captures the same contrary forces as with the Keller, those who emphasize nostalgic historicism versus an emphasis on achieving the best performance facilities. The latter won out in New York. Let’s hope the same happens in Portland.



This dazzling west facing facade is exactly what the Keller Fountain and downtown Portland need. But a better purpose needs to be found for the building behind the facade that will promote this kind of vitality all day long and throughout the year.

Equally important is the treatment of the south elevation facing the historic district, which currently is just a blank wall with emergency doors, thereby adding to the dismal, vehicle-oriented character of SW Market.



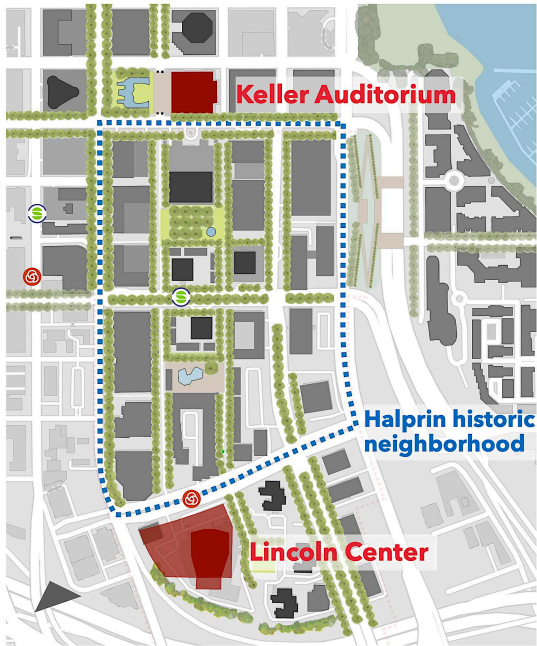
This urbane proposal for a new Theater Arts and Culture facility provides an exciting cultural amenity to the Halprin historic neighborhood and finally replaces a conspicuous, desolate open air parking lot and a dreary motel, with a meaningful urban presence and community purpose.



South elevation of Civic Auditorium in 1967 (and now) adding monotony to SW Market



University Place Motel, a touch of suburbia in the historic district



Plan of historic district with proposed sites

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
87	Sarah Oeffering	Support	I'll be honest: I avoid seeing shows at the Keller whenever I can. There are too many bad seats, long lines, narrow stairs, poor acoustics, and limited amenities. Going to the theater should feel like a night out, but at the Keller, it often feels like you are being processed through the building and rushed out the front door as soon as the show is over. I recently had the opportunity to tour the Keller, and seeing the building up close made its limitations even more apparent. At one point, we were told that they cannot store anything underneath the seating because if something spills, it can run through the floor. That may sound like a small detail, but to me, it illustrates just how many compromises are required to keep an aging building functioning in ways it was never designed to. The Keller will continue to require significant investment, no matter how much money we put into it. At some point, we have to ask whether we are spending money to preserve a building or spending money to make it work. Let's invest in a long-term solution rather than continuing to put resources into a facility that was never designed to meet today's needs. As architects, we understand that what audiences see is only a fraction of what makes a Broadway-capable theater work. Behind the scenes are loading, production spaces, rehearsal rooms, dressing rooms, storage, back-of-house circulation, acoustical infrastructure, and countless other requirements. These things take space. Trying to accommodate them within the extremely constrained footprint of an existing theater creates compromises that are difficult and sometimes impossible to overcome. A purpose-built venue can be designed around the needs of today's performers, productions, and audiences rather than forcing those needs into a building designed for another era. This is also an incredible opportunity for the City to partner with an institution that is deeply invested in Portland's success, one that is bringing its own money, expertise, and management to the table. This isn't an out-of-state billionaire or a mega ticketing company looking to extract value from our city. It is an opportunity to build a venue by Portlanders, for Portlanders. Portland is known for its incredible arts and music community. A new venue with the right accommodations, production capabilities, and acoustics can help attract even more performers, productions, and audiences to our city. Portland has some work to do when it comes to our reputation. A world-class performing arts venue is an opportunity to show people the creative, welcoming, ambitious, and beautiful side of our city. We also need to consider the alternative. A major renovation of the Keller would require closing the venue for an extended period, potentially two years. That would have real consequences for the artists, technicians, stagehands, businesses, and organizations that rely on performances there for their livelihoods. It could put Portland's Broadway programming at risk during that period and make it more difficult to bring those productions back. Broadway also provides a significant portion of the operating revenue for Portland's Centers for the Arts, meaning the impact would extend far beyond the Keller itself. Renovating an existing theater on a constrained site comes with significant unknowns and evolving costs. A new building provides the opportunity for a more predictable scope, schedule, and cost while creating a venue designed specifically for the needs of today's performing arts. Let's build a venue that is safe, accessible, acoustically excellent, functional for the people who work in it, and enjoyable for the people who come to experience it. Let's build something that shows people what Portland is capable of and gives our community a place they can be proud of.	No	09/01/26 10:37 AM
88	Jeremy Sacks	Oppose	I strongly oppose funding a new center at PSU - there is no plan to fund it and no amenities around PSU to attract audiences (hotels, restaurants, etc.). Moreover, there is no plan to address the Keller. Nor has any professional market study been undertaken. This seems like a solution in search of a problem, and sadly in the tradition of shoot first and aim later.	No	09/01/26 10:44 AM
89	Cormac Burke	Oppose	Please vote this down, it makes no sense and the city can't afford it.	No	09/01/26 11:35 AM
90	Tuck Wilson		I am a resident since 1956 and have consistently been engaged in the life of the city. I appreciate the dilemma you confront. Portland State is our beloved university but should not be permitted to spin a web entangling its host like a spider with its prey. Today's resolution is ill informed and premature. Preserving a performance facility in Portland is a worthy goal but satisfying solutions are not yet in hand. Both the city and Portland State are bowed by debt and competing funding demands. Vote no today and wait until the time is right. In the meantime, our hundred-year-old Keller will continue to host major performances, providing much needed revenue for Portland's performing arts venues.	No	09/01/26 2:05 PM

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
91	Mert Meeker	Oppose	I strongly oppose this recommendation and urge council to remodel the Keller and keep it our premier Broadway show venue.	No	09/01/26 2:39 PM
92	Laurie Wimmer	Support	PACC: to revitalize Portland and PSU and save jobs	Yes	09/01/26 4:15 PM
93	Julie Blackman	Oppose	Portland's budget is currently stretched very thin. The same is true of Portland State University, which is actively cutting faculty and programs. This is not the time to invest in a speculative venture with PSU. This is particularly true given that the Keller Auditorium anchors its sector of downtown Portland. It's been, in one form or another, a major piece of Portland's artistic life for many decades. And while it would benefit from improvements, nothing is so urgent that the city should abandon the Keller at this time. I urge the city to act responsibly by retaining the Keller and walking away from the expensive boondoggle represented by the PSU option.	No	09/01/26 5:16 PM
94	Jeanie Lai	Support	I strongly support Portland State University's vision for a new performing arts venue and a new home for the Keller. This is an extraordinary opportunity for Portland, not only to create a safe, world-class performing arts venue, but to make a significant investment in the future of our downtown. I've worked in Portland for 20 years, and despite my love of the arts, I've only been to the Keller twice. As an architect, I know enough about the building's seismic vulnerability that I actively avoid going there. Portland deserves a major performing arts venue where audiences, performers, and staff can gather without that concern and one designed to serve our city for the next 50 years and beyond. But this is about much more than replacing an aging building. Portland is still struggling to bring people and energy back downtown following the pandemic. We need significant investments that give people a reason to come downtown, stay downtown, eat at restaurants, support local businesses, and experience the city together. A new performing arts center at PSU could be exactly that kind of catalyst, a civic and cultural landmark that brings life to this part of the city night after night. Building new also allows Portland to keep the existing Keller operating until the new venue is ready. That continuity matters. Closing the Keller for years during a renovation would affect not just audiences, but performers, arts organizations, technicians, restaurants, hotels, and the many people whose livelihoods depend on the activity it generates. At a time when downtown needs more activity, not less, maintaining that cultural and economic engine while we build for the future is incredibly important. There are very few moments when a city gets the chance to intentionally create a new civic landmark in their downtown. Portland has that opportunity now. We have seen with the new PDX airport what ambitious, distinctly Portland design can do. Not just create a great place but change how people experience and perceive our city. We need more investments like that. A new performing arts center connected to PSU could be another defining civic project: welcoming, ambitious, sustainable, and rooted in the culture of this place. It could bring people together, strengthen our arts community, energize downtown, and give Portland something we can be proud of for generations. We need to think beyond fixing what we have and INVEST IN WHAT PORTLAND CAN BECOME. I strongly support moving forward with the PSU performing arts center and a new Keller.	No	09/01/26 6:55 PM



Representing 106 affiliates and their 60,000 members in the four-county Metropolitan Portland area

Date: September 1, 2026
To: Portland City Council,
Council President Dunphy and Members
From: Laurie Wimmer, Executive Secretary-Treasurer,
NW Oregon Labor Council, AFL-CIO
RE: Portland Arts and Culture Center

We are pleased to speak in support of a path forward for the development of a large, Broadway-capable theater as part of the Portland State University arts and culture complex, which will save, create, and expand good union jobs in this city, boost PSU's enrollment, improve the city's arts inventory, and will ultimately help revitalize our city.

Your predecessors on the former Commission originally had only one vision to address the inadequacies of the Keller Auditorium, which was to close it for two or more years to expand and seismically improve it, thereby costing hundreds of jobs, walking away from millions in economic activity, and potentially driving off Broadway Across America – its most lucrative tenant. We stepped forward and asked that commission to consider a different path – one that could be staged over time, benefit the larger community, and save as many as 1,000 jobs. That commission listened – thank you, Councilor Ryan, for your vote to look at other options.

Fast forward to this hearing today. You have before you the work product of two years of meetings, studies, fundraising, and planning for an approach that meets an array of needs. A significant sum of money has already been raised or pledged for the Portland State plan which would be situated on the largest developable parcel in downtown, just two blocks from the Keller.

We believe that as Portland continues to build back from the challenges of the past six years, we must play to our strengths. The inter-institutional partnerships envisioned in the PACC plan plays uniquely to the Portland we love. We are proud of our excellent arts faculty, some of whose students must rehearse in stairwells, others who have led the university's choir to international fame for its excellence.

Today, we are thrilled to say that not only would this path enable our IATSE members to maintain their employment by moving to the new large theater once completed, but the Keller, too, can still be renovated and offer a smaller venue for smaller scale arts programming.

Most especially, we would like to point out that as PSU struggles to reverse its downward enrollment trends and resulting fiscal crisis, we see the PACC as a part of the turnaround effort the university can employ – along with effective marketing of its excellent academic programs – to ensure that they are never again in a position to shamefully lay off a portion of their faculty.

PSU and the building trades have entered into an agreement, not even a week old, to deploy a project workforce development agreement for this project as well, and NW Oregon Labor Council was proud to have served as a catalyst for this to occur. We thank President Ann Cudd for her willingness to sign on to a labor-friendly approach to the development of the arts complex.

We also anticipate ongoing work for various other trades, including operating engineers, electricians, security, and more.

We are grateful to this committee for its often-expressed union values as city leaders. Your support for this proposal is the best demonstration of those values we could imagine. We urge the council to support this revitalization plan with a do-pass recommendation.

Thank you.

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
95	J. Carlson	Oppose	Dear Portland City Councilors: I am writing about concerns I have about the resolution to Accept the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts Recommendations to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center at Portland State University. This concept has been analyzed from many aspects since 2017. It would be nice in a perfect world if the city had money to remodel the Keller Auditorium and help build the new venue at PSU, but it doesn't. The city does not have money to do any of it. How does it even figure in budgets moving forward with all the needs this city has? Does it lead to more taxes, bond measures or what? The city should focus on the Keller Auditorium. There have been opinions written that support the renovation of the Keller at half the price of a new venue. The Halprin Conservancy developed an extensive renovation plan that would expand the Keller Auditorium. The City Council is well aware of the contents of this plan that adds 41,000 square feet to the building, creates a pedestrian mall between the front of the auditorium and the iconic Keller Fountain, considered one of America's greatest fountains of the 20th Century. The current Keller location provides 2,475 nearby parking spaces, public access by MAX trains and TriMet buses and 800 nearby hotel rooms, amenities that surpass the proposed PSU location at SW Fourth Ave and Lincoln St. This plan could also be done in phases. I appreciate your reading my thoughts. Thank you J. Carlson	No	09/01/26 11:05 PM
96	Michelle Schulz	Support	Thank you for considering my supporting testimony.	Yes	09/01/26 11:30 PM
97	Karen Crichton	Oppose	You're not telling the public anything about what's going on with the Moda situation, and now you're also moving forward with other "Large-Scale Performing Arts" venue plans-?! - This item needs to be put on hold at least until the voters have a solid-accounting of the Moda plans - And then, this time, there needs to be realistic-numbers presented to the public from all related Bureaus & public agencies, regarding the true cost (short-term & long-term) of each of these projects - the increased police/EMT staffing, Public Works/infrastructure changes, PBOT/ODOT/TriMet, BPS, etc. - A lot of us assume that those who plan to profit from the PSU proposal view the student body as an endless supply of hungry workers willing to staff the venue for meager wages. The students know this, obviously - let's show them that the public won't be subsidizing any project at their school that was never intended to benefit them or their education. - Portlanders would rather have a thriving, well-funded-&-maintained parks system & other outdoor / public recreation spaces than what you're proposing. Considering your current budgetary situation, you obviously can't find the money for both -- given a choice, Portlanders choose parks. And schools. And getting everyone housed again. And public transportation. ---->> And transparency from our government.	No	09/02/26 7:04 AM
98	Mark Schopmeyer	Support	A Broadway-capable venue at PSU is the only option that preserves Portland's existing arts economy while also ensuring its long-term viability. We must advance this option for more detailed planning.	No	09/02/26 8:39 AM
99	Erin Fox	Support	I believe that we have a greater understanding of the power of in-person arts and community in the wake of the pandemic. As someone who has worked professionally in the theater industry, I understand how having venues of various sizes in one city benefits a robust cultural arts scene - allowing for local art makers to flourish, not just allocate otherwise unoccupied space for touring shows. The variety of arts/performance/support spaces included in the PSU project is very exciting and helps to create the environment that Portland used to be known for - a place where artists thrive. Additionally, it is simply more sensible for a new theater to be built for the large scale productions with the myriad associated loading and backstage requirements. This does not mean that the Keller is to be forgotten - it too can be part of the city's future if an appropriately scaled renovation is to follow the new construction at PSU.	No	09/02/26 10:09 AM

September 1, 2026

**Portland City Council
Resolution Supporting Future Large-Scale Performing Arts Recommendations**

Mayor, Council President, and Councilors,

My name is Michelle Schulz. I am a Principal with GBD Architects, a Portland-based architecture firm, and I am also serving as President of CREDA Oregon, representing commercial real estate owners, developers, investors, and professionals who are committed to the long-term success of our region.

I am writing in strong support of the resolution accepting the recommendations for a future large-scale performing arts venue and encouraging continued advancement of this important investment.

As someone who has spent my career helping shape places where people want to live, work, learn, and gather, I believe projects like this are exactly what Portland needs to accelerate the revitalization of our central city.

For several years, Portland has been working to recover from the economic impacts of the pandemic, changing work patterns, and reduced activity downtown. We have spent considerable time discussing how to bring people back to the urban core. The answer is not any single project or policy. It is creating compelling reasons for people to choose downtown as a destination.

A world-class performing arts center would do exactly that.

Major cultural venues generate activity far beyond their walls. They create opportunities for restaurants, hotels, retailers, parking operators, and countless small businesses. They attract visitors from across the region and beyond. They create reasons for office workers to stay downtown after work, for families to visit on weekends, and for tourists to choose Portland over competing destinations.

Importantly, they help create vibrancy throughout the day and evening, making downtown feel active, welcoming, and safe.

As design professionals and economic development advocates, we know that thriving cities are built on more than housing and employment. They are built on culture, experiences, and gathering places that foster civic pride and community connection. Great cities invest in the institutions that define who they are. Portland has long been recognized for its creativity, arts, and culture. This project represents an opportunity to reinforce that identity while also providing significant economic benefit.

The proposed partnership with Portland State University is particularly compelling. PSU serves as an anchor institution in the heart of downtown, and investments that strengthen its connection to the city create benefits for students, businesses, residents, and visitors alike. This is the type of catalytic project that can attract additional investment and help stimulate continued revitalization of the surrounding district.

From a commercial real estate and economic development perspective, we need more projects that create destinations and draw people together. We need investments that demonstrate confidence in Portland's future and signal to residents, employers, and investors that we continue to believe in our downtown.

This performing arts center is more than a cultural amenity. It is an economic development strategy. It is a placemaking strategy. It is an investment in the future competitiveness and vitality of Portland's urban core.

On behalf of CREDA and as a Portland business leader, I encourage the Council to support this resolution and continue advancing this important opportunity for our city.

Thank you for your consideration.

Michelle Schulz, GBD Architects
CREDA Oregon President (formerly NAIOP)

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Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Lynda Moss	Support	Once in a Life Time Opportunity As a one of twelve members of the Large Scale Performing Arts Steering Committee, I support the Mayor's resolution to move forward for a new Keller Auditorium at Portland State University. I testified before the City Life Committee to share my support based on review of the technical reports and data the Steering Committee reviewed as well as additional information provided by the Arts and Culture staff, other Steering Committee members, interviews and research. In my capacity and with my experience in philanthropy as the Chair Emeritus of the Northwest Area Foundation (NWAf) that funds in Oregon, seven other states and 25 Native Nations in the West and Pacific Northwest, I interviewed two philanthropic leaders in Portland and Oregon. They shared the fact that the nonprofit sector in Portland is stressed and funding request to one foundation had increased by 30%. I also learned the City of Vancouver is planning a small performing arts venue which was not included in the Hundren market analysis, further solidifying the finding that Portland can only support one large scale performing arts facility. I learned and shared with the Steering Committee that the Eugene Ballet facility includes a performing arts theater and classrooms as well as as condominium housing above the arts structure that provides a sustainable process and source of funding, similar to a building reserve endowment. If the site of the Keller Auditorium is reimagined, that type of public/private partnership could revitalize the Downtown and provide additional tax support. Putting a bandaid on the Keller just "kicks the can down the road". The current structure does not meet seismic codes and is a public safety risk! This is a once in a lifetime opportunity for Portland to embrace change, work across sectors and build a state of the art performing arts center. Please step forward, not backward. Support the PSU proposal that the Steering Committee supported unanimously!	No	09/02/26 10:53 AM
Nicole De Jong	Support	I'm very excited about a new state of the art performance venue in Portland. The new venue will support the arts with the latest technologies and variety of performing spaces. The venue will have state of the art technology and improved acoustics that will draw performers and audiences and increase Portland's reputation as an arts and performance hub. The new venue will increase my personal attendance as I don't feel comfortable in the Keller due to seismic safety concerns and out of date accessibility.	No	09/02/26 1:14 PM
Wynne Wakkila	Oppose	The new location is not convenient, detracts business from downtown, and costs way too much. I prefer the Keller. It's already established in a supportive neighborhood with restaurants, parking, and easy access. Downsizing the Keller makes no sense. Please use logic in making your decision. Thank you!!!	No	09/02/26 2:18 PM
Frederick Wearn	Oppose	The City is not in the financial position to support both the PSU site and the Keller. The Keller Auditorium and Fountain supports a critical part of downtown. The PSU site is on a marginal of downtown, up against the freeway. Everyone should walk the two sites and feel the difference.	No	09/02/26 2:26 PM
Frederick Wearn	Oppose	The City is not in the financial position to support both the PSU site and the Keller. The Keller Auditorium and Fountain supports a critical part of downtown. The PSU site is on a marginal of downtown, up against the freeway. Everyone should walk the two sites and feel the difference.	No	09/02/26 2:26 PM
Harriet Bing	Oppose	The Keller is part of the fabric of the inner city. Cost to repair and continue its use are much less than a new performing arts center.	No	09/02/26 2:54 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Connie Kirk	Oppose	Dear Mayor Wilson and Honorable City Council Members: Though I support arts everywhere and robustly over time ... *Please OPPOSE 2026 - 270 PSU's Large Scale Broadway venue at this time. *Please support and initiate the Keller's Affordable Fix as a priority now. PSU's Labor disputes need to be addressed before awarding them monies. I support the Keller Reimagined Project as Portland's first priority: 1. Money has been raised for the Keller. 2. Engineering has been robustly addressed by engineers. 3. Keller's design will draw local, international and broad audiences. 4. The outdoor venue will be hip in scope and draw a wide demographic. 5. The outdoor venue will provide equitable access to broader socio-economic demographics. 6. Keller's vision is fully realized. Other venues, albeit notable, appear in their infancy. 7. Keller's Fountain District has an infrastructure in place. 8. Keller's proposal is more affordable. 9. The Keller's renovation is vital to downtown's revitalization. PSU's Labor Relations Reports Are Disturbing. See below the American Association of University Professors (AAUP) press coverage relating PSU's labor disputes. https://psuaaup.net/about/press https://nwlaborpress.org/2025/11/psu-ordered-to-reinstate-faculty-with-back-pay/ https://www.opb.org/article/2025/12/05/portland-state-university-faculty-union/ https://www.opb.org/article/2025/10/16/portland-state-unfair-labor-practice/ SEE BELOW AN AI SUMMARY (of publicly available information) regarding PSU's labor disputes. [] Denote AI's attributional sources. Portland State University (PSU) is currently facing significant labor disputes, primarily involving its faculty union, the American Association of University Professors (AAUP). The university has been criticized for ignoring a binding arbitration decision that ordered the reinstatement of laid-off faculty members and back pay, raising concerns about its commitment to labor agreements and shared governance. [dailynous.com, Oregon Public Broadcasting] Overview of Labor Disputes at Portland State University Portland State University (PSU) is currently embroiled in significant labor disputes involving its faculty union, the American Association of University Professors (AAUP). The core issue revolves around the university's failure to comply with a binding arbitration decision regarding the reinstatement of laid-off faculty members. Key Issues Arbitration Decision Ignored An independent arbitration ruling mandated PSU to reinstate ten non-tenure-track faculty members and provide back pay. The university has not acted on this decision, leading to accusations of bad faith and disregard for labor agreements. Faculty Layoffs In 2024, PSU laid off several faculty members as part of cost-cutting measures. The layoffs have been criticized for not following proper procedures outlined in the faculty union's contract. Responses from Labor Leaders Union and National Support The PSU-AAUP has expressed frustration over the university's actions, stating that they undermine union contracts. National labor leaders are closely monitoring the situation, emphasizing the importance of adhering to arbitration rulings. Potential Actions The union may seek clarification from the arbitrator or file an unfair labor practice complaint with Oregon's Employment	No	09/02/26 3:15 PM

Document Number 2026-270

Position Oppose

Comments Dear Mayor Wilson and Honorable City Council Members:

Though I support arts everywhere and robustly over time ...

*Please OPPOSE 2026 - 270 PSU's Large Scale Broadway venue at this time.

*Please support and initiate the Keller's Affordable Fix as a priority now.

PSU's Labor disputes need to be addressed before awarding them monies.

I support the Keller Reimagined Project as Portland's first priority:

1. Money has been raised for the Keller.
2. Engineering has been robustly addressed by engineers.
3. Keller's design will draw local, international and broad audiences.
4. The outdoor venue will be hip in scope and draw a wide demographic.
5. The outdoor venue will provide equitable access to broader socio-economic demographics.
6. Keller's vision is fully realized. Other venues, albeit notable, appear in their infancy.
7. Keller's Fountain District has an infrastructure in place.
8. Keller's proposal is more affordable.
9. The Keller's renovation is vital to downtown's revitalization.

PSU's Labor Relations Reports Are Disturbing.

See below the American Association of University Professors (AAUP) press coverage relating PSU's labor disputes.

<https://psuaaup.net/about/press>

<https://nwlaborpress.org/2025/11/psu-ordered-to-reinstate-faculty-with-back->

<https://www.opb.org/article/2025/12/05/portland-state-university-faculty-unio>

<https://www.opb.org/article/2025/10/16/portland-state-unfair-labor-practice/>

SEE BELOW AN AI SUMMARY (of publicly available information) regarding PSU's labor disputes. [] Denote AI's attributional sources.

Portland State University (PSU) is currently facing significant labor disputes, primarily involving its faculty union, the American Association of University Professors (AAUP). The university has been criticized for ignoring a binding arbitration decision that ordered the reinstatement of laid-off faculty members and back pay, raising concerns about its commitment to labor agreements and shared governance.
[dailynous.com, Oregon Public Broadcasting]

Overview of Labor Disputes at Portland State University Portland State University (PSU) is currently embroiled in significant labor disputes involving its faculty union, the American Association of University Professors (AAUP). The core issue revolves around the university's failure to comply with a binding arbitration decision regarding the reinstatement of laid-off faculty members.

Key Issues

Arbitration Decision Ignored

An independent arbitration ruling mandated PSU to reinstate ten non-tenure-track faculty members and provide back pay.

The university has not acted on this decision, leading to accusations of bad faith and disregard for labor agreements.

Faculty Layoffs

In 2024, PSU laid off several faculty members as part of cost-cutting measures.

The layoffs have been criticized for not following proper procedures outlined in the faculty union's contract.

Responses from Labor Leaders

Union and National Support

The PSU-AAUP has expressed frustration over the university's actions, stating that they undermine union contracts.

National labor leaders are closely monitoring the situation, emphasizing the importance of adhering to arbitration rulings.

Potential Actions

The union may seek clarification from the arbitrator or file an unfair labor practice complaint with Oregon's Employment Relations Board, a process that could take years.

Conclusion

The ongoing labor disputes at PSU highlight significant tensions between university administration and faculty, raising questions about the institution's commitment to shared governance and labor rights. The situation remains dynamic, with potential implications for faculty employment and university governance.

[Oregon Public Broadcasting]

[Justia]

End of AI Summary

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Respectfully,

Connie Kirk, Portland, OR
Resident - District #4

Name or Organization	Connie Kirk

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
107	Bosco-Milligan Foundation/Architectural Heritage Center	Oppose		Yes	09/02/26 3:21 PM
108	Rick Bella	Oppose	The Keller is a proven asset to the city, as well as the entire region. Modernizing and/or expanding it certainly should be a priority and would fulfill the building's purpose, which is to provide a well-appointed venue for performances -- both for artists and audiences.	No	09/02/26 3:34 PM
109	Crystal Froembling	Support	Councilors, Thank you for considering this important issue. All of Portland and our surrounding region is relying on a positive path forward for downtown Portland. I write to you as a lifelong Portlander, PSU double-alum, and a member of the PSU professional community, but my opinions and position on this issue are my own. I believe this project needs to move with urgency and collective support so that our region puts in to practice the critical concept that we are all *one team*. We all feel the impact of urban development or lack thereof. I'll share a specific example of my own experience in the arts. My wife and I used to be season ticket holders at Portland Opera. For years now, the limitations on offerings, changed schedule, and logistics challenges have resulted in averaging one opera attended annually, instead of 3-4. We enjoy at least 4 or 5 additional theater events a year and also love musicals. Over the last two years progressive health issues have made it necessary for her to use a walker for mobility and safety. The last time we attended an event at the Keller Auditorium, (recently) she had to proactively plan how she was going to manage getting to the restroom and accessing facilities in time to make it back into the show. (Before we even arrived.) Once facing intermission, she encountered "the crowd", waded across the room, and then had to argue with a group of people all socializing and blocking entrance to the SINGLE all gender/disabled bathroom. I was outraged and walked away feeling so disappointed in Portland. A few weeks later we attended an opera in NYC at the Metropolitan Opera. Upon arrival we were pulled out of line and directed to an accessible entrance. An usher showed us the most appropriate bathroom and offered to bring her walker back to her at intermission if that was helpful. At the end of the show, they checked in with us to make sure we had a great experience. These are all simple facility issues, but the difference was dramatic and left a lasting impression of the erosion of basics in our fair city. If Portland wants to sustain being a major metropolitan city, we need to hold ourselves to the standards that keep people here and not nostalgia as a planning strategy. I urge you to support this project for all of these reasons and more. Respectfully, Crystal Froembling, MPA	No	09/02/26 3:47 PM
110	Elizabeth Sazie	Oppose	I support a more affordable fix of the current Keller Auditorium, which I have been attending for many years. Yes, I agree it is in need of some upgrades, but the proposed future Broadway-capable venue at PSU does not appear as accessible and is too expensive. I do not support building a new venue at PSU.	No	09/02/26 4:10 PM



September 3, 2026

Portland City Council
Re. Keller Auditorium and Proposed PSU Complex

Dear Members of City Council,

The mission of the Architectural Heritage Center/Bosco-Milligan Foundation is to empower people to discover and preserve Portland's historic and culturally significant places. Through our programs and advocacy, people across this city are embracing preservation and reuse as a key component in creating equitable, livable, and sustainable communities..

We applaud the City Council's interest in promoting the arts as one of the pillars of a culturally and economically vibrant city. But we urge you to **vote No** on the resolution to move forward with a new city-owned Broadway theater at PSU. **We see no evidence that there is funding or a customer base to support the proposed new complex and still retain the Keller** – especially with other new venues already under development.

One of our central values is **Stewardship**. And in this case, **stewardship of the Keller and our downtown should be paramount**. We endorse the Halprin Conservancy's proposed \$15M upgrade of the Keller which will elevate both the functionality of the Keller and the vibrancy of the surrounding park and fountain sequence, which is a national treasure.

Without a plan - and dedicated funds to complete that plan - the likelihood that the Keller will be left vacant and the heart of our downtown cultural district would spiral further downward is real.

Thank you again for your support of Portland's arts and culture, for the opportunity to weigh in, and for your thoughtful consideration of our concerns.

Claire Long
Executive Director

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
111	Virginia Ehelebe	Oppose	WRITTEN TESTIMONY: Agenda Item 2026-270 Like other members of the Concerned Citizens group, I urge you to delay a decision on a future performing arts center. I support a delay even though I recognize large construction projects can help revive our city's listless economy. The city's fiscal constraints coupled with the size of our capital maintenance backlog, however, argue for setting a high bar for new projects. To merit investment of city time and money, projects should boost the city's long-term growth potential and involve minimal downside risks. The PSU proposal does not satisfy these criteria. As a replacement to the Keller in what is arguably a mature industry, the PSU project's long-term job generating potential is probably limited. A firm verdict on the project's riskiness cannot be rendered until a robust financial analysis is undertaken. That said, PSU's recent confusing \$44 million funding request does not inspire confidence. Virginia Ehelebe	Yes	09/02/26 4:48 PM
112	Kalman C. Toth, Ph.D., P.Eng.	Oppose	I support the Keller Affordable Fix and oppose the dual project. The Keller project is well funded while leveraging the existing local parking and business infrastructure. Keller Reimagined should be a stand-alone priority for revitalizing downtown.	No	09/02/26 5:34 PM
113	Pat Kaczmarek	Oppose	Dear City Council Members, I am a citizen and property owner in Portland, Oregon. I am writing to ask that the city council reject the city's proposal for a new Broadway theater on the PSU campus. After years of debate, there is strong grassroots opposition to this costly and unnecessary plan. The city council should reject this idea and pursue a more affordable, practical alternative to plan for upgrades to the Keller Auditorium. There is a lack of available funding, questionable market demand and no mandate for this costly investment at a time when our city is facing a climate emergency that will require massive investments to head off the extreme impacts of global warming, and put in place the necessary mitigation measures to protect our citizens and our environment from climate threats that are already anticipated to grow over the coming decades. It does not make sense to move Portland's largest theater out of downtown and away from an excellent location near to its iconic fountain and the neighborhood of housing, hotels, restaurants and parking that was purposely planned and built around it. The proposed location for a new theater is further away from these amenities and lacks adequate access. Please reject this poorly conceived proposal and move forward with plans that will strengthen our city into the future, not weigh it down with poorly thought out and unnecessary future obligations to our limited resources. Yours, Pat Kaczmarek	No	09/02/26 6:10 PM

WRITTEN TESTIMONY: Agenda Item 2026-270

Like other members of the Concerned Citizens group, I urge you to delay a decision on a future performing arts center. I support a delay even though I recognize large construction projects can help revive our city's listless economy. The city's fiscal constraints coupled with the size of our capital maintenance backlog, however, argue for setting a high bar for new projects. To merit investment of city time and money, projects should boost the city's long-term growth potential and involve minimal downside risks. The PSU proposal does not satisfy these criteria. As a replacement to the Keller in what is arguably a mature industry, the PSU project's long-term job generating potential is probably limited. A firm verdict on the project's riskiness cannot be rendered until a robust financial analysis is undertaken. That said, PSU's recent confusing \$44 million funding request does not inspire confidence.

Virginia Ehelebe

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
114	Luisa Adrianzen Guyer	Oppose	September 1, 2026 Dear Mayor and City Council, I'm writing to ask you not to move forward with the PSU project and to instead focus on protecting and investing in The Keller Auditorium. I'm concerned that this resolution starts the city down an expensive path without a clear funding plan, without real evidence that the market can support it, and without any meaningful guarantee that The Keller and the surrounding downtown area will be protected. The first issue is cost. This proposal seems to set the city up for nearly \$1 billion in spending for two new theaters, a parking garage, a hotel near PSU, and some version of a renovated Keller. Portland does not have that money, and taxpayers should not be asked to take on a project this large and uncertain when there are so many other urgent needs. I'm also not convinced there is a real plan behind this. The resolution seems to assume there will be demand for a smaller, renovated Keller theater, but I have not seen studies that support that assumption. At the same time, our current city-owned theaters are underused and new private venues are already being built. That makes it hard to understand why the city would move ahead with another major performing arts project without much stronger evidence. Most importantly, I do not see a guarantee for The Keller. Once new theaters, parking, and hotel development are built near PSU, what happens to The Keller, the fountain, and that part of downtown? I worry that the city could end up leaving another empty or neglected civic space in the middle of downtown for years, or even decades. There is a more practical option. Broadway Across America's recent commitment to seven more years of shows at The Keller shows that the venue still has value and a future. Rather than committing to a project the city cannot afford, Portland should invest in the building it already owns. A focused investment of \$15 million over the next five years for improvements and deferred maintenance would help keep The Keller working and economically successful for the next decade. Please do not advance the PSU project. I urge you to choose the more responsible path: fix and protect The Keller now, keep this cultural asset downtown, and avoid committing Portland to an expensive project without a clear need or funding plan. Sincerely, Luisa Adrianzen Guyer	Yes	09/02/26 6:31 PM
115	Janet Schaeffer	Oppose	I don't understand why the city would commit to a new facility for Broadway productions and other major performances that is not downtown when the Keller has the preferred site, incorporating Forecourt Fountain. Upgrading the Keller can be done in stages without losing Broadway production revenue. With all the city's financial struggles, why would you commit to the unknown cost of a brand new hall when we already have one that turns a profit.	No	09/02/26 6:39 PM
116	Xavier D. Stickler, PSU Student, Downtown Neighborhood Association	Oppose		Yes	09/02/26 6:51 PM
117	Stefee Knudsen	Support	As a native Portlander, we need a fully functional performing arts center that can handle the requirements of international caliber shows. Our current Keller is not only structurally unsafe, but woefully undersized to attract or support these shows, and so Portland is consistently passed by! While we all feel nostalgia for the current location and have memories in this space, we need to evolve and grow. Attempting to renovate the existing facility will have disastrous consequences to our arts community, shutting down their one significant venue for 2+ years, and after which it still will not have the ability to support Broadway shows. That is just a waste of taxpayer money and an opportunity. Yes, we need to build *something* in that location to support surrounding businesses and street life. So do it right. The proposed facility at the PSU location is what we need as a city, then build something else that can support our civic and cultural needs in old Keller location - if possible, something that brings life to the streets during the days and evenings! Let's embrace this once in a generation opportunity to be smart about how we invest our time, our money, and our city's space to make two landmarks for Portland and is the right long-term plan.	No	09/02/26 8:52 PM

September 1, 2026

Subject: Testimony in Support of The Keller and Opposition to the PSU Project

Dear Mayor and City Council,

I'm writing to ask you not to move forward with the PSU project and to instead focus on protecting and investing in The Keller Auditorium. I'm concerned that this resolution starts the city down an expensive path without a clear funding plan, without real evidence that the market can support it, and without any meaningful guarantee that The Keller and the surrounding downtown area will be protected.

The first issue is cost. This proposal seems to set the city up for nearly \$1 billion in spending for two new theaters, a parking garage, a hotel near PSU, and some version of a renovated Keller. Portland does not have that money, and taxpayers should not be asked to take on a project this large and uncertain when there are so many other urgent needs.

I'm also not convinced there is a real plan behind this. The resolution seems to assume there will be demand for a smaller, renovated Keller theater, but I have not seen studies that support that assumption. At the same time, our current city-owned theaters are underused and new private venues are already being built. That makes it hard to understand why the city would move ahead with another major performing arts project without much stronger evidence.

Most importantly, I do not see a guarantee for The Keller. Once new theaters, parking, and hotel development are built near PSU, what happens to The Keller, the fountain, and that part of downtown? I worry that the city could end up leaving another empty or neglected civic space in the middle of downtown for years, or even decades.

There is a more practical option. Broadway Across America's recent commitment to seven more years of shows at The Keller shows that the venue still has value and a future. Rather than committing to a project the city cannot afford, Portland should invest in the building it already owns. A focused investment of \$15 million over the next five years for improvements and deferred maintenance would help keep The Keller working and economically successful for the next decade.

Please do not advance the PSU project. I urge you to choose the more responsible path: fix and protect The Keller now, keep this cultural asset downtown, and avoid committing Portland to an expensive project without a clear need or funding plan.

Sincerely,
Luisa Adrianzen Guyer

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Written Testimony of Xavier D. Stickler
Before Portland City Council - September 3rd, 2026
concerning the future of the Keller Auditorium
& Proposed Performing Arts & Culture Center at PSU

Councilors,

My name is Xavier D. Stickler, and I am a student at PSU, the Vice President of the Downtown Neighborhood Association, and a life-long lover of the performing arts. As such, I am intimately familiar with the needs of the University, those of the Downtown community, and the struggles faced by actors and performing arts technicians. I want to see Portland's arts community thrive, and I believe that this requires robust public investment. But I cannot support the resolution before you today, and I respectfully urge you to vote 'no' on the proposal before you.

PSU has spoken a lot about vision. As an aspiring urban planner, I understand the value of visionary thinking. But in these circumstances, I'm afraid a reality check is urgently required: we simply do not have the money for any aspect of the program this resolution seeks to establish.

While it's easy to commit to investigating funding mechanisms later on, once we have the exact project costs that this resolution directs staff and PSU to produce, we must be honest: those costs will be in the hundreds of millions of dollars. Furthering this resolution may seem like a no-cash commitment, but it commits the City to a project with no viability; it diverts us onto a highway with an endpoint that is neither discernable nor desirable.

It pains me to say this, but we do not have the resources to complete the renovation of the Keller while maintaining it at a 3,000 seat capacity—estimated to cost the City between \$150 to 200 million, and still the cheapest option ever considered in the course of this process. This means that we certainly don't have the estimated

\$447,000,000 required to plan, design, develop, and construct a new venue at PSU, as this proposal advocates: i.e., more than double what it would cost the City to keep the Keller. And it also means that we absolutely do not have the money to pursue the scheme set forth in this resolution: the development of a new PSU theater, as well as a renovation of the Keller into a smaller theatre, amounting to a commitment of nearly \$1,000,000,000 (one billion dollars). We simply cannot afford this. With the utmost respect, it is a boondoggle in the making.

Unfortunately, this resolution contemplates a whole lot of dollars and very little sense.

While it's true we will eventually need a 21st-century Keller, it makes no sense to prioritize PSU's project in the context of the City's many more critical needs, at a time when transit is being slashed, when essential employees are being let go from both the City and PSU, and when our backlog of public infrastructure maintenance is ballooning. It makes no sense to add a whole new theater to the City's portfolio—especially while simultaneously renovating what is currently a profit-generating Keller into a venue with no demonstrated market demand, which will need significant public subsidies, at a smaller size, and with a cost that would very nearly equal what it would take to maintain the Keller at 3,000 seats. It makes no sense for PSU (an institution whose enrollment is declining, which is laying off my instructors, and where one in five students are housing insecure or homeless) to prioritize a foray into showbusiness.

So, what *does* make sense? What *can* we afford? The only responsible choice here for Council is the "Affordable Fix"—finding the \$10-15 million needed to keep the Keller in a state of good repair for the next ten years. These repairs will provide needed electrical, mechanical, and architectural system upgrades critical to supporting the arts environment that we know to work, we know to be profitable, and we know must continue regardless of construction at PSU. Broadway Across America has already renewed their contract at the Keller through 2033. The proposed repairs require no

shutdown of the Keller, while allowing Broadway to finish out its contracted tenure at the Keller.

Please: vote 'no' on this resolution. Reject yet another megaproject we cannot afford. Give the economy a chance to recover, for PSU to stabilize, for the bond market to improve, and for us to actually study the feasibility of a temporary venue to be erected during the Keller renovation (which could eliminate the need for a new venue entirely). Only when this is done will it be the right time to pursue a vision for the future. And so I urge you to make the difficult choice to vote 'no' on this resolution. A 'no' vote is not a vote in opposition to the arts: it is a vote to preserve a piece of Portland's architectural and artistic heritage, to commit to what works for our city, and to reject pie-in-the-sky visions that come at the expense of established successes. Thank you.

118

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Emily Wilson	Support	To the Portland City Council, I am writing in strong support of building a new performing arts center on PSU's proposed site rather than renovating the existing Keller Auditorium. Portland rarely gets the chance to intentionally create a civic landmark, and this is one of them. Renovating the Keller in place means closing it for roughly two years, a devastating gap for the artists, technicians, and businesses who depend on it, and a real risk to the Broadway revenue that funds much of Portland's Centers for the Arts' operating budget. Building new lets the Keller stay open while it happens. A new site also gives room for the back-of-house, rehearsal, and production space a Broadway-capable venue needs but the Keller's footprint can't provide, with more predictable scope, cost, and seismic performance than a constrained retrofit. A project like this can also anchor downtown and, built in mass timber, be something distinctly Portland. Sincerely, Emily Wilson	No	09/02/26 8:53 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
119 Tom Bugas	Oppose	September 2, 2026 City Council Portland, Oregon Dear Councilors, I'm writing to you concerning the issue of the operation and management of the Portland's Centers for the Arts, P'5. While now retired, I worked for over 40 years at P'5 as both a union stagehand with the International Alliance of Stage Employees (IATSE) and in management for the Operations Department, retiring as the Assistant Director of Operations. This gave me a unique view, both as laborer and manager, of the operational use of the theaters, committed to Portland's, the clients of the venues and the talented people who work there in all departments of the venues. My employment history at the venues included working under the aegis of the City of Portland, the Metropolitan Exposition Recreation Commission (MERC) and Metro as the political winds dictated shift of management for the venues. Now, with another sea change of elected managers in both Metro and the City there is discussion again of reassigning operational management of the venues. As each previous change took place the employees of the venues suffered under changes in management style, changes in wages and benefits, rules and expectations, while continuing to make their best efforts to provide superior service to the citizen taxpayers, theater clients and patrons. Those making decisions about all the employees of the theaters were never taking into account the institutional knowledge, dedication and historical commitment of the staff. One example of that commitment is that the stagehands of IATSE have been employed by the City of Portland at the Keller continuously since it opened as the Portland Civic Auditorium in 1917. Your consideration of privatizing management of Portland's at a time when Metro has already abdicated their responsibilities, which they publicly wrested from MERC, is a further insult to your dedicated staff. Many on the staff at every level, from department directors to custodians, ushers, stationary engineers and stagehands have spent their professional lives being of service to the citizens of Portland. Abandoning the staff without recognition of their industry experience and dedication to the taxpayers is not only short sighted it would guarantee a reduction in efficient operation of the venues while offering financial gain only to whomever might gain privatized management. I urge the city council to reconsider evading responsibility for the Portland's venues. Instead it is time that, as owners of the venues, you realize your responsibility to the taxpayers and to your dedicated staff by taking the proper steps to manage the publicly owned venues only for the community good and not for the profit of some private operator. While it might seem momentarily expedient to eschew responsibility for the venues, handing them over to private operators for their own profit would be a great disservice to the people of Portland. The taxpayers deserve more. Please do the right thing and retain City of Portland management control of Portland's Centers for the Arts, providing continued public employment for all the dedicated Portland's staff who work there. The Portland's staff deserve recognition for their professionalism and dedication, the public deserves committed, responsible management from City Council. Thank you, Tom Bugas bluebugtom@icloud.com	No	09/02/26 9:11 PM
120 Dan Vizzini	Oppose	Written Testimony is attached. It's worth a good read.	Yes	09/02/26 9:46 PM
121 Beth Warner	Oppose	No! No! No! Although a Performing Arts Venue at PSU sounds wonderful, it's pie-in-the-sky without a budget and funding plan. A remodel of the Keller is much more logical and something the City can support. PSU has had to close down departments and lay off professors because of budget woes. Is this really the right time to be proposing a multi-million project? The City needs to finalize their plans with the Moda Center and honor their budget commitments before they commit funds to the PSU project.	No	09/02/26 10:38 PM

**Testimony presented to the Portland City Council
with regard City Council Document Number 2026-270
September 3, 2026**

Accept the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts recommendations to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University, and initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium (Resolution)

City Councilors:

The resolution before you today is a word salad of mind-numbing proportions. May I suggest that you simplify your deliberations by considering the following summary of the document's resolves. Therein lies the meat of the issues to be decided. Allow me to offer the following summary and conclude with a short list of observations.

Council resolves and commitments:

In summary, Council continues to support PSU's planning and pre-development efforts BUT does not intend to authorize or commit any new city financial resources to the proposed center until substantially more research, analysis and planning is completed and presented for review and approval.

Here are the details:

1. support for advancing planning and pre-development for a potential new City-owned approximately 3,000-seat Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University.
2. refrain from taking action to authorize, appropriate, or commit City funds for development or construction of the proposed Portland State University venue beyond funding previously authorized by City Council, including the following resolves:
 - a. refrain from any agreement that financially obligates the City to development or construction of the proposed Portland State University venue until Council considers and approves a resolution containing a detailed financial plan as described in this resolution.
 - b. the Project Commitment Agreement, described in this resolution, shall not obligate the City to provide capital funding or otherwise financially commit the City to development or construction of the project without subsequent City Council approval.
3. continue programming, including Broadway shows, and City investment at the Keller Auditorium to avoid economic losses, upgrade the facility, and continue cultural activity.
4. identify and pursue funding sources, where feasible, to support implementation of an adopted plan for the future of Keller Auditorium, including potential funding from City Council, the State Legislature, Metro, the federal government, and other appropriate sources.

Council directives to the Deputy City Administrator:

In summary, Council directs the Deputy City Administrator to organize a project team and steering committee to produce the following: (1) a detailed financial plan; (2) a comprehensive philanthropic strategy; and (3) a Project Commitment Agreement. In addition, the DCA is directed to initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium.

Here are the details:

1. stand up a staff project team of technical experts with Portland State University to complete pre-development functions.
2. designate a pre-development steering committee to participate in the process as needed.
3. provide a clear understanding of the City's obligations and costs for the project.
4. develop a detailed financial plan, including
 - a. a fully defined capital stack.
 - b. total estimated project cost.
 - c. proposed City contribution and funding sources.
 - d. confirmed and anticipated funding from other public and private partners.
 - e. anticipated ongoing City operating and maintenance obligations.
 - f. and material financial risks.
5. develop a Project Commitment Agreement with Portland State University by December 1, 2026, that includes the following elements
 - a. the scope, schedule, and governance framework for the project;
 - b. a shared commitment between the City and Portland State University to develop a proposed full capital funding strategy,
 - c. affirmation that the agreement does not obligate the City to provide capital funding or otherwise financially commit the City to development or construction of the project without subsequent City Council approval.
6. direct a cohesive, comprehensive philanthropic strategy; and collaborate with the Portland State University Foundation in its role as lead philanthropic strategist to identify and secure necessary funding.
7. direct staff to initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium, to be conducted in tandem with the Portland State University 3000-seat venue. This will include conducting community engagement, market study, financial analysis, and initial design work to determine feasibility as a renovated 1,200 to 1,800-seat performing arts venue.
8. provide input into the initial phases of the project and project construction management direction.

Observations:

1. The entire tone of the resolves leaves the reader with the impression that city support for the project is a fait accompli, and the exhaustive list of directives to the DCA are merely intended to give the impression of thoroughness, thoughtfulness, transparency and accountability. The text is devoid of clauses that condition action by the DCA on a "GO" decision by Council on project funding. Perhaps the resolves should exclude all tasks that would be undertaken once a "GO" decision is made and then include those directives in that future resolution.
2. The resolves imply a timetable but fails to explicitly state any for the various tasks. The only deadline is set for the Project Commitment Agreement. The date of December 1, 2026, seems impossibly short to allow for the DCA to complete his tasks in time to inform the drafting, review and Council approval of the agreement. It seems like that one deadline is meant to comply with the conditions of the state's bond sale to subsidize the project. Perhaps the cart is before the horse here.

3. The DCA's tasks are extensive and yet there are no specifics about the city resources that must be expended to produce the deliverables. The published statement of financial and budgetary impacts is not credible unless one or more of the following conditions exist: (1) the work will be incorporated in the existing workloads of city staff and performed over an extended time period to minimize impacts on other staff responsibilities; (2) the work will be prioritized over existing work assignments at the expense of those tasks and work products; (3) most of the work will be performed by PSU-funded staff with minimal involvement of city staff; or the quality of the research and analysis for the financial plan will be lacking and reflect a rushed and reverse-engineered product for Council approval.
4. One final observation. This one regards the city's evolving governance structure. Where is the city administrator in this entire endeavor? Why aren't the resolution's directives being made to the city administrator? Isn't it the city administrator's charter responsibility to direct the work identified in the resolution? Not that it seems to matter to the drafters or the council's committee, but taxpayers are paying a lot of money for the city's governance structure for some reason.

Thank you for your kind consideration.

Dan Vizzini
Public Policy Advisory

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED that this resolution with the attached Exhibits A-E is accepted by the City Council; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Council support advancing planning and pre-development for a potential new City-owned approximately 3,000-seat Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University at 310/330 SW Lincoln Street, with a goal of opening in 2030, capitalizing on the state's funding commitment of \$137.5 million, public private partnerships, and a future forward vision that expands Portland's arts ecosystem, subject to future City Council review and approval of the project's financial plan, capital funding strategy, and City financial obligations; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Deputy City Administrator is directed to stand up a staff project team of technical experts with Portland State University to complete pre-development functions, including but not limited to: develop a detailed financial plan with a fully defined capital stack, funding timelines, and operations and maintenance responsibilities that provides a clear understanding of the City's obligations and costs for the project; direct a cohesive, comprehensive philanthropic strategy, collaborate with the Portland State University Foundation in its role as lead philanthropic strategist, and work together to identify and secure necessary funding; provide input into the initial phases of the project and project construction management direction; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that adoption of this resolution does not authorize, appropriate, or commit City funds for development or construction of the proposed Portland State University venue beyond funding previously authorized by City Council; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that prior to execution of any agreement that financially obligates the City to development or construction of the proposed Portland State University venue, the Deputy City Administrator shall return to City Council with the detailed financial plan described in this resolution, including a fully defined capital stack, total estimated project cost, proposed City contribution and funding sources, confirmed and anticipated funding from other public and private partners, anticipated ongoing City operating and maintenance obligations, and material financial risks, for City Council review and approval.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Deputy City Administrator is directed to develop a Project Commitment Agreement with Portland State University by December 1, 2026, that establishes the scope, schedule, and governance framework for the project and a shared commitment between the City and Portland State University to develop a proposed full capital funding strategy, provided that the Project Commitment Agreement shall not obligate the City to provide capital funding or otherwise financially commit the City to development or construction of the project without subsequent City Council approval; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Deputy City Administrator is directed to designate a pre-development steering committee to participate in the process as needed; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that while development of a new Broadway-capable venue at Portland State University is ongoing, programming, including Broadway shows, and City investment will continue at the Keller Auditorium to avoid economic losses, upgrade the facility, and continue cultural activity; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City will identify and pursue funding sources, where feasible, to support implementation of an adopted plan for the future of Keller Auditorium, including potential funding from City Council, the State Legislature, Metro, the federal government, and other appropriate sources.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Deputy City Administrator is directed to direct staff to initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium, to be conducted in tandem with the Portland State University 3000-seat venue. This will include conducting community engagement, market study, financial analysis, and initial design work to determine feasibility as a renovated 1,200 to 1,800-seat performing arts venue.

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
122 Tom Reichert	Oppose	PDX council written testimony: Tom Reichert PhD/MD Former Head of Biomedical Engineering at C-MU; and resident of Harrison Towers for the last 9 years. Council has recently brought forward plans, to develop an amphitheater (The Bowl) and possibly a wider swath of the Tom McCall waterfront park. A facilitating element for this development would be an East/West Connector utilizing a pair of streets with opposing directionality (e.g. Market and Clay). Incentives for additional development on/around this Connector are expected. The Keller Auditorium (KA) occupies an entire block between 2nd and 3rd Avenues within or adjacent to such Connectors. The KA is generally credited with stimulating and sustaining many restaurant and shopping opportunities in its surround. However, it was constructed with no appreciation of the site's seismic liability. With ~1 million satisfied theater-goers per year, a seismic renovation of KA seems an obvious candidate for maintenance and redevelopment as a pivotal element in the revival of Downtown Portland. The Keller fountain, across the street from KA, is the northern terminus of the Halprin Open Sequence, a 9-block landscaping marvel which was named, on its 60th anniversary (in 2025), "the best urban renewal development in the 20th Century...in the world!" This new notoriety augments the argument for maintaining and remodeling KA. Contemporaneous development of the Bowl (and possibly more of the Willamette waterfront) suggests that renovation of the KA is both timely and synergistic. The Halprin Open Sequence extends southward from the KA for nine blocks. Business development in the periphery obviously tapers south of the only roadway which pierces The Sequence, Harrison St. There are very few enterprises in the area south of Lincoln St. PSU has proposed an alternative to seismically renovating the KA. The site is the three blocks between 1st and 4th avenues south of Lincoln St. This site adjoins the American Plaza condominiums; and now houses the University Hotel. Construction of an alternative venue to the KA, at the edge of the screaming 405 freeway, will require massive concrete complexity, a box-within-a-box structure with intra-box acoustic isolators; and multi-layered glass for any light-piercing aspects to reduce the penetration of external noise to a level which does not affect the performances. Broadway-type performances rely heavily on extreme dynamic range. Whispers, solo acoustic instruments and pauses in dialogue will be overwhelmed if any of the adjacent highway sounds "leak" inside. Lastly, there must be a recognition that the exterior of such a building will be subject to 24/7 exposure to very high sound levels (>75dba). The 8-hour Rule is that sustained exposure to sound levels in the periphery of a high-frequency highway (and measured as such at the PSU site) can cause permanent, irreversible hearing damage, in as little as 8 hours of exposure. Conservatively, the surround for a building at the southern aspect of the PSU site should not invite even a single 8-hour usage; and it is not clear whether serial shorter exposures are equivalent. It is plausible that even waiting in very long lines may be injurious to one's acoustic health. In contrast, the KA exterior is already time-tested and provides no opportunity for this phenomenon. Hopefully, the PDX council is aware of the especial challenges the PSU site proffers as a replacement for the KA. To this observer, the PSU project is not well characterized; but appears to be the wrong solution in the wrong location. -It offers no synergy, is disastrous financially; and is plausibly an acoustic nightmare for attendees. My advice: -1. Fix the Keller as an element in a mega-project to develop the marvelous Tom McCall waterfront -2. . Sell hard the, now world famous, Halprin Open Sequence. Propose an international symposium to guide maintenance and management of architectural gems worldwide.	No	09/02/26 10:46 PM
123 Anonymous	Oppose	We oppose spending any more public funds to advance the design of a new PSU venue. Please vote "no". A "yes" vote will be fiscally irresponsible in such tight budget times. The city is not even maintaining the cultural venues we have. It's also too soon to assess the impact of 2 new private venues which will absorb demand. Finally, the "co-op" operational plan has not been tried or tested and could become a long-term tax dollar drain. Renovating the Keller is a much better option.	No	09/02/26 10:49 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Katherine Goeddel	Oppose	Written Testimony: Agenda Item 2026-270 Like other Concerned Citizens, I urge you to vote no on Agenda Item 2026-270 and delay this decision. Portland faces serious financial constraints and an enormous backlog of maintenance needs. Those realities demand that the City set a very high bar before committing its limited resources to another major capital project. The Keller Auditorium continues to attract approximately 400,000 people downtown each year. A substantially more affordable path is available: make the improvements needed to keep the Keller safe, functional, and capable of hosting Broadway productions. Council Vice President Clark previously described the City's history as "chasing bright shiny objects as opposed to taking care of what we have." I agree. Before committing City resources to an expensive new facility, Portland should take care of the valuable buildings and infrastructure it already owns. Please pause this process, fully evaluate the affordable Keller alternative, and put the City's existing responsibilities first. Vote no on Item 2026-270.	No	09/02/26 11:04 PM
J R Merrick AIA	Oppose	Subject: Agenda Item 2026-270 Vote to Advance the PSU Arts Center Dear City Council, Our City is currently the proud owner of five performing arts venues plus the Moda Center. With the exception of the Keller Auditorium, the P5 are not financially viable. The Keller is functioning at about 40% capacity and is subsidizing the other P4. At a time of gloomy budgets and heavily taxed property owners, you are being pressed to further invest in a facility that obligates Portland residents to shoulder debt for a much larger multiuse P6. The underlying justifications for the new large capacity arts complex are largely aspirational and lacking a financial pro-forma and specifically one that considers both the existing P5 and the additional hall. I strongly support the value of quality venues for performing arts and can envision the day in the somewhat distant future when the audience demand and the quality of the existing facilities requires a thorough reassessment. We will not know if the current mismanagement of the P5 is an old story until the new management team is selected next June and has a year by which to judge. Meanwhile the time is now to focus on the maintenance and improved utilization and economics of the P5 and specifically the \$15M needed during the next 5 years to make improvements to the Keller. Place this concept on hold for 5 years and then reconsider. With Appreciation for your attention, Rod Merrick, AIA 3627 SE Cooper St Portland 97202	Yes	09/03/26 12:11 AM
Matthew Touzet	Support	Please support 2026-270 for the new Performing Arts + Culture Center at PSU. The Keller is a beloved landmark, but its site is too constrained to meet the production, accessibility, and backstage needs of a Broadway-capable theater. Renovating around those limits means unpredictable costs for an outcome that still falls short. Portland's arts and music community deserves a venue built for today's needs, not retrofitted toward them. Please vote yes.	No	09/03/26 7:30 AM

Subject: Agenda Item 2026-270 Vote to Advance the PSU Arts Center

Dear City Council,

Our City is currently the proud owner of five performing arts venues plus the Moda Center. With the exception of the Keller Auditorium, the P5 are not financially viable. The Keller is functioning at about 40% capacity and is subsidizing the other P4.

At a time of gloomy budgets and heavily taxed property owners, you are being pressed to further invest in a facility that obligates Portland residents to shoulder debt for a much larger multiuse P6. The underlying justifications for the new large capacity arts complex are largely aspirational and lacking a financial pro-forma and specifically one that considers both the existing P5 and the additional hall.

I strongly support the value of quality venues for performing arts and can envision the day in the somewhat distant future when the audience demand and the quality of the existing facilities requires a thorough reassessment. We will not know if the current mismanagement of the P5 is an old story until the new management team is selected next June and has a year by which to judge.

Meanwhile the time is now to focus on the maintenance and improved utilization and economics of the P5 and specifically the \$15M needed during the next 5 years to make improvements to the Keller. Place this concept on hold for 5 years and then reconsider.

With Appreciation for your attention,

Rod Merrick, AIA
3627 SE Cooper St
Portland 97202

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Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Portland Downtown Neighborhood Association	Oppose	I am LaJune Thorson, President of the Downtown Neighborhood Association. Thank you for this opportunity to speak on behalf of the DNA. While we appreciate improvements to the Resolution of the Avalos and Clark/Zimmerman amendments, we are asking you to vote No. •Before taking on another big project let's take stock of what we already own. •Let's figure out whether the city can support a new venue. •Let's look at all our current venues and the improvements and maintenance each needs. We've neglected these assets long enough. Let's develop a maintenance strategy. •And Let's look for ways to improve the revenue potential of each venue through new management of P'5. Only then should we even contemplate building a new performing arts center. There are other reasons why this is a bad idea: 1.The City's loss of decision-making autonomy in the commercial condominium financial structure. Compare that with the control the City has by virtue of owning the Keller and the land outright. PSU plans to use the Vanport Commercial Condominium model for the proposed performing arts center. 2.The real possibility that the Keller will become another subsidized venue instead of the profit generator it is now. 3.The financial losses to the hotels, garages, restaurants, bars, and coffee shops near the Keller if those services are replicated a few blocks away. These are real businesses and real jobs. This is real money we're talking about with real tradeoffs. We're making drastic cuts in the City's budget. We're cutting basic city services! And dare I mention the impending Moda Center decision. Let's not be distracted by the state money. That's real money too. The threat of loss of state money is not a reason to commit millions more dollars for something we don't need. Support the Affordable Fix. Make the necessary improvements at the Keller without a shutdown and the Keller will serve us for many more years. Taxpayers are paying attention and beginning to see the real costs and tradeoffs of this commitment. Please show us--the taxpayers---you can be good stewards of our money. Vote No. Support the Affordable Fix.	No	09/03/26 7:32 AM
Portland Downtown Neighborhood Association	Oppose	I am LaJune Thorson, President of the Downtown Neighborhood Association. While we appreciate improvements to the Resolution of the Avalos and Clark/Zimmerman amendments, we are asking you to vote No. •Before taking on another big project let's take stock of what we already own. •Let's figure out whether the city can support a new venue. •Let's look at all our current venues and the improvements and maintenance each needs. We've neglected these assets long enough. Let's develop a maintenance strategy. •And Let's look for ways to improve the revenue potential of each venue through new management of P'5. Only then should we even contemplate building a new performing arts center. There are other reasons why this is a bad idea: 1.The City's loss of decision-making autonomy in the commercial condominium financial structure. Compare that with the control the City has by virtue of owning the Keller and the land outright. If you don't know what this is about, do some research on the Vanport building. 2.The real possibility that the Keller will become another subsidized venue instead of the profit generator it is now. 3.The financial losses to the hotels, garages, restaurants, bars, and coffee shops near the Keller if those services are replicated a few blocks away. These are real businesses and real jobs. This is real money we're talking about with real tradeoffs. We're making drastic cuts in the City's budget. !We're cutting basic city services. And dare I mention the impending Moda Center decision. Let's not be distracted by the state money. That's real money too. The threat of loss of state money is not a reason to commit millions more dollars for something we don't need. Support the Affordable Fix. Make the necessary improvements at the Keller without a shut down and the Keller will serve us for many more years. Taxpayers are paying attention and beginning to see the real costs and tradeoffs of this commitment. Please show us--the taxpayers---you can be good stewards of our money. Vote No. Support the Affordable Fix.	No	09/03/26 7:43 AM
Vern William Harpole	Oppose	PSU has no capability of financing or running a for profit entertainment venue. PSU has an auditorium in their performing arts building that is appropriate for their small number of performing arts majors. please keep PSU in the Education business. it is struggling with just that.	No	09/03/26 9:13 AM

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Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Jessie Vargo	Support	I support the Performing Arts + Culture Center at Portland State University to spark the next generation of Portland's arts, performance, and music scene in a way that other venues cannot. The new PSU center will integrate accessibility from the onset of the design, creating a welcome and safe space for all, further broadening the reach of performing arts in our city. Often retrofitting existing buildings to "accommodate" our disabled community can feel like an afterthought. As larger corporate performance venues enter Portland, the PSU project represents a long-term reinvestment going directly into our community instead of going to huge global corporations like LiveNation. Portland has been losing smaller venue spaces for local artists and musicians, while also lacking the capability to host Broadway scale performances. The city needs a venue that can provide both: a space where local artists can thrive, and where Broadway scale productions can perform safely and efficiently. I support a Portland-owned and Portland-developed performance center that meets modern needs for accessibility and safety while serving local artists, musicians, audiences, and major touring productions alike.	No	09/03/26 9:54 AM
Anonymous	Oppose	Support the Keller first and foremost	No	09/03/26 9:55 AM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Columbia Pacific Building & Construction Trades Council	Support	The Columbia Pacific Building Trades Council is in support of the proposed PSU Performing arts project. We proudly represent over 20,000 construction professionals across 22 local unions and 14 of the 15 Building Trades Crafts in the Portland Metropolitan and Southwest Washington region. We are proud to give public support to the proposed 4-acre development of Portland State University's (PSU) new Performing Arts venue and hotel development. We are happy to announce that PSU and the Columbia Pacific Building Trades Council reached an agreement to ensure the PSU-owned portions of this project will have excellent labor standards ensuring our community will reach maximum return on their investment to this project. This project will create an estimated 2,000 construction jobs and 400 permanent jobs including operations and maintenance that many of our affiliates also represent. It will also help activate seven blocks of developable proximate property with spillover investment potential of around \$1 billion (beyond the Center construction). We have an opportunity to put Portland back on the map as a destination, and that could start with this project. The fact that we have a Project Workforce Development Agreement with PSU, which they proactively negotiated with our council, is indicative of a future-focused visionary commitment to collaboratively shaping the future of downtown Portland. This project is unlike any other the City of Portland has considered in recent years. It has the potential to increase foot traffic downtown and put cranes in the air for a decade to come, all while advancing a commitment to workforce development, business development, and labor engagement: values I know this committee shares. At the council, we work with a lot of developers, but very few are like PSU. PSU shares our commitment to working with high-road contractors, advancing minority- women- emerging- veteran- and small/emerging businesses, and they care about the workers putting their sweat into building this campus of the future. With PSU's commitment to strong labor standards, it opens the door for another useful tool like Project Labor Agreements (PLAs). Many well-known and recent studies have shown PLAs expand local hire and opportunities to workers from disadvantaged backgrounds and our recent agreement offers this as an option to meet their already strong standards. PLAs grow the number of registered apprentices, and many include language hiring local workers and workers from disadvantaged backgrounds (Ormiston & Duncan, 2022). From 1995 to 2010, an estimated 75% of PLAs promoted the hiring of veterans, 56% required hiring women and people of color, and 38% set local hiring goals (Figueroa, Grabelsky, & Lamare, 2011). It should be noted that agreements like the RWEA and the Project Workforce Development Agreement with PSU are not only great at providing opportunities for underserved populations, they can also ensure there is a mechanism for accountability through partnership that is invaluable to the communities they serve. In closing, The Building Trades believes that public contracting is a benefit to the community and needs to ensure hard working women and men in our communities are paid their fair share and treated with dignity and respect through safe and healthful workplaces in all industries not limited to construction but also in operation of these types of facilities; this project will do exactly that. We recognize that PSU is not only an excellent source for higher education, however, an excellent partner in the community. We are excited to work collaboratively with their leadership team to get this project over the finish line. Thank you for your time and consideration, Randall Friesen Executive Director, Columbia Pacific Building & Construction Trades Council	Yes	09/03/26 10:20 AM
SMILE	Oppose	Portland needs to care for what it has and stop chasing shiny objects that it has not money to pursue realistically. It's the definition of provincial that a city like Portland keeps trying to become a major player with a major league baseball team, or a new performing arts center rather than take care of what it already has. Portland has a troubling history of that, which is one reason the city finances are in such a shambles. Upgrade the Keller. Stop chasing the shiny object of a new and unneeded performing arts center, for which there is no money and little chance of obtaining it. Take care of the business at hand. Sincerely, Bryce R Butler 2010 SE Bybee Blvd Portland, OR 97202SMILE	No	09/03/26 10:32 AM



9/03/26

Re: Portland City Council – PSU Performing Arts

Council President Dunphy, Vice President Clark, and Council Members,

For the record my name is Randall Friesen, Executive Director of the Columbia Pacific Building and Construction Trades Council. The Columbia Pacific Building Trades Council proudly represents over 20,000 construction professionals across 22 local unions and 14 of the 15 Building Trades Crafts in the Portland Metropolitan and Southwest Washington region.

We are proud to give public support to the proposed 4-acre development of Portland State University's (PSU) new Performing Arts venue and hotel development. We are happy to announce that PSU and the Columbia Pacific Building Trades Council reached an agreement to ensure the PSU-owned portions of this project will have excellent labor standards ensuring our community will reach maximum return on their investment to this project.

This project will create an estimated 2,000 construction jobs and 400 permanent jobs including operations and maintenance that many of our affiliates also represent. It will also help activate seven blocks of developable proximate property with spillover investment potential of around \$1 billion (beyond the Center construction). We have an opportunity to put Portland back on the map as a destination, and that could start with this project. The fact that we have a Project Workforce Development Agreement with PSU, which they proactively negotiated with our council, is indicative of a future-focused visionary commitment to collaboratively shaping the future of downtown Portland.

This project is unlike any other the City of Portland has considered in recent years. It has the potential to increase foot traffic downtown and put cranes in the air for a decade to come, all while advancing a commitment to workforce development, business development, and labor engagement: values I know this committee shares.

At the council, we work with a lot of developers, but very few are like PSU. PSU shares our commitment to working with high-road contractors, advancing minority- women- emerging- veteran- and small/emerging businesses, and they care about the workers putting their sweat into building this campus of the future.

With PSU's commitment to strong labor standards, it opens the door for another useful tool like Project Labor Agreements (PLAs). Many well-known and recent studies have shown PLAs expand local hire and opportunities to workers from disadvantaged backgrounds and our recent agreement offers this as an option to meet their already strong standards.

PLAs grow the number of registered apprentices, and many include language hiring local workers and workers from disadvantaged backgrounds ⁱ(Ormiston & Duncan, 2022). From 1995 to 2010, an estimated 75% of PLAs promoted the hiring of veterans, 56% required hiring women and people of color, and 38% set local hiring goals ⁱⁱ(Figueroa, Grabelsky, & Lamare, 2011). It should be noted that

agreements like the RWEA and the Project Workforce Development Agreement with PSU are not only great at providing opportunities for underserved populations, they can also ensure there is a mechanism for accountability through partnership that is invaluable to the communities they serve.

In closing, The Building Trades believes that public contracting is a benefit to the community and needs to ensure hard working women and men in our communities are paid their fair share and treated with dignity and respect through safe and healthful workplaces in all industries not limited to construction but also in operation of these types of facilities; this project will do exactly that. We recognize that PSU is not only an excellent source for higher education, however, an excellent partner in the community. We are excited to work collaboratively with their leadership team to get this project over the finish line.

Thank you for your time and consideration,

A handwritten signature in dark ink, appearing to read 'Randall Friesen', with a large, stylized flourish extending to the right.

Randall Friesen
Executive Director
Columbia Pacific Building & Construction Trades Council

ⁱ Ormiston, Russell and Kevin Duncan. (2022). *Project Labor Agreements: A Research Review*. Institute for Construction Employment Research; Allegheny College; Colorado State University-Pueblo.

ⁱⁱ Figueroa, Maria, Jeffrey Grabelsky, and Ryan Lamare. (2011). *Community Workforce Provisions in Project Labor Agreements: A Tool for Building Middle-Class Careers*. Cornell University.

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
134	Christopher Almeida	Support	I am in support of a new facility at PSU to provide a long-term solution for a world class performing arts center. This will be a multi-generational opportunity to give our city a stage to put on performing arts of all kinds and continue a tradition of Broadway shows in our city for years to come at a brand new facility. Continuing to use the Keller, even with upgrades, is an inadequate solution and essentially putting a band aid on the problems on a building that has seen its best days. Please vote to advance the planning of the proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center at PSU. Thank you!	No	09/03/26 10:48 AM
135	Daniel Friedman	Oppose	For downtown Portland to recover from its current hollowed-out state, decision-makers must pursue multiple strategies that preserve—and, wherever possible, increase—the number of people on the streets. The proposed PSU theater complex is far enough from the downtown core that much of the economic benefit generated by theatergoers would be lost. In practice, most people will walk only short distances for dining, shopping, or other services. Keller Auditorium is close enough—and well connected enough—to draw patrons to nearby businesses along SW Broadway, the Park Blocks, the University District, and the West End. In contrast, the PSU site sits in an isolated corner of the outer edge of downtown with few direct street connections to the core. Please reject the proposed PSU venue today. Instead, support Downtown revitalization by appropriating what is realistically needed to address deferred maintenance and make modest, cost-effective upgrades to the Keller.	No	09/03/26 11:09 AM
136	Ellen Drumheller	Oppose	TO: Portland City Council Please VOTE NO today and SUPPORT THE KELLER AFFORDABLE FIX! Thank you for your service to the City of Portland. Ellen Drumheller 1260 NW Naito Pkwy Unit 606 Portland, OR 97209	No	09/03/26 11:12 AM
137	Craig R. Loftin	Oppose	Please vote NO!	Yes	09/03/26 11:19 AM

**Craig Loftin
1500 SW 5th Avenue
Unit 1506
Portland, OR 97201-5428**

September 3, 2026

Dear Mayor Wilson and Members of the City Council,

I would urge you to vote **NO** on the Agenda Item 2026-270: Accept the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts recommendations to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center at Portland State University, and initiate planning for the future of the Keller Auditorium. Rather, I urge you to support the renovation and remodel of the Keller Auditorium as previously proposed.

As we all know, the last several years has been devastating to downtown Portland in many ways that I will not enumerate here. Serious efforts to revitalize this essential heart of the city are underway and as a resident of downtown, I can attest that these efforts are having a positive effect. Now is the time to emphasize a firm commitment to this revitalization of the core of downtown, rather than focusing on further building out underdeveloped land in an area on the outskirts of downtown.

Choosing to build a totally new performing arts and culture center will, no doubt, benefit struggling Portland State University. But it would also come with an estimated nearly one billion dollar price tag. The City of Portland has neither the funding available, nor can afford such an expense. Moving forward on this plan would significantly burden the city and its residents for decades to come.

Renovating the existing Keller to overcome its current deficiencies, as previously proposed elsewhere, could be accomplished at a fraction of this proposed expenditure. Together, the renovated Keller, with the award-winning Keller Fountain as its backdrop, would provide Portland with a world-class performing arts center that would be a beautiful addition to the city. The Keller and its location are well known and loved, and has easy access both by Tri-Met and other methods of transportation.

If the City Council rejects the Keller as the option going forward, there are no longer available established plans for the existing Keller that would not require significant sums of money to enact. Other than simply demolishing the existing structure, any future use would require the seismic and other renovations that would be completed if the Keller were the selected option.

Further, Broadway Across America recently committed to seven more years of shows being held at the Keller. This relationship has been a major economic advantage to the city and demonstrates the confidence of Broadway Across America in both the Keller venue and Portland itself.

With all this in mind, please **VOTE NO** on this proposal.

Thank you for your consideration,

Craig R. Loftin

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Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Samantha Pahlow	Support	Chair Dunphy and Members of City Council, My name is Samantha Pahlow, and I serve as Chair of the Portland State University Foundation Board of Trustees, the university's philanthropic partner. In my professional life, I evaluate opportunities through a lens of stewardship, long-term value, and responsible investment. Those same principles guide my support for the Performing Arts + Culture Center. The Foundation Board supports PSU President Ann Cudd and this project because we believe it represents a rare opportunity to strengthen both Portland State University and the city it serves. As downtown's public university, PSU's future is intertwined with Portland's future. A vibrant city helps us attract students, faculty, and investment. In turn, PSU contributes talent, innovation and energy to the heart of downtown. We succeed together. The Performing Arts + Culture Center will strengthen PSU's exceptional arts programs while creating new educational and workforce opportunities for students interested in stagecraft, production, and other creative industries. It will also support the broader arts ecosystem, especially smaller regional organizations that continue to rebuild and grow following COVID. In addition, this project is designed to be a catalyst for a thriving downtown, driving the sustained economic activity that will benefit businesses, residents, and visitors alike while reinforcing Portland's identity as a center for culture, creativity, and innovation. For three years, PSU and the Foundation have invested significant time, resources and leadership in developing this vision. Independent studies, economic analyses, advisory groups, and City-led processes have consistently pointed to this site and this concept as the strongest path forward. The university has stepped up. The Foundation has stepped up. The state of Oregon, private investors and philanthropists have too. I urge you to vote yes on this resolution to keep the momentum on the City-owned Broadway theater moving forward. As stewards of PSU's future, the PSU Foundation Board believes this is the right project, in the right place, at the right time. Thank you for your consideration, Samantha Pahlow, Chair, PSU Foundation Board of Trustees	No	09/03/26 11:31 AM
Sara Matarazzo	Oppose	I am opposed to the building of a \$1billion performing arts center at PSU. I have lived in Portland for over 60 years and practiced law downtown, and have been a long time supporter and attendee of the Portland Opera, symphony and theatre productions at the Keller. The Keller is a gem, along with its iconic and historic fountain plaza, and its location continues to provide an economic engine for the core of downtown, including restaurants, shops and office buildings in our downtown core. Downtown suffered from violence, homelessness, vandalism and other property crime for several of the last 5 years. 2021-2025 has been a slow but steady testament to its survival and recovery. With city, county, metro, Tri-Met, PSU faculty layoffs and PPS school budget cuts everywhere in the city, and the Moda center in desperate need of a deal to keep our beloved Blazers, there are better things for city government to do with millions of dollars, let alone \$1 billion which we don't have, and won't have. The Keller is popular, fully rented out for years to come, well situated and paid for. A small renovation won't cost that much. Broadway across America seems very satisfied with it. I can only guess it is a small self-interested group who wants to throw money at a plan that can't possibly succeed, is not supported by the majority of Portlanders, and makes no financial sense. This proposal is akin to Trump's golden ballroom: unnecessary, waste of taxpayer dollars and a vanity project. Please exercise your good judgment and fiscal responsibility with our tax dollars. I know you have to make a lot of tough decisions every day. This is an easy one. Vote NO. Thank you very much for all you do.	No	09/03/26 11:46 AM
Joel Thorson	Oppose	City Administrator Lee: please direct staff's attention to these matters of urgency.	Yes	09/03/26 11:55 AM
Anonymous	Oppose	I oppose what would likely be the destruction of historical & beautiful Keller! I oppose spending this much money on the new venue, and not sure it could be explained to many even when considering the amount spent on sports. Why is the city ignoring its own study, and not putting needed money to work elsewhere like the homeless?	No	09/03/26 12:59 PM

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Testimony re: Resolution 2026-270

Joel Thorson

thorson@easystreet.net

I'm opposed to the Resolution, for many reasons, on many levels. My intention here, however, is twofold: to **place two largely overlooked but urgently important matters into the public record**, and to focus staff scrutiny on them for immediate action (**CITY ADMINISTRATOR LEE, PLEASE TAKE NOTE**):

A. the **Project Commitment Agreement (PCA)** mandated by the resolution. Warning: once signed by the City Administrator, this agreement will **set financial events in motion even before the Council has a final chance to approve of the Resolution itself**. See details below.

B. a topic of urgent importance which has escaped the Council's attention so far, and which the Resolution never even mentions: **FINANCIAL RISK**.

So here's the "ask." The following is wordy, BUT the impending danger in this moment escalates it from TL;DR (too long, didn't read) to **TC;MR (TRULY CRITICAL; MUST READ)**.

Table of Contents

Both parts, as you will see, reference the so-called "Vanport template," which is PSU's preferred model for structuring the entire Project:

- A. **Scrutinize any initial draft of the PCA, AND all proposed formation documents creating the governing structure of the Project.** Withhold all signatures until redrafting yields a fair deal for the City. This should be considered **standard due diligence** in a matter of this size and import, but it was bypassed by C.A. Lee's predecessor in signing the Letter of Intent three years ago.
- B. Make sure that the Mayor and all Councilors understand the **potentially ruinous financial risks** that the Project entails, given the turbulent state of the nation's economy.
- C. **Categories of risk** include:
 - 1. Borrowing cost increases
 - 2. Construction cost increases
 - 3. Unbounded growth of common expenses
 - 4. Loss of autonomous control over "calendar real estate"
 - 5. Withdrawal or failure of another project participant

A. Withhold signatures on all project documents until the City gets a square deal

City Administrator Lee: I implore you to avoid making the same mistake your predecessor did. It is YOUR signature, not the DCA's, that will activate the Project Commitment Agreement (PCA) mandated by the Resolution. I urge you to insist on the City's right to transparency and full disclosure, and exercise it to the fullest. Please scrutinize not only the PCA but the legal documents proposed for creating a governing body, and withhold all signatures until all documents yield a fair deal for the City.

Specifically:

- 1) Pay close attention to **the wording of the PCA**. The very name signifies that it will be used, WITH OR WITHOUT A DOWN PAYMENT, as a pledge toward "certification" of matching funds required for unlocking state bond funding. The bill will come due, and soon. And where are we going to find \$44 million lying around?
- 2) **Do not sign the PCA** unless all decisions that PSU proposes to make in the City's behalf not only include an "opportunity to review and comment" but **the right to withhold consent**. Examples include selection and hiring of an architect, designer and construction company, oversight of the construction process, and all other decisions bearing materially on the City's governance of its own deeded space. The City already has such power over its own decisions in governing its own Keller property. Why would it want to forfeit that inherent right of ownership?
- 3) **Do not sign the PCA** if it proposes to use PSU's "Vanport model" as a template for organizing the project's governing body. See **The Vanport Building: an object lesson**, below, for a cut-and-dried explanation of how the very core of the condominium concept -- the sharing of rights and responsibilities in a shared property ownership -- was *abused* in the Vanport project from its inception, so as to create a **permanent 51% PSU voting majority** for the developer.
- 4) Insist on **right of refusal of any draft formation papers** instituting a governing Condominium Owners Association, including its by-laws. Ensure redrafting such that voting rights be allocated fairly, reflecting not only square footage but size of financial investment. Ensure that governance and operations will be turned over to an entity fairly representing the interests of ALL investing partners, including the right to change their board officers, amend their by-laws, and hire their building management.
- 5) Make sure that the City reserves not just "an opportunity to review and comment" but the **right to withhold consent** for all decisions that PSU proposes to make in the City's behalf, such as selection and hiring of an architect, designer and construction company, and all other decisions bearing materially on the City's governance of its own deeded space.
- 6) Make sure that the City reserves access to legal redress for return of any "down payment" it might make toward pre-construction funding, in case the project fails as a result of cost overruns, rising bond rates, or the withdrawal or failure of any of the other participants, or other surprises beyond the City's control

B. FINANCIAL RISKS

B.1. Borrowing cost increases

In recent news, we see headlines like this:

MoneyWatch | Managing Your Money | CBS News Price Tracker

MoneyWatch

Rising bond yields threaten to push up U.S. borrowing costs. Here's what to know.

By [Mary Cunningham](#)

Updated on: September 1, 2026 / 4:44 PM EDT / CBS News

 Add CBS News on Google

Treasury yields edged higher on Tuesday, extending a global bond sell off and threatening to raise borrowing costs for millions of Americans.

The yield on the 10-year Treasury, which influences mortgage rates, rose to 4.78%, up from 4.75% late Monday and the highest level since January 2025. The yield on the 2-year Treasury, which closely tracks expectations for the Federal Reserve's interest rate decisions, rose to 4.37%, up from 4.34% late Monday. The 30-year Treasury hovered around 5.25% on Tuesday.

MONEY WATCH



Oil prices rise again as U.S. renews Iran strikes
(02:12)

MONEYWATCH

How much interest can a \$200,000 high-yield savings account earn over the next year?

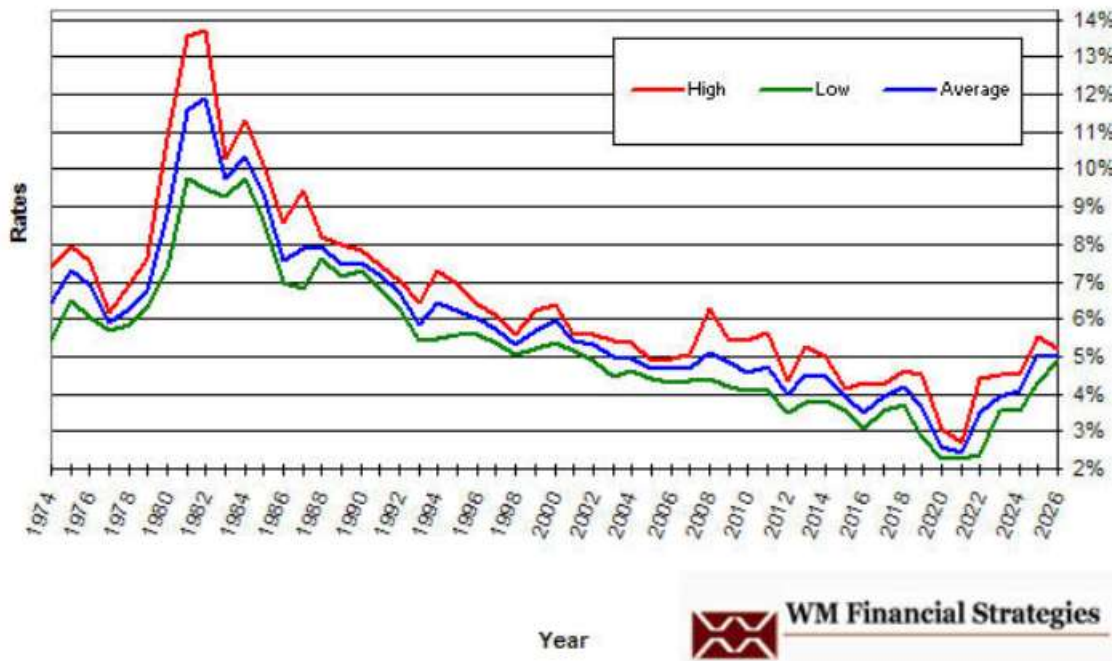


Source: CBS Moneywatch <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/rising-bond-yields-borrowing-costs-inflation/>

Municipal bond yields, as always, are subject to fluctuations in the municipal bond market. But this time is different. Now, inevitably, the bond market is paying attention to a persistent upward trend in the inflation rate. Bond yields have doubled from their COVID low (<2.5% in 2022) to about 5%. Keep in mind that a single percentage point, applied to a \$450 million bond, equals a \$4.5 million increase in annual debt service. That's a line item in the city's overstressed budget or, if financed through a bond measure, *everyone's* household budget.

And that's far from the worst-case scenario. We've encountered the effects of an oil embargo before. Most Americans weren't alive when the so-called Arab Oil Embargo virtually crippled the American economy in the early '80s, giving rise to the term "stagflation" – runaway inflation combined with a resulting stagnation caused by interest-rate hikes applied by a hawkish Federal Reserve to bring inflation back down. Muni bond yields reached 13-14% before yielding. That's almost 3x today's level.

20-BOND BUYER INDEX 1974-PRESENT



Source: Muni Bond Advisor <https://www.munibondadvisor.com/market.htm>

Could it happen again? It surely could. There seems to be no end in sight to the stubborn vanity war we're involved in "over there." The only thing worse than the events of the '80s would be a Federal Reserve *unwilling* to draw political fire by raising interest rates. Then it's bank runs and wheelbarrows full of cash to buy a loaf of bread. The world has seen that too.

B.2. Construction cost increases

It's not unusual for big, complex construction projects to soar past their initial cost estimates and run out of money. Then it's back to the funding sources for another dip into the bond market. Isn't that the rule, not the exception? People pitching a big project seem to have a tendency to lowball their estimates, for the best possible access to funding.

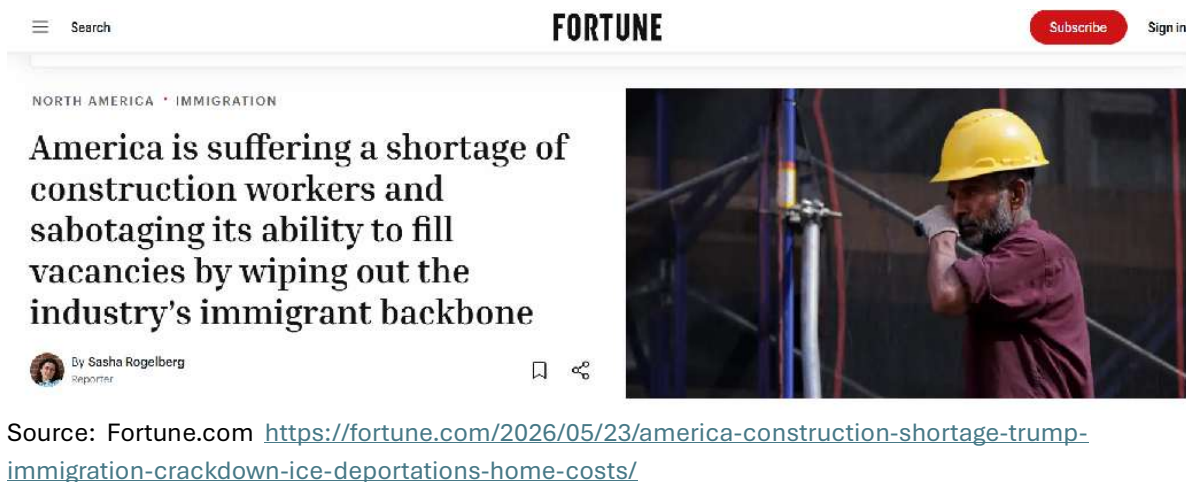
When dealing with a \$445 million project, a modest 10% overrun leaves a shortfall of \$44.5 million. Another bond measure, anyone? So much for refurbishing the Keller Auditorium once the PSU venue is up and running.

Concrete, copper, steel, aluminum, gasoline and diesel fuel, virtually every material cost has undergone sharp price increases since the Tariff and Hormuz Wars began. Never mind that the true bearers of the tariff burdens -- the import companies -- have in some cases been reimbursed

behind the scenes, without passing any savings on to their domestic customers, and all on the federal credit card. That's doubly inflationary, BTW.

Then there's the rising cost of labor, an utterly predictable result of our deportation of foreign-born workers who, as recently as 2024, comprised 26.3% of the construction workforce. Since then, the foreign-born percentage has dropped by about 7.5% by some estimates, to about 23.5%. Other accounts report that for every non-native worker who leaves a job site, another 6 stay home for fear of ICE raids. Whatever the numbers, the loss of foreign-born workers has hampered the industry and significantly slowed the pace of construction projects.

Into the teeth of this labor shortage comes PSU, construction cranes flying. What could go wrong?



B.3 Unbounded growth of common expenses

There is no reason to believe that PSU has any designs on the current Keller's surplus revenues. But there's another pitfall which may, eventually, overtake and surpass the Keller's net operating surplus, which has subsidized the other P'5 venues for years.

In addition to the initial investment, he said, each participant will be responsible for a pro rata share of the project's overall common-area upkeep, including such ongoing expenses as landscaping, external repair and maintenance, insurance and reserve account accumulation.

As any residential condo owner knows, debt service can be reduced or paid off, but **HOA dues are forever. And they can, and do, increase -- and keep increasing, without limit.**

Lacking a final PSU design and funding model, it's unclear how big the "new Keller's" pro rata share of common expenses would be. Its construction footprint appears to be nearly half the project's total, and its capital cost, half or more the project's total. Whatever the City's pro rata share of

ownership turns out to be, it will be much greater if other major project elements remain unsubscribed or unbuilt for years before completion, or if one fails, or otherwise withdraws from the project.

Beyond its ongoing maintenance fees, the “new Keller” would have to lease parking space in the new underground parking garage, an expense it doesn't currently bear: the current Keller is surrounded by thousands of spaces in private garages within two or three blocks of the auditorium, and they serve the Keller's needs quite well.

The existing Keller has neither common-property maintenance fees nor parking lease payments to contend with, and any equivalent expenses are already accounted for in its financial performance.

B.4 Loss of autonomous control over “calendar real estate”

In the status quo, the City's sovereignty over its own Broadway-capable building provides the latitude it needs for maximizing revenues and minimizing expenses. By entering into a forced collaboration / competition with a nearby PSU student venue (perhaps even in the same building), the new venue relinquishing sole control. There is no guarantee that the resulting operation will remain profitable, PSU claims notwithstanding.

There is no reason why a City-owned Broadway-capable Keller replacement on PSU's site couldn't be a solely-owned venue in its own separate building, just as it is today – *except* that conjoining it with PSU functions helps make the Project appear **entirely education-related** and hence eligible for state higher-ed bond financing.

As one PSU advocate wonders, “Wouldn't it be great if students on their way to their rehearsal rooms were to bump into Renée Fleming in a hallway, and she held a master class right on the spot?”

The PSU plan *does* achieve some economies of scale and elimination of redundancy – but they work generally to PSU's advantage, not so much to the City's – particularly the revenues flowing from restaurant and bar operations in the concert-hall lobby. (Note: In the Vanport precedent, sublease revenue from street-level retail tenants goes solely to PSU -- AND their floor space counts toward PSU's permanent 51% majority voting allocation.)

Time is money, especially for ticket sales. It's useful to view the Keller's calendar as a scarce, hence valuable, financial asset – call it **“calendar real estate.”** Viewing it this way is useful because it generates a perpetual stream of benefits, cultural and economic, not only for arts organizations large and small, but for their diverse audiences, not to mention countless downtown businesses.

Ownership of its entire year's calendar enables the current Keller to optimize its income by skillfully distributing 365 days of the year among Broadway shows (with their various travel schedules, load-in / -out and equipment setup requirements) with the calendars and and other needs of the Portland Opera, the Oregon Ballet, Shen Yun, graduations and various other miscellaneous events large and small.

Consider the traffic, transit and parking congestion that would ensue if the two venues were to schedule major events on the same date. Consider the difficulty in sharing a lobby, bar and restaurant facilities, equipment and costume storage, restrooms, parking, marketing, crowd movement and signage. Such collisions could simply not be allowed. The entire calendar-filling job would become unimaginably more difficult if it all had to be done by permission granted by PSU, who would have a built-in conflict of interest favoring their own student venue.

The only solutions I can see would be either to (1) set up some intermediating scheduling entity to arbitrate calendar conflicts, or (2) contractually partition the calendar into two timeshares. And either solution would amount to surrendering a crucial component of the City's latitude in maximizing its own revenues.

B.5 Withdrawal or failure of another project participant

Given turbulence in the economy, it is not unlikely that either the hotel developer or some key contractor might fail to perform its duties, causing the whole house of cards to fall. It would be irresponsible for the City to overlook this contingency, and the effect it would have on the City's obligations as a partner. Who would cover the missing partner's share of project expenses? In a condominium arrangement, it all depends on how the COA governance is structured.

Customarily, a legitimate COA board would pass a "special assessment" to cover the unexpected expense. If the COA board is wholly controlled by PSU, they alone would have the power to decide whose creditors get stuck with the bill.

Which brings us to PSU's favorite form of governance, which their advocates call their "Vanport template."

The Vanport Building: an object lesson

The commercial condominium model structure is a major PSU requirement, not a suggestion. PSU advocates have said repeatedly that they plan to base PA+CC governance on their vaunted "Vanport template." Numerous such declarations are scattered throughout the Letter of Intent (LOI) signed in November 2024 (*not* 2025; see

signature page) between CA Lee's predecessor Michael Jordan and PSU President Ann Cudd. (See Exhibit C for dangerous excerpts from the LOI.)

Rather than the "Vanport template," I suggest that this model might be more aptly called the "Vanport pitfall."

The City fell into the pit before, when it invested \$15 million in the 2021 Vanport Building project. The \$100 million construction cost was shared by OHSU, PCC, the City of Portland, and PSU, the developer, who promoted it as a commercial condo partnership.

It was a partnership, all right, but only where construction costs were concerned. Instead of a proportional share of voting power, the City and its two other partners ended up with **ZERO de facto influence in their building's governance**. That's because PSU, in creating and filing the COA's founding documents including bylaws and property deeds, had quietly granted itself a **PERMANENT 51% VOTING MAJORITY** in all COA board decisions.

A condominium "turnover" event customarily marks a transition wherein the developer turns over governing control to an independent board of directors representing all members. In the Vanport case, it was PSU the developer turning control over to itself, then hiring its own building management office as property manager.

See Exhibits A and B, revealing how the Vanport magic was made.

Exhibit A

UNIT AREAS AND VOTING SHARES

Source: Vanport Building condominium
declaration document filed with the
Multnomah County Clerk

Unit #	Area In Square Feet	Voting Share Allocation
1	10,247	7.31%
2	36,462	26.02%
3	783	0.56%
4	822	0.59%
5	492	0.35%
6	1,464	1.04%
7	24,010	17.14%
8	39,936	28.50%
9	3,876	2.77%
10	22,022	15.72%
Total:	140,114	100.00%

Exhibit B

DISTRIBUTION OF UNITS, SPACE AND VOTING SHARES AMONG TENANTS

Source: Vanport Building condominium formation documents
filed with the Multnomah County Clerk

Unit owner	Investment	Units owned	Sq. feet	% of common-area expenses	Nominal share of voting rights	Effective share of voting rights
PSU	\$36,222,233	1,2,9	50,585	51.05%	51.05%	100.00%
	\$725,658	1/2 tenancy-in-common interest, 5&6	978			
	\$13,947,218.50	1/2 tenancy-in-common interest, 8	19,968			
OHSU	\$1,190,880	3,4	1605	15.63%	15.63%	0.00%
	\$241,886	1/6 tenancy- in-common interest, 5&6	326			
	\$13,947,218.50	1/2 tenancy-in-common interest, 8	19,968			
PCC	\$18,636,775	7	24,010	17.60%	17.60%	0.00%
	\$483,772	1/3 tenancy- in-common interest, 5&6	652			
City of Portland	\$14,867,528	10	22,022	15.72%	15.72%	0.00%
Totals:	\$100,263,169	1-10	140,114	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%

EXHIBIT C

REFERENCES TO THE “VANPORT MODEL” IN THE 2024 LETTER OF INTENT (LOI)

Source: Letter of Intent (LOI) co-signed by City Administrator Michael Jackson and PSU President Anne Cudd, November 14-15, 2024

Note: the LOI is no longer available in the City’s online archive (or is exceedingly difficult to find). Contact Joel Thorson, thorson@easystreet.net, for a copy via return email attachment.

2. Policy Visions

...

f. The Project will continue to advance the mutually beneficial relationship similar to the existing COP [City of Portland] - PSU condominium relationships of the Vanport Building, 1900 Building, and the Academic Student Recreation Center.

...

4. Building and Space Requirements, Desired Scope and Operation

...

e. The Project will be developed and operated as a commercial condominium, similar to the Vanport Building... Common space and shared spaces will be determined during the design phase of the Project and recorded in the condominium documents.

...

i. PSU will take the lead in creating the condominium in accordance with the Oregon Condominium Act... PSU will be responsible for preparing condominium documents and costs to prepare the condominium documents will be shared by PSU and COP and potentially other partners in the Project. [note conspicuous lack of oversight; no opportunity for review, comment, or refusal]

LOI: PSU WILL ASSUME ALL CONTROL OVER DESIGN AND CONSTRUCTION OF THE CITY’S VENUE

2. Policy Visions

...

5. Project Development

...

b. PSU will procure and manage a construction contract... PSU will consult with COP prior to selecting the contracting form and the contractor. PSU will provide a copy of the construction contract(s) to the City for review and comment [noticeably missing: "consent"] prior to finalizing the agreement(s).

c. PSU will procure and manage professional services contracts (i.e., designer, architect, engineers, etc.) required to complete the Project.

d. PSU will provide COP the opportunity to review and comment [again, no "consent" required] on all phases of design and construction. COP will have... equal approval authority on [documents] that pertain to shared systems and spaces within the Project and to the City Venue.

e. PSU will be responsible for building the core and shell of the building along with all mechanical, electrical, and plumbing systems, as well as tenant improvements of the City Venue necessary for a fully functioning Broadway-capable performing arts venue.

f. At completion of the Project, PSU will provide COP with a full set of As-built drawings and Operations and Maintenance documents.

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
142	Daniel M. Kaufman, PDXK Productions, IATSE Local 28, Musicians Local 99	Oppose	As a life-long resident of Portland and user of the Keller Auditorium (my LHS graduation ceremonies) some of the best concerts and events I have ever seen and/or participated in have happened in that beautiful space. As a member of IATSE Local 28 and Musician's Local 99 I have a vested interest in see the Keller remain intact. A billion dollar proposal with no plan for funding while destroying something irreplaceable smells like another developer boondoggle that makes the rich richer and Portlanders poorer. Please vote no and do better!	No	09/03/26 1:16 PM
143	Tad Everhart	Oppose	Don't discard Portland's past and present jewels for an uncertain future. The Keller has been vital part of Portland for 109 years. We must retain it for many reasons: economic, environmental, social, historical, reviving downtown, maintaining a rich cultural life, etc. In a City and County and Metro Region where we dedicate funding to: the Oregon Historical Society; rich programs at the Portland Parks & Recreation; extravagant public Library system; over-funded Climate Adaptation/Protection program; rapidly expanding Metro land acquisition program; an Arts Tax; and many other expensive public-funded social, cultural, educational, artistic, literary, and historical programs, there is room to include money to renovate and preserve the Keller. I suggest many of these existing programs should fund the Keller's renovation and preservation. And this would fit neatly within their mandates and missions.	No	09/03/26 1:39 PM
144	Linda Engels	Oppose	I support making the Keller earthquake prepared and certainly not destroyed. The Keller is in the city hub; convenient to local transit, parking, hotels and restaurants. Portland State is not downtown and will not improve the efforts to revitalize the downtown. In this country, we seem to dismiss and destroy what already exists rather than improve. Italy should be a lesson to America. Buildings older than our country today are actually used and continue to provide a sense of history and purpose.	No	09/03/26 2:48 PM
145	SMART Local 16	Support		Yes	09/03/26 3:33 PM
146	David Spaulding	Oppose	I am a resident of District 2 in Portland. I strongly oppose the construction of a new performing arts venue at PSU. During a severe budget shortfall, Portland must prioritize foundational downtown revitalization over an expensive, speculative entertainment project. True downtown recovery requires investing in baseline needs like clean streets, improved public safety, and reliable transit, rather than a new mega-project that serves only a niche audience. Committing millions in seed money without a secured funding structure risks taxpayer dollars on a project independent market studies suggest Portland cannot sustain. We should stabilize our current downtown core and optimize existing facilities like the Keller Auditorium, rather than diluting limited resources. I urge the Council to vote no and redirect these financial resources to the local restaurants and retailers who form the actual backbone of downtown's daily economy.	No	09/04/26 6:38 AM
147	Joanne Carlson	Oppose	Dear Portland City Councilors: I am writing about concerns I have about the resolution to Accept the Future of Large-Scale Performing Arts Recommendations to advance a new Broadway-capable venue as part of the proposed Performing Arts and Culture Center at Portland State University. This concept has been analyzed from many aspects since 2017. It would be nice in a perfect world if the city had money to remodel the Keller Auditorium and help build the new venue at PSU, but it doesn't. The city does not have money to do any of it. How does it even figure in budgets moving forward with all the needs this city has? Does it lead to more taxes, bond measures or what? The city should focus on the Keller Auditorium. There have been opinions written that support the renovation of the Keller at half the price of a new venue. The Halprin Conservancy developed an extensive renovation plan that would expand the Keller Auditorium. The City Council is well aware of the contents of this plan that adds 41,000 square feet to the building, creates a pedestrian mall between the front of the auditorium and the iconic Keller Fountain, considered one of America's greatest fountains of the 20th Century. The current Keller location provides 2,475 nearby parking spaces, public access by MAX trains and TriMet buses and 800 nearby hotel rooms, amenities that surpass the proposed PSU location at SW Fourth Ave and Lincoln St. This plan could also be done in phases. I appreciate your reading my thoughts. Thank you. Joanne Carlson	No	09/05/26 2:29 PM
148	John W Pimentel	Oppose		No	09/06/26 4:46 PM



International Association of Sheet Metal, Air, Rail, Transportation Workers

LOCAL UNION NO. 16

2379 N.E. 178th AVE., SUITE 16
PORTLAND, OREGON 97230-5957
PHONE: (503) 254-0123 • FAX: (503) 254-0157

Council President Dunphy
Vice President Clark
Council Members

For the Record: My name is Russell Benton. I'm a Regional Representative for the Sheet Metal Workers of SMART Local 16.

We are proud to give public support to the proposed 4-acre development of Portland State University's (PSU) new Performing Arts venue and hotel development. We are happy to announce that PSU and the Columbia Pacific Building Trades Council reached an agreement to ensure the PSU-owned portions of this project will have excellent labor standards ensuring our community will reach maximum return on their investment to this project.

This project will create an estimated 2,000 construction jobs and 400 permanent jobs including operations and maintenance. It will also help activate seven blocks of developable proximate property with spillover investment potential of around \$1 billion (beyond the Center construction). We have an opportunity to put Portland back on the map as a destination, and that could start with this project. The fact that we have a Project Workforce Development Agreement with PSU, which they proactively negotiated with the Columbia Pacific Building and Construction Trades Council, is indicative of an equity-centered commitment to collaboratively building economic justice in downtown Portland.

This project is unlike any other the City of Portland has considered in recent years. It has the potential to increase foot traffic downtown and put cranes in the air for a decade to come, all while advancing a commitment to workforce development, business development, and labor engagement through a compliance pathways approach ensuring support for high-road responsible contractors, skilled and trained workforce utilization, and Project Labor Agreements. Many studies have shown PLAs expand local hire and opportunities to workers from disadvantaged backgrounds and underserved communities.

Thank you for supporting this project and the working families of Portland and beyond.

Sincerely
Russ Benton
NWRG/SMART Local 16

	Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
149	Milestone Initiatives, Inc.	Oppose	My name is Julie Bunker. I am a Certified Venue Executive currently working as a spectator venue consultant as President of Milestone Initiatives, Inc. I was Director of Operations for Portland's from 2017 until the Covid closure in 2020. I participated in the initial Keller seismic study and early Keller remodel planning. I am testifying against this resolution. Any decision regarding an additional venue needs to be placed on hold until the change in management of the existing P5 venues is resolved. I cannot emphasize this enough. Page 2 of The City Life Committee document, dated 8/11 and attached as an addendum to the resolution, clearly states that the "proposed venue is not part of the Portland's Centers for the Arts portfolio." A 3,000-seat venue designed specifically for commercial events and not included in the P5 portfolio will cause a significant loss of revenue, have a negative effect on maintaining P5's existing venues, and harm local arts groups that rely on subsidized non-profit rates. Removing commercial revenue from the P5 portfolio makes a management agreement less attractive for potential operators. Potential operators deserve the opportunity to make suggestions regarding the impact a change in commercial revenue will have should the new venue not be included in the portfolio. What happens to the current venues if P5's commercial revenue is reduced or removed, needs to be discussed. PSU is part of the national trend of colleges planning spectator venues and expanding rental opportunities to offset enrollment drops due to demographics. I do not believe PSU would be as interested in a "Broadway" venue without the revenue that comes with it. Locally Lewis & Clark college is currently planning a new performing arts center for exactly the same reason. It is not the responsibility of the Portland City Council to help support a state university. It is the responsibility of the council to support the existing city owned venues and resolve the question surrounding the management of those venues. Who will own the building, how it is operated and funded, and what PSU expects out of it, are questions that need to be answered before the city uses its limited resources on this question.	No	09/07/26 7:49 AM
150	Helen Ying			Yes	09/08/26 11:55 AM
151	North Coast States Regional Council of Carpenters	Support with changes	Good morning. My name is Santino Juarez. This project will be built with an extraordinary level of public investment. That means the City has a duty to determine not only what will be built, but who will be trusted to build it. The lowest bid is not always the lowest cost. A contractor that cuts wages, misclassifies workers, ignores safety requirements, relies on an unqualified workforce, or leaves subcontractors unpaid transfers those costs back to workers, families, taxpayers, and the project itself. Responsible bidding must mean more than possessing a license and submitting a number. Before receiving public work, every contractor should be required to disclose its record of wage violations, safety violations, discrimination, retaliation, payroll fraud, worker misclassification, unfinished projects, and failure to pay workers or subcontractors. That review must apply to the general contractor and every subcontractor at every tier. Public accountability cannot disappear when work is passed down through layers of subcontracting. The City should require contractors to demonstrate adequate staffing, proper supervision, financial capacity, a qualified workforce, and a history of completing work safely, legally, and on schedule. This is not about excluding competition. It is about ensuring that the companies competing for public work are capable of delivering what the public is paying for. A responsible contractor protects workers, protects the construction schedule, protects the project budget, and protects the public from preventable risk. Before this project moves into major procurement, responsible-bidder standards must be written directly into the Project Commitment Agreement. Public dollars should reward contractors that follow the law, invest in workers, and build responsibly. If a company cannot meet those basic standards, it should not be trusted with this project. Santino Juarez	No	09/08/26 1:06 PM

September 3, 2026

President Dunphy and members of the Portland City Council,

My name is **Helen Ying**. I am a former educator, Portland State University alumna, longtime community leader, and a neighbor of the site where the proposed PSU Performing Arts + Culture Center would be located.

In 2024, I testified because I believe accessible arts and cultural spaces strengthen individuals, families, and neighborhoods. Since then, serving on the City's **FoLSPA Steering Committee**—in a technical role reviewing data and evaluating options—has further affirmed my support for PSU's proposed Performing Arts + Culture Center. Today, I speak as a community member who understands what this means for Portlanders.

This resolution is good for **PSU**, good for **Portland**, and good for the **community**.

For **PSU**, the new venue strengthens its mission as an urban-serving university and creates meaningful opportunities for students, faculty, and families. It also builds on significant state and philanthropic commitments already secured.

For **Portland**, this approach protects the economic activity generated by touring productions, supports downtown recovery, and activates the Halprin Sequence year-round—while allowing the City to reimagine the Keller without shutting down our large-scale performing arts ecosystem.

And for the **community**, this plan expands access for artists of color, community-based arts groups, and young people who struggle to find affordable venues. It supports small businesses and reflects Portlanders' values: inclusion, accessibility, creativity, and cultural vibrancy.

I respectfully urge you to adopt this resolution.

Thank you for your leadership and your commitment to our city.

152

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
North Coast States Regional Council of Carpenters	Support with changes	Good morning. My name is Santino Juarez. This project will be built with an extraordinary level of public investment. That means the City has a duty to determine not only what will be built, but who will be trusted to build it. The lowest bid is not always the lowest cost. A contractor that cuts wages, misclassifies workers, ignores safety requirements, relies on an unqualified workforce, or leaves subcontractors unpaid transfers those costs back to workers, families, taxpayers, and the project itself. Responsible bidding must mean more than possessing a license and submitting a number. Before receiving public work, every contractor should be required to disclose its record of wage violations, safety violations, discrimination, retaliation, payroll fraud, worker misclassification, unfinished projects, and failure to pay workers or subcontractors. That review must apply to the general contractor and every subcontractor at every tier. Public accountability cannot disappear when work is passed down through layers of subcontracting. The City should require contractors to demonstrate adequate staffing, proper supervision, financial capacity, a qualified workforce, and a history of completing work safely, legally, and on schedule. This is not about excluding competition. It is about ensuring that the companies competing for public work are capable of delivering what the public is paying for. A responsible contractor protects workers, protects the construction schedule, protects the project budget, and protects the public from preventable risk. Before this project moves into major procurement, responsible-bidder standards must be written directly into the Project Commitment Agreement. Public dollars should reward contractors that follow the law, invest in workers, and build responsibly. If a company cannot meet those basic standards, it should not be trusted with this project. Santino Juarez	No	09/08/26 1:06 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
North Coast States Regional Council of Carpenters	Support with changes	Good morning. My name is Nickeia Hunter. A responsible building begins with an honest paycheck. Every worker on this publicly supported project must receive the correct wage for the work actually performed. Workers must be properly classified, paid for every hour, and receive every benefit and protection required by law. Those obligations cannot exist only on paper. The City and Portland State University should require certified payrolls from every contractor and subcontractor. Those payrolls must be reviewed—not simply collected and stored. The project must include worker interviews, classification checks, payroll audits, and a clear process for identifying discrepancies. When violations are found, workers must receive prompt restitution. Contractors should face payment withholding, corrective-action requirements, and disqualification for serious or repeated misconduct. The project must also prohibit wage theft, off-the-clock work, improper deductions, cash-payment schemes, and the misclassification of employees as independent contractors. Workers must have a confidential way to report concerns without risking retaliation, reduced hours, reassignment, or termination. Transparency is equally important. The public should receive regular reports showing who is working on the project, which contractors employ them, what classifications they are working under, and whether every contractor is meeting its obligations. This is not unnecessary paperwork. Payroll transparency protects honest contractors from being underbid by companies that lower their prices by cheating workers. Responsible bidders should welcome a system that creates a level playing field and holds every company to the same rules. Before contracts are awarded, these protections must be made enforceable conditions of receiving public money. If taxpayers are expected to pay every project invoice, workers must be guaranteed every dollar they earn. Nickeia Hunter	No	09/08/26 1:10 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
North Coast States Regional Council of Carpenters	Support with changes	Good morning. My name is Melvin Norman. Responsible building is not only about completing a structure. It is about whether the people performing the work are trained, protected, and given a genuine opportunity to build lasting careers. This project should require every bidder to submit a project-specific safety plan, disclose its safety record, provide qualified supervision, and demonstrate that workers are properly trained for the work they will perform. Safety cannot be reduced to a poster hanging on a jobsite wall. The project must track injuries, near misses, hazards, corrective actions, and retaliation complaints. Workers must be able to raise a safety concern or refuse unlawfully dangerous work without fearing that they will lose their livelihood. The City should also require meaningful use of registered apprenticeships and establish measurable workforce goals based on actual hours worked—not promises, referrals, or temporary hires. Those opportunities should intentionally reach women, people of color, veterans, people with disabilities, formerly incarcerated people, low-income residents, and communities historically excluded from public construction careers. Access must be supported by practical investments such as transportation, childcare, tools, work clothing, training, and retention services. Opening the door means little if workers are not given what they need to remain and advance. Every contractor should report its apprenticeship, hiring, retention, safety, and workforce outcomes. Performance should be evaluated contractor by contractor and trade by trade so that poor performance cannot be hidden inside a project-wide average. These requirements strengthen the pool of qualified workers, reduce injuries and disruptions, and help keep the project on schedule. A responsible bidder does not merely promise to finish the building. A responsible bidder proves it can develop workers, protect workers, and deliver quality work safely. That standard must be established before procurement begins. Melivn Norman	No	09/08/26 1:15 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
North Coast States Regional Council of Carpenters	Support with changes	Good morning. My name is Jesus Saucedo. You have heard what responsible bidding and building should require: qualified contractors, honest wages, safe jobsites, skilled workers, genuine career access, and transparency at every level. Now those principles must become enforceable requirements. Good intentions are not labor standards. Aspirational goals are not accountability. A commitment without monitoring, deadlines, public reporting, and consequences is only a promise that can be abandoned when the project becomes difficult. The Project Commitment Agreement between the City and Portland State University must establish a comprehensive responsible-bidding and labor-standards framework before major construction procurement begins. It should require contractor screening, certified payroll review, workforce reporting, safety monitoring, apprenticeship utilization, confidential worker complaints, protection from retaliation, and independent compliance oversight. It must also establish real consequences: corrective-action plans, withheld payments, wage restitution, removal of noncompliant subcontractors, disqualification from future bid packages, and termination when serious misconduct continues. The City Council must receive regular public reports showing which contractors are meeting the standards, which are falling short, what violations have been identified, and how those violations were corrected. Most importantly, these requirements must apply to every contractor and every subcontracting tier. No company should be able to escape responsibility by shifting work, workers, or violations to another entity. Council has its greatest leverage now—before the delivery system is finalized, before major funds are committed, and before contracts are awarded. We are asking you to use that leverage. Do not approve a blank check and hope responsible practices follow. Make responsible bidding and responsible building conditions of receiving public money. This building may stand for generations. The standards established today will determine whether it also stands as an example of public integrity. Put those standards in writing. Make them transparent. Make them enforceable. And require every bidder to meet them. Jesus Saucedo	No	09/08/26 1:17 PM

Name or Organization	Position	Comments	Attachment	Created
Joel Thorson	Oppose	Testimony re: Resolution 2026-270 Joel Thorson thorson@easystreet.net September 9, 2026 The attached files, hereby placed in the public record, emphasize and clarify the massive financial risks posed by the PSU PA+CC proposal. My main intended audience is City Administrator Lee and his staff. The Avalos and Clark / Zimmerman amendments are a good start, but beyond the unknown project cost, there are other pitfalls -- less obvious but equally dangerous -- for the future financial health of the City and its taxpayers. CA Lee: It's YOUR signature, not your deputy's, that will activate the Project Commitment Agreement mandated by the Resolution. The very name suggests that PSU will likely use the signed agreement, EVEN BEFORE FINAL COUNCIL PASSAGE, as a pledge toward "certification" that PSU has met its \$50 million match requirement for unlocking state bond funding. I urge you, CA Lee, to exercise the City's right to transparency and full disclosure. Please scrutinize not only the Project Commitment Agreement but the legal documents proposed for creating a governing body. Avoid the one-sided provisions of a "Vanport template" agreement, which would allow the City no power to avoid major unforeseen condominium expenses and special assessments. Please withhold signatures until all documents yield a fair deal for the City.	Yes	09/09/26 9:41 AM

Letter of Intent

City of Portland (Oregon)

&

Portland State University

This Letter of Intent ("LOI") is made this 15th day of November, 2025, between the City of Portland ("COP or City"), a municipal corporation of the State of Oregon and Portland State University ("PSU") each of PSU and the City being a "Party" and collectively the "Parties".

In order to obtain State funding, PSU requested this LOI from COP with respect to COP's planned participation in a real property development conceived as the Oregon Center for the Performing Arts which would include a Broadway capable performing arts venue owned by the City as well as education uses owned by PSU and potentially other ancillary uses (the "Project"). This LOI identifies the Parties' shared understanding, purpose and vision for the Project. Although this LOI is not binding on the Parties, it memorializes general terms for their discussion and evaluation in developing agreements related to the Project.

1. Development Concepts

1. PSU will develop and construct the Project. The Project will include a newly-constructed, City-owned, Broadway-capable performing arts venue (the "City Venue"). The Project will also include a newly-constructed, PSU-owned performing arts venue of between 600 and 1,200 seats and associated academic spaces (the "PSU Space"). The Project is also envisioned to include a hotel and conference center, a resident arts company, on-site parking, a full-service restaurant and other amenities to serve building users.

The proposed development site is a half approximately four-acre site located at 310/330 SW Lincoln Street described as:

Parcel 1:

Tax Map: 1S1E03CC -00800 Tax Lot: 1 TL 800

Original Address: 310 SW Lincoln Street

M Co. Deed Book & Pg. # Unavailable

Purchased from: Portland Development Commission 02-18-2004

Lot 1 of Blk. C, South Auditorium Addition, in SW1/4 of SW1/4 of Section 3, Township 1S, Range 1E from western meridian in Multnomah Co., Oregon.

Parcel 2:

Tax Map: 1S1E03CC -00900 Tax Lot: 1 TL 900

Original Address: 330 SW Park Ave.

M Co. Deed Book & Pg. # Unavailable

Purchased from: Prescott Airpark 6720, L.L.C

Lot 1 of Blk. C, South Auditorium Addition, in SW1/4 of SW1/4 of Section 3, Township 1S, Range 1E from western meridian in Multnomah Co., Oregon.

- b. The City Venue is estimated to be available for COP occupancy on or before December 1, 2030.
- c. COP will be the owner of the City Venue.
- d. If PSU is unsuccessful at obtaining state funding by July 31, 2025 for the PSU portion of the Project, the Parties will convene to determine if the Project should be delayed until July 2027 or canceled.

2. Policy Visions

- a. The Project will serve as a means to prevent an extended closure of the existing Keller Auditorium and thus prevent loss of jobs, revenue and activity in the downtown core as described in City Resolution 37680.
- b. The City and PSU will establish a Project Team of technical experts (the "Project Team") to develop a detailed financial plan, provide input into the initial phases of the Project and Project construction management direction.
- c. The City, PSU and other partners if applicable, will equitably share predevelopment costs, including a traffic study, programming, legal costs and other feasibility studies as determined by the Project Team. The City and PSU recognize that a future development agreement will govern Project design and construction costs.
- d. The City and PSU will work together to identify and secure necessary funding and will collaborate with the PSU Foundation in its role as the lead philanthropic strategist for the Oregon Center for the Performing Arts, including establishment of a related organization for the project.
- e. The Deputy City Administrator will designate a pre-development steering committee to participate in the process, as needed.
- f. The Project will continue to advance the mutually beneficial relationship similar to the existing COP - PSU condominium relationships of the Vanport Building, 1900 Building, and the Academic Student Recreation Center. The Parties will incorporate

mutual respect and partnership in all aspects of the Project, from initial scoping to final occupancy.

- g. The Project will showcase and promote sustainability, community development, public engagement and accessibility to the arts.
- h. The Project will comply with Oregon's Percent for Solar requirement.
- i. The Project will aim to reduce both embodied and operational carbon impacts and strive to meet Living Building requirements. Recognizing that the Parties may have different green building/green construction requirements for improvement projects (e.g., Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design (LEED)), the Parties will adopt the more advanced sustainability program goals unless the Parties mutually agree in writing that a lesser standard should be applicable to identified aspects of the Project.
- j. The Project will support the Parties' commitment to actions which provide for economic development, equity, their roles as diligent stewards of public funds and resources, and other important public policies.
- k. Recognizing that the Parties might have different public works requirements such as project labor rates per Bureau of Labor and Industries (BOLI) or Davis-Bacon and apprenticeship participation requirements, the Parties may need to fashion mutually acceptable goals for participation of minority, women, and emerging small businesses (MWESB's) that may exceed any legally required minimums. The Parties will need to incorporate mutually acceptable workforce goals and MWESB requirements into all professional services and construction contracts for the Project. These mutually acceptable goals will need to incorporate State of Oregon goals as well as City goals and Prosper Portland goals.
- l. The Project will comply with applicable State public arts funding and COP's Percent for Art Program requirements. If required, Project documents need to clearly contemplate the requisite set-asides to meet requirements of the two public arts programs.

3. COP Financial Evaluation

- a. Given the objective of using COP's interest in ownership as match for State financing for the Project, COP financing terms may need to reflect minimum standards required to be considered match for PSU's purposes.
- b. The terms of the purchase agreement for the City Venue, including but not limited to price per square foot and desired target funding strategy, will be negotiated by June 30, 2026 concurrent with a development agreement(s). The cost for the city-owned venue portion of the development project is currently estimated to be \$358 million from all sources. Both parties understand the City's intended funding sources have yet to be determined, but could include Tax Increment Financing, Local Bond

Proceeds, Other City Revenue Sources, State Bond Proceeds, Philanthropy and other Public-Private Partnership funding.

- c. COP understands that monies required for their portion of the capital project, shall be held and monitored in discretely established interest earning PSU accounts on behalf of COP. Capital funds of COP shall be certified as restricted in the name of the project and held as unequivocally available until such time as their expenditure becomes necessary to acquire, plan, design, construct, improve, repair, equip and furnish buildings, structures, land, improvements and other projects, or parts thereof, as specified in the development agreement. Cash received for the COP portion of the capital project shall also be certified as irrevocable unless the project is formally abandoned by the parties. COP understands that financial contributions in an amount at least equal to the monetary requirements of financial match to state-backed debt shall be on deposit and certified by PSU as legitimate project funds by February 2027.

4. Building and Space Requirements, Desired Scope and Operation

- a. COP's minimum space requirement will be informed by a Market Feasibility Study commissioned by the City. The Market Feasibility Study will recommend a preferred number of venue seats and the operational model for the City Venue. COP retains the ultimate decision making authority on COP-owned venue size.
- b. The City Venue will be designed to meet the current state-of-the-art, and reasonably anticipated future needs of touring Broadway Shows, as well as the needs of Portland Opera and Oregon Ballet Theater and other potential commercial shows.
- c. The City Venue will be constructed in conjunction with the PSU Space and will include shared services such as loading, parking, building atrium, restrooms, storage, etc. to the extent practical and feasible.
- d. The Project must be built to a "life-safety" standard and not to "essential facility" standard.
- e. The Project will be developed and operated as a commercial condominium, similar to the Vanport Building. Costs of construction and operation will be based on a pro rata share of the wholly-owned condominium units. Common space and shared spaces will be determined during the design phase of the Project and recorded in the condominium documents.

5. Project Development

- a. Project construction will be overseen by a project Steering Committee composed of staff from PSU, the City and any other project owners. The Steering Committee is envisioned to meet monthly to make key project decisions and oversee the development of the project. The Steering Committee is a different committee than the pre-development steering committee referenced in section 2.e.

- b. PSU will procure and manage a construction contract in the form that would best protect the Parties' interests. PSU will consult with COP prior to selecting the contracting form and the contractor. PSU will provide a copy of the construction contract(s) to the City for review and comment prior to finalizing the agreement(s).
- c. PSU will procure and manage professional services contracts (i.e., designer, architect, engineers, etc.) required to complete the Project. The Parties will share in ownership and intellectual property rights of Project work product.
- d. PSU will provide COP the opportunity to review and comment on all phases of design and construction. COP will have opportunities to inspect, review, comment and will have equal approval authority on design and construction documents including but not limited to concept plans, schematic designs, contract documents, written specifications, designs, proposals or revisions that pertain to shared systems and spaces within the Project and to the City Venue.
- e. PSU will be responsible for building the core and shell of the building along with all mechanical, electrical, and plumbing systems, as well as tenant improvements of the City Venue necessary for a fully functioning Broadway-capable performing arts venue.
- f. At completion of the Project, PSU will provide COP with a full set of As-built drawings and Operations and Maintenance documents. These documents will be delivered in a mutually-agreed electronic format.
- g. Specific technical requirements for the City Venue will be detailed in future discussions and included into the Project development agreement. These requirements will be written in "performance specification" language and, in general, will include any mechanical, electrical, plumbing, space layout, telecommunication components, and other technical aspects. PSU shall include all performance requirements into the Project design documents and will assure implementation during construction.
- h. PSU will provide COP with a title report, environmental report (at a minimum a Phase I environmental assessment) and a geotechnical report of the Project site. PSU will disclose all known environmental hazards (hazardous substances and contaminated media) that may be discovered at any point in the Project.
- i. PSU will take the lead in creating the condominium in accordance with the Oregon Condominium Act. General common elements need to include fee simple interest in the land unless COP specifically agrees otherwise and the Parties have the opportunity to adjust for less than fee simple. PSU will be responsible for preparing condominium documents and costs to prepare the condominium documents will be shared by PSU and COP and potentially other partners in the Project.

6. Miscellaneous

- a. The Parties understand that participation in this LOI will not preclude PSU or COP from pursuing other development opportunities, which may come from public interest in connection to this LOI.
- b. This LOI will not preclude the Parties from discussing economic development opportunities with any other public agencies, or prevent the Parties from entering into an agreement with any other party in accordance with their individual or collective interests.
- c. Nothing in this LOI waives any Party's policy or prohibits a Party from maintaining or enforcing its current policies or agreements, including, but not limited to, contracting, competitive bidding, workforce and other requirements.

The Parties understand that this Letter of Intent expresses the intentions and desires of the Parties to enter into discussions with respect to this Project in mutually beneficial collaborative efforts. The Parties agree that this Letter of Intent is not binding on the Parties, does not give rise to any legally binding or enforceable obligation, liability, or agreement of the Party.

City of Portland (Oregon)

Portland State University

Michael
Jordan

Digitally signed by Michael
Jordan
Date: 2024.11.14 20:11:53
-08'00'

Michael Jordan

City Administrator

Date: Nov 14, 2024



Dr. Ann Cudd

President

Date: 11/15/2024

Testimony re: Resolution 2026-270

Joel Thorson

thorson@easystreet.net

I'm opposed to the Resolution, for many reasons, on many levels. My intention here, however, is twofold: to **place two largely overlooked but urgently important matters into the public record**, and to focus staff scrutiny on them for immediate action (**CITY ADMINISTRATOR LEE, PLEASE TAKE NOTE**):

A. the **Project Commitment Agreement (PCA)** mandated by the resolution. Warning: once signed by the City Administrator, this agreement will **set financial events in motion even before the Council has a final chance to approve of the Resolution itself**. See details below.

B. a topic of urgent importance which has escaped the Council's attention so far, and which the Resolution never even mentions: **FINANCIAL RISK**.

So here's the "ask." The following is wordy, BUT the impending danger in this moment escalates it from TL;DR (too long, didn't read) to **TC;MR (TRULY CRITICAL; MUST READ)**.

Table of Contents

Both parts, as you will see, reference the so-called "Vanport template," which is PSU's preferred model for structuring the entire Project:

- A. **Scrutinize any initial draft of the PCA, AND all proposed formation documents creating the governing structure of the Project.** Withhold all signatures until redrafting yields a fair deal for the City. This should be considered **standard due diligence** in a matter of this size and import, but it was bypassed by C.A. Lee's predecessor in signing the Letter of Intent three years ago.
- B. Make sure that the Mayor and all Councilors understand the **potentially ruinous financial risks** that the Project entails, given the turbulent state of the nation's economy.
- C. **Categories of risk** include:
 - 1. Borrowing cost increases
 - 2. Construction cost increases
 - 3. Unbounded growth of common expenses
 - 4. Loss of autonomous control over "calendar real estate"
 - 5. Withdrawal or failure of another project participant

A. Withhold signatures on all project documents until the City gets a square deal

City Administrator Lee: I implore you to avoid making the same mistake your predecessor did. It is YOUR signature, not the DCA's, that will activate the Project Commitment Agreement (PCA) mandated by the Resolution. I urge you to insist on the City's right to transparency and full disclosure, and exercise it to the fullest. Please scrutinize not only the PCA but the legal documents proposed for creating a governing body, and withhold all signatures until all documents yield a fair deal for the City.

Specifically:

- 1) Pay close attention to **the wording of the PCA**. The very name signifies that it will be used, WITH OR WITHOUT A DOWN PAYMENT, as a pledge toward "certification" of matching funds required for unlocking state bond funding. The bill will come due, and soon. And where are we going to find \$44 million lying around?
- 2) **Do not sign the PCA** unless all decisions that PSU proposes to make in the City's behalf not only include an "opportunity to review and comment" but **the right to withhold consent**. Examples include selection and hiring of an architect, designer and construction company, oversight of the construction process, and all other decisions bearing materially on the City's governance of its own deeded space. The City already has such power over its own decisions in governing its own Keller property. Why would it want to forfeit that inherent right of ownership?
- 3) **Do not sign the PCA** if it proposes to use PSU's "Vanport model" as a template for organizing the project's governing body. See **The Vanport Building: an object lesson**, below, for a cut-and-dried explanation of how the very core of the condominium concept -- the sharing of rights and responsibilities in a shared property ownership -- was *abused* in the Vanport project from its inception, so as to create a **permanent 51% PSU voting majority** for the developer.
- 4) Insist on **right of refusal of any draft formation papers** instituting a governing Condominium Owners Association, including its by-laws. Ensure redrafting such that voting rights be allocated fairly, reflecting not only square footage but size of financial investment. Ensure that governance and operations will be turned over to an entity fairly representing the interests of ALL investing partners, including the right to change their board officers, amend their by-laws, and hire their building management.
- 5) Make sure that the City reserves not just "an opportunity to review and comment" but the **right to withhold consent** for all decisions that PSU proposes to make in the City's behalf, such as selection and hiring of an architect, designer and construction company, and all other decisions bearing materially on the City's governance of its own deeded space.
- 6) Make sure that the City reserves access to legal redress for return of any "down payment" it might make toward pre-construction funding, in case the project fails as a result of cost overruns, rising bond rates, or the withdrawal or failure of any of the other participants, or other surprises beyond the City's control

B. FINANCIAL RISKS

B.1. Borrowing cost increases

In recent news, we see headlines like this:

MoneyWatch | Managing Your Money | CBS News Price Tracker

MoneyWatch

Rising bond yields threaten to push up U.S. borrowing costs. Here's what to know.

By [Mary Cunningham](#)

Updated on: September 1, 2026 / 4:44 PM EDT / CBS News

 Add CBS News on Google

Treasury yields edged higher on Tuesday, extending a global bond sell off and threatening to raise borrowing costs for millions of Americans.

The yield on the 10-year Treasury, which influences mortgage rates, rose to 4.78%, up from 4.75% late Monday and the highest level since January 2025. The yield on the 2-year Treasury, which closely tracks expectations for the Federal Reserve's interest rate decisions, rose to 4.37%, up from 4.34% late Monday. The 30-year Treasury hovered around 5.25% on Tuesday.

MONEY WATCH



Oil prices rise again as U.S. renews Iran strikes
(02:12)

MONEYWATCH

How much interest can a \$200,000 high-yield savings account earn over the next year?

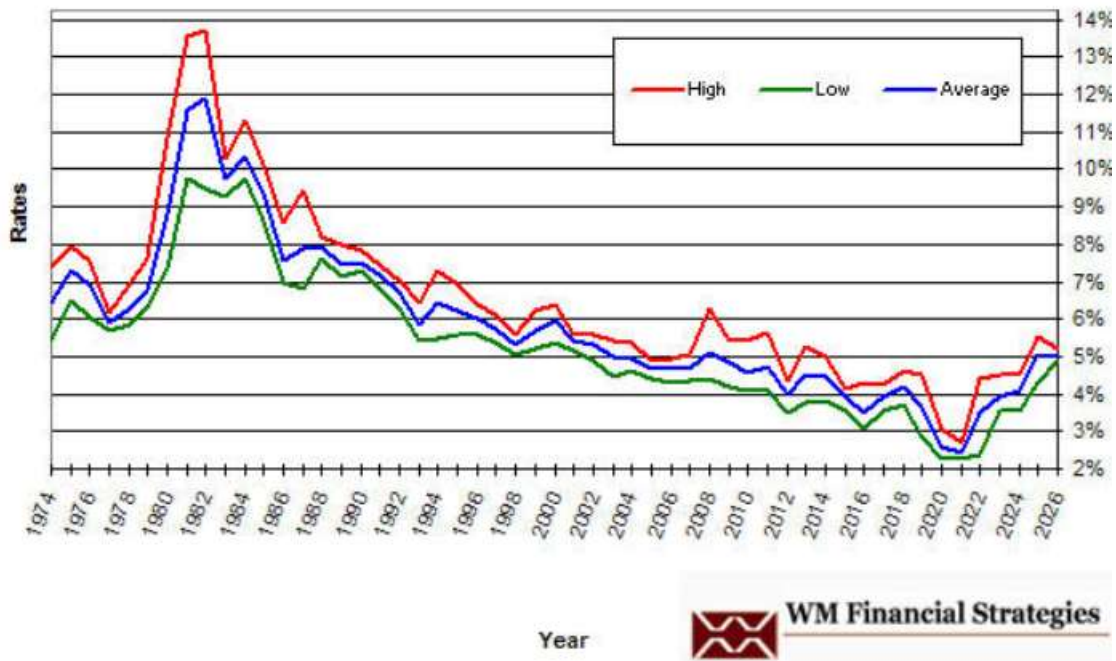


Source: CBS Moneywatch <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/rising-bond-yields-borrowing-costs-inflation/>

Municipal bond yields, as always, are subject to fluctuations in the municipal bond market. But this time is different. Now, inevitably, the bond market is paying attention to a persistent upward trend in the inflation rate. Bond yields have doubled from their COVID low (<2.5% in 2022) to about 5%. Keep in mind that a single percentage point, applied to a \$450 million bond, equals a \$4.5 million increase in annual debt service. That's a line item in the city's overstressed budget or, if financed through a bond measure, *everyone's* household budget.

And that's far from the worst-case scenario. We've encountered the effects of an oil embargo before. Most Americans weren't alive when the so-called Arab Oil Embargo virtually crippled the American economy in the early '80s, giving rise to the term "stagflation" – runaway inflation combined with a resulting stagnation caused by interest-rate hikes applied by a hawkish Federal Reserve to bring inflation back down. Muni bond yields reached 13-14% before yielding. That's almost 3x today's level.

20-BOND BUYER INDEX 1974-PRESENT



Source: Muni Bond Advisor <https://www.munibondadvisor.com/market.htm>

Could it happen again? It surely could. There seems to be no end in sight to the stubborn vanity war we're involved in "over there." The only thing worse than the events of the '80s would be a Federal Reserve *unwilling* to draw political fire by raising interest rates. Then it's bank runs and wheelbarrows full of cash to buy a loaf of bread. The world has seen that too.

B.2. Construction cost increases

It's not unusual for big, complex construction projects to soar past their initial cost estimates and run out of money. Then it's back to the funding sources for another dip into the bond market. Isn't that the rule, not the exception? People pitching a big project seem to have a tendency to lowball their estimates, for the best possible access to funding.

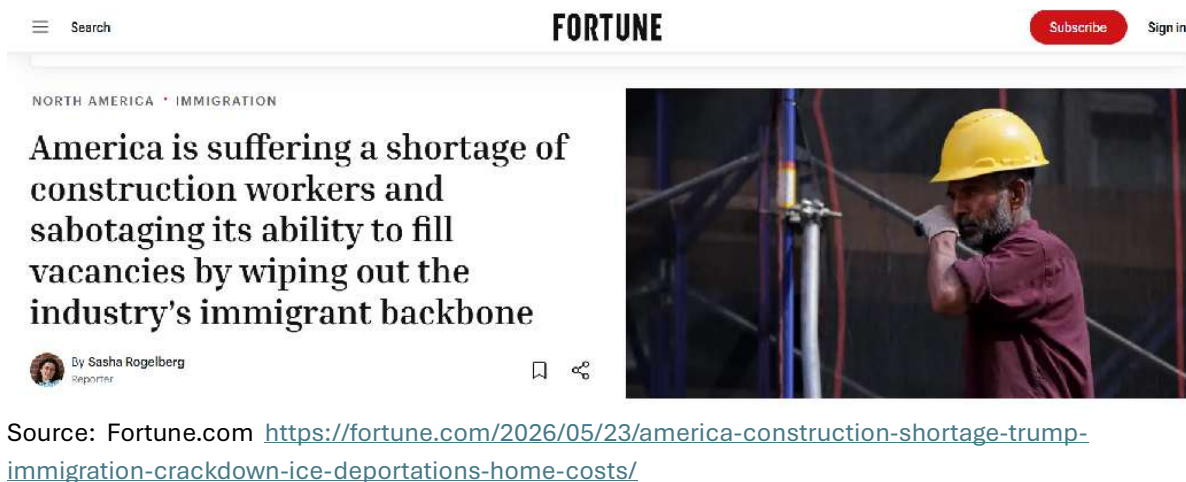
When dealing with a \$445 million project, a modest 10% overrun leaves a shortfall of \$44.5 million. Another bond measure, anyone? So much for refurbishing the Keller Auditorium once the PSU venue is up and running.

Concrete, copper, steel, aluminum, gasoline and diesel fuel, virtually every material cost has undergone sharp price increases since the Tariff and Hormuz Wars began. Never mind that the true bearers of the tariff burdens -- the import companies -- have in some cases been reimbursed

behind the scenes, without passing any savings on to their domestic customers, and all on the federal credit card. That's doubly inflationary, BTW.

Then there's the rising cost of labor, an utterly predictable result of our deportation of foreign-born workers who, as recently as 2024, comprised 26.3% of the construction workforce. Since then, the foreign-born percentage has dropped by about 7.5% by some estimates, to about 23.5%. Other accounts report that for every non-native worker who leaves a job site, another 6 stay home for fear of ICE raids. Whatever the numbers, the loss of foreign-born workers has hampered the industry and significantly slowed the pace of construction projects.

Into the teeth of this labor shortage comes PSU, construction cranes flying. What could go wrong?



B.3 Unbounded growth of common expenses

There is no reason to believe that PSU has any designs on the current Keller's surplus revenues. But there's another pitfall which may, eventually, overtake and surpass the Keller's net operating surplus, which has subsidized the other P'5 venues for years.

In addition to the initial investment, he said, each participant will be responsible for a pro rata share of the project's overall common-area upkeep, including such ongoing expenses as landscaping, external repair and maintenance, insurance and reserve account accumulation.

As any residential condo owner knows, debt service can be reduced or paid off, but **HOA dues are forever. And they can, and do, increase -- and keep increasing, without limit.**

Lacking a final PSU design and funding model, it's unclear how big the "new Keller's" pro rata share of common expenses would be. Its construction footprint appears to be nearly half the project's total, and its capital cost, half or more the project's total. Whatever the City's pro rata share of

ownership turns out to be, it will be much greater if other major project elements remain unsubscribed or unbuilt for years before completion, or if one fails, or otherwise withdraws from the project.

Beyond its ongoing maintenance fees, the “new Keller” would have to lease parking space in the new underground parking garage, an expense it doesn't currently bear: the current Keller is surrounded by thousands of spaces in private garages within two or three blocks of the auditorium, and they serve the Keller's needs quite well.

The existing Keller has neither common-property maintenance fees nor parking lease payments to contend with, and any equivalent expenses are already accounted for in its financial performance.

B.4 Loss of autonomous control over “calendar real estate”

In the status quo, the City's sovereignty over its own Broadway-capable building provides the latitude it needs for maximizing revenues and minimizing expenses. By entering into a forced collaboration / competition with a nearby PSU student venue (perhaps even in the same building), the new venue relinquishing sole control. There is no guarantee that the resulting operation will remain profitable, PSU claims notwithstanding.

There is no reason why a City-owned Broadway-capable Keller replacement on PSU's site couldn't be a solely-owned venue in its own separate building, just as it is today – *except* that conjoining it with PSU functions helps make the Project appear **entirely education-related** and hence eligible for state higher-ed bond financing.

As one PSU advocate wonders, “Wouldn't it be great if students on their way to their rehearsal rooms were to bump into Renée Fleming in a hallway, and she held a master class right on the spot?”

The PSU plan *does* achieve some economies of scale and elimination of redundancy – but they work generally to PSU's advantage, not so much to the City's – particularly the revenues flowing from restaurant and bar operations in the concert-hall lobby. (Note: In the Vanport precedent, sublease revenue from street-level retail tenants goes solely to PSU -- AND their floor space counts toward PSU's permanent 51% majority voting allocation.)

Time is money, especially for ticket sales. It's useful to view the Keller's calendar as a scarce, hence valuable, financial asset – call it **“calendar real estate.”** Viewing it this way is useful because it generates a perpetual stream of benefits, cultural and economic, not only for arts organizations large and small, but for their diverse audiences, not to mention countless downtown businesses.

Ownership of its entire year's calendar enables the current Keller to optimize its income by skillfully distributing 365 days of the year among Broadway shows (with their various travel schedules, load-in / -out and equipment setup requirements) with the calendars and and other needs of the Portland Opera, the Oregon Ballet, Shen Yun, graduations and various other miscellaneous events large and small.

Consider the traffic, transit and parking congestion that would ensue if the two venues were to schedule major events on the same date. Consider the difficulty in sharing a lobby, bar and restaurant facilities, equipment and costume storage, restrooms, parking, marketing, crowd movement and signage. Such collisions could simply not be allowed. The entire calendar-filling job would become unimaginably more difficult if it all had to be done by permission granted by PSU, who would have a built-in conflict of interest favoring their own student venue.

The only solutions I can see would be either to (1) set up some intermediating scheduling entity to arbitrate calendar conflicts, or (2) contractually partition the calendar into two timeshares. And either solution would amount to surrendering a crucial component of the City's latitude in maximizing its own revenues.

B.5 Withdrawal or failure of another project participant

Given turbulence in the economy, it is not unlikely that either the hotel developer or some key contractor might fail to perform its duties, causing the whole house of cards to fall. It would be irresponsible for the City to overlook this contingency, and the effect it would have on the City's obligations as a partner. Who would cover the missing partner's share of project expenses? In a condominium arrangement, it all depends on how the COA governance is structured.

Customarily, a legitimate COA board would pass a "special assessment" to cover the unexpected expense. If the COA board is wholly controlled by PSU, they alone would have the power to decide whose creditors get stuck with the bill.

Which brings us to PSU's favorite form of governance, which their advocates call their "Vanport template."

The Vanport Building: an object lesson

The commercial condominium model structure is a major PSU requirement, not a suggestion. PSU advocates have said repeatedly that they plan to base PA+CC governance on their vaunted "Vanport template." Numerous such declarations are scattered throughout the Letter of Intent (LOI) signed in November 2024 (*not* 2025; see

signature page) between CA Lee's predecessor Michael Jordan and PSU President Ann Cudd. (See Exhibit C for dangerous excerpts from the LOI.)

Rather than the "Vanport template," I suggest that this model might be more aptly called the "Vanport pitfall."

The City fell into the pit before, when it invested \$15 million in the 2021 Vanport Building project. The \$100 million construction cost was shared by OHSU, PCC, the City of Portland, and PSU, the developer, who promoted it as a commercial condo partnership.

It was a partnership, all right, but only where construction costs were concerned. Instead of a proportional share of voting power, the City and its two other partners ended up with **ZERO de facto influence in their building's governance**. That's because PSU, in creating and filing the COA's founding documents including bylaws and property deeds, had quietly granted itself a **PERMANENT 51% VOTING MAJORITY** in all COA board decisions.

A condominium "turnover" event customarily marks a transition wherein the developer turns over governing control to an independent board of directors representing all members. In the Vanport case, it was PSU the developer turning control over to itself, then hiring its own building management office as property manager.

See Exhibits A and B, revealing how the Vanport magic was made.

Exhibit A

UNIT AREAS AND VOTING SHARES

Source: Vanport Building condominium
declaration document filed with the
Multnomah County Clerk

Unit #	Area In Square Feet	Voting Share Allocation
1	10,247	7.31%
2	36,462	26.02%
3	783	0.56%
4	822	0.59%
5	492	0.35%
6	1,464	1.04%
7	24,010	17.14%
8	39,936	28.50%
9	3,876	2.77%
10	22,022	15.72%
Total:	140,114	100.00%

Exhibit B

DISTRIBUTION OF UNITS, SPACE AND VOTING SHARES AMONG TENANTS

Source: Vanport Building condominium formation documents
filed with the Multnomah County Clerk

Unit owner	Investment	Units owned	Sq. feet	% of common-area expenses	Nominal share of voting rights	Effective share of voting rights
PSU	\$36,222,233	1,2,9	50,585	51.05%	51.05%	100.00%
	\$725,658	1/2 tenancy-in-common interest, 5&6	978			
	\$13,947,218.50	1/2 tenancy-in-common interest, 8	19,968			
OHSU	\$1,190,880	3,4	1605	15.63%	15.63%	0.00%
	\$241,886	1/6 tenancy- in-common interest, 5&6	326			
	\$13,947,218.50	1/2 tenancy-in-common interest, 8	19,968			
PCC	\$18,636,775	7	24,010	17.60%	17.60%	0.00%
	\$483,772	1/3 tenancy- in-common interest, 5&6	652			
City of Portland	\$14,867,528	10	22,022	15.72%	15.72%	0.00%
Totals:	\$100,263,169	1-10	140,114	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%

EXHIBIT C

REFERENCES TO THE “VANPORT MODEL” IN THE 2024 LETTER OF INTENT (LOI)

Source: Letter of Intent (LOI) co-signed by City Administrator Michael Jordan and PSU President Anne Cudd, November 14-15, 2024

Note: the LOI is no longer available in the City’s online archive (or is exceedingly difficult to find). Contact Joel Thorson, thorson@easystreet.net, for a copy via return email attachment.

2. Policy Visions

...

f. The Project will continue to advance the mutually beneficial relationship similar to the existing COP [City of Portland] - PSU condominium relationships of the Vanport Building, 1900 Building, and the Academic Student Recreation Center.

...

4. Building and Space Requirements, Desired Scope and Operation

...

e. The Project will be developed and operated as a commercial condominium, similar to the Vanport Building... Common space and shared spaces will be determined during the design phase of the Project and recorded in the condominium documents.

...

i. PSU will take the lead in creating the condominium in accordance with the Oregon Condominium Act... PSU will be responsible for preparing condominium documents and costs to prepare the condominium documents will be shared by PSU and COP and potentially other partners in the Project. [note conspicuous lack of oversight; no opportunity for review, comment, or refusal]

LOI: PSU WILL ASSUME ALL CONTROL OVER DESIGN AND CONSTRUCTION OF THE CITY’S VENUE

2. Policy Visions

...

5. Project Development

...

b. PSU will procure and manage a construction contract... PSU will consult with COP prior to selecting the contracting form and the contractor. PSU will provide a copy of the construction contract(s) to the City for review and comment [noticeably missing: "consent"] prior to finalizing the agreement(s).

c. PSU will procure and manage professional services contracts (i.e., designer, architect, engineers, etc.) required to complete the Project.

d. PSU will provide COP the opportunity to review and comment [again, no "consent" required] on all phases of design and construction. COP will have... equal approval authority on [documents] that pertain to shared systems and spaces within the Project and to the City Venue.

e. PSU will be responsible for building the core and shell of the building along with all mechanical, electrical, and plumbing systems, as well as tenant improvements of the City Venue necessary for a fully functioning Broadway-capable performing arts venue.

f. At completion of the Project, PSU will provide COP with a full set of As-built drawings and Operations and Maintenance documents.

If you build it ... they still won't come

A sobering look at Portland's embrace of theater construction

Allan Classen

Northwest Examiner

Mar 10, 2026



Kurt Misar has been watching the Portland theater scene intently, and from various angles, for much of his life.

Part I —The Keller Auditorium



The proposed remodeling of The Keller Auditorium would entail a two-year closure.

My earliest interest in this subject was the city's urban renewal changes of the Civic Auditorium in the late '60s and continued following the city acquisition of the old Paramount Theater, its conversion into the Schnitzer Concert Hall and the subsequent construction of Antoinette Hatfield Hall housing the Newmark, Winningstad and Brunish theaters.

It is vital to understand that the city has a history of building things not by market need but in the hope that, once built, the market will materialize and make them financially stable. I know from conversation with fellow artists and with former City Commissioner Mildred Schwab, that the City Council's intention to build was with the assumption that availability would attract rental use regardless of the lack of demand for same.

The Hatfield Hall complex opened in 1987 and struggled financially for two years before the city turned over management to Metro. Metro was able to stabilize these properties financially by putting them all under a single accounting umbrella with properties like the Portland Expo Center (which Metro states needs a current long-term plan for financial sustainability) and the Oregon Convention Center. Simply put, the success of one would aid the losses of others, the tide raising all boats. This history, were it well-known, ought to encourage voters to look more closely at city proposals to create new theaters where no market need is warranted.

In 2025, Metro chose to divest management of Portland's, with control reverting to the city in summer 2027. The press release did not emphasize that profit and loss will be separated from Metro's broader umbrella. With that loss, the city must now prepare to manage these with more financial success than ever. In preparation for this transfer, a Performing Arts Venues Workgroup and a "Future of Portland's" team were formed, emphasizing three goals: expand usage to increase revenue, strengthen engagement with local arts groups, and improve booking policies. It is fair to extrapolate that these three objectives, the very first in their list, recognize the Workgroup's concern for Portland's income and financial stability.

Introduction

In my years as a part-time theater artist, I have had the fortune of juggling careers in banking, commercial real estate management and development, commercial leasing and residential home sales. It's an odd juxtaposition of skills and experiences, ranging from music composition, arrangement, production and film scoring to double entry bookkeeping, analyzing financial statements, ad-copy writing, telemarketing and direct sales.

I occasionally draw opinions about the failing health of the local performing arts industry. With the city proposing a new public theater on the Portland State University campus, there is a need for honest assessment of the existing market and how the city manages its current venues. Over a series of commentaries, I will offer a sober look at the local business realities of this changing industry.

The Keller dilemma

The 3,000-seat Keller depends on large-scale productions requiring high gross revenues. Over the next four months, it lists four single-night events, two multi-night events (totaling nine booked days out of 120), plus six Broadway bus-and-truck musicals. That totals about 40 performance days, with additional move-in/move-out rental days. It is the busiest Portland's venue—but largely because of a single anchor tenant: Broadway Across America. Without that tenant, the building would sit empty roughly 80–85% of the year and become bankrupt. That's worrisome. What happens to rental viability of the property if they were to lose that one anchor client?

The Keller also faces a proposed two-year closure for retrofit. During that time, it risks losing Broadway Across America unless another suitable venue is provided. This likely drives the recent proposal for a new 3,000-seat theater on the PSU campus.

In summary, consider that the Keller, actually the most actively used of the Portland's properties, currently operates successfully thanks to the whim of a single anchor tenant, who, if gone, would bankrupt the property. At the same time, due to age and wear, the property needs to shut down operation for two years and certainly doesn't want to lose their primary anchor tenant's business. So there is a scramble to bridge that period with an all-new theater on the PSU campus—a capital investment made by the public to create a property serving the university.

This is the same city, in the absence of having the power to require employees return to the workplace, that operates properties owned and leased for the benefit of a largely absent staff; operating with all associated lease, utility and insurance costs for buildings getting little usage and properties owned that have little reason to remain on the city books—that could be sold as non or underperforming real assets. This existing practice certainly suggests that the city prefers to own properties that cannot turn a profit (to pay for themselves or pay for needed retrofits) and doesn't care how much drain they are. And now, they will be taking back management of the Portland's.

More to come—in the next installment.

Part I - THE KELLER AUDITORIUM

Part II - THE ARLENE SCHNITZER CONCERT HALL

Part III - THE NEWMARK THEATER

Part IV - WINNINGSTAD AND BRUNISH THEATERS

Part V – LIVE NATION AND AEG PRESENTS

If you build it ... they still won't come

Part II - The Arlene Schnitzer Concert Hall

[Kurt Misar](#)

Mar 13, 2026



The Oregon Symphony, the Arlene Schnitzer Concert Hall's anchor tenant, will be a critical player as venues battle to avoid extinction.

Last year, Metro chose to divest management of Portland's, returning it to the city in 2027. That means the theaters' profits and losses will no longer be blended into Metro's broader finances. The city will again be responsible for aggressively maximizing rental income, retaining earnings, and preparing for aging-related capital upgrades.

Creating the Performing Arts Venues Workgroup, the city's key short-term recommendations are: expand usage to increase revenue, strengthen engagement with local arts groups and improve booking policies to boost rentals. Increased rental sales and income will become central to Portland's financial stability.

ARLENE SCHNITZER CONCERT HALL

Understanding the Keller's severe rental customer limitations and plans to shutter, as well as potentially losing a vital anchor rental tenant, be assured that the Portland's Schnitzer Concert Hall is another 3,000 seat venue. If stage size, technical specifications and load-in can accommodate them, Broadway Across America could go here. Thankfully, the Schnitzer isn't exactly empty. Over the next 60 days, about 17 days (25% of all rental dates) are not booked. Some of the dates might be needed for move in-move out, but the events aren't big productions needing many moving days.

They have an anchor tenant—The Oregon Symphony. They'll be in there six times (13 performance dates). Another 25% of all the bookings there are coming from Live Nation and AEG Entertainment. This is useful diversification, offering less chance that the venue could fail economically if one tenant were to go bankrupt. Bookings will decline during the summer season.

It will be too busy, however, to accommodate Broadway Across America. So what do they do when the Keller closes for retrofit? The proposed Portland State University development would seem to have a role. But what happens to the financial sustainability of PSU's property when that lone anchor tenant returns to the Keller after two years in reconstruction? (Assuming they want to go back. If not, then how does the Keller avoid bankruptcy?)

There is another option. Is it possible that some of the Schnitzer bookings—say all the stand-up comic, single instrumentalists or small musical ensembles—could get booked into the Newmark Theater? Naturally, that would depend on whether those artists and producers were willing to reduce gross sales opportunities from a 3,000-seat property to a roughly 900-seat venue.

This isn't a bad idea, since the other Schnitzer anchor tenants are Live Nation and AEG Entertainment. Both book about 25% of all the acts in this venue, and acts of this size are their primary product. So, there may be reason to push more of their acts out of a 3,000 seat house into the smaller Newmark. For a lone comic with a traveling set, simple lighting and sound demands, more dates in a smaller venue can pencil out equal to a single date in a larger venue.

The Arlene Schnitzer Concert Hall might endure some lost booking sales when the Keller shutters for retrofit. It could use some bookings in the 17 open dates in the next 60 days. Drawing more single-date events into the Newmark might give the Schnitzer flexibility in accommodating lost tenants during a rebuild of the Keller.

In the meantime, more than 50% of all Schnitzer bookings rest solely on the needs of three anchor tenants, the Oregon Symphony, Live Nation and AEG. One can assume the Oregon Symphony is in better financial condition than the recently shuttered Portland Symphony Orchestra, but in future installments, we'll discuss how Live Nation and AEG will cause some Portland's problems no one is yet talking about.

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Part IV - WINNINGSTAD AND BRUNISH THEATERS

Part V – LIVE NATION AND AEG

Part VI - AN UNHEALTHY THEATER INDUSTRY

Part VII – THE ARTIST REPERTORY THEATER DEBACLE



Kurt Misar is a part-time theater artist who has worked in banking, commercial real estate management and development, commercial leasing and residential sales. He is an associate broker with Capstone Real Estate Services and a resident of Goose Hollow.

If you build it ... they still won't come

PART III —THE NEWMARK THEATER

[ALLAN CLASSEN](#)

MAR 16, 2026



The mid-sized Newmark has not found the economic sweet spot.

In 2025, Metro returned Portland's management to the city, effective 2027, without stressing that theater finances will no longer be supported by Metro's broader budget. The city must now maximize rentals, retain earnings and fund capital upgrades. Its Performing Arts Venues Workgroup's priorities—expand usage, strengthen local arts partnerships and improve booking policies—ultimately hinge on increasing rental revenue to ensure financial stability.

The 900-seat Newmark Theater suits mid-sized productions with moderate break-even needs, such as local dance and theater companies, stand-up comics and small musical ensembles. However, no local theater company has sufficient subscription or ticket demand to fill 900 seats over multiple performances, nor the budget to cover union-scale move-in, move-out, stagehand, actor and musician costs. Most operate in 150–250 seat venues and lack the market demand to scale up. Only about half a dozen local companies can afford to rent this space even occasionally.

In a 60-day sample, five local dance companies account for 22 of the booked days, though they do not sustain that volume year-round. The Metro Youth Symphony and Portland Opera add 10 days, and five additional events are single-night performances. Excluding possible move-in, move-out bookings, the Newmark remains dark 25 of the next 60 days. This rental sample is a close to a best-case scenario and unlikely to repeat consistently, especially in summer. The conclusion is clear: The city's Workgroup is correct—the Newmark needs substantially more bookings and sales.

This raises a fundamental question of design and intent. Before the venue opened in 1987, what evidence demonstrated market demand for a 900-seat theater in Portland? Which well-capitalized local arts organizations with proven audiences could offer regular tenancy—and how was that need validated?

History suggests the demand was overstated. The Oregon Shakespeare Festival satellite company couldn't make a success of a regional transplant operations there—it imploded in crushing debt. Portland Civic Theater attempted to use the space, but its finances brought about ultimate bankruptcy and destruction. Oregon Children's Theater Co. is another that could not financially survive attempting to provide entertainment there. Local independent producers who I know likewise could not recoup investment, let alone profit. The few who remain, survive solely on charity and choose their rental dates carefully in their season of events.

Though I have not analyzed the full data, the issue appears to extend beyond one 900-seat theater, revealing a basic economic divide between local and national productions. A key factor is audience perception of quality: Many patrons assume that touring or national programs offer superior entertainment, while viewing local productions as inferior. They will pay \$90–\$120 for Broadway Across America, yet far fewer will spend \$60 on a locally produced version of the same musical.

While touring casts are equity professionals using original or replicated New York sets and costumes—and quality differences likely exist—the performance gap may be narrower than assumed. Nonetheless, audiences will not pay comparable prices for local productions, even in the same venue.

National producers can more easily absorb Newmark's rental costs because they generate far greater gross revenue, but local companies cannot. All Portland's venues are union houses, requiring minimum union hires for stage crews, actors and related labor—costs equal for all producers. Most local companies do not face these union expenses in their own venues and cannot generate sufficient ticket revenue at necessary price points to cover them. This exposes a flawed city assumption: that local arts organizations could become substantial, regular lessees of this 900-seat space. They lack both the revenue scale and pricing power to sustain that level of production costs.

Of 13 productions scheduled at the Newmark in the next 60 days, six are booked by national producers—two by Live Nation and one by AEG—accounting for six of the 33 booked days in this sample. None, local or national, function as anchor tenants providing consistent volume. Roughly half of bookings come from out-of-town producers. Currently, this is the only venue of this size. If a new city-operated Portland State University theater entered the market, it would not double demand but divide it -- splitting bookings between two properties and leaving both underutilized, where previously one might remain profitable.

In summary, the Newmark operates at roughly 40–45% vacancy, underperforming in both bookings and revenue. Its scale and union requirement effectively exclude most local arts companies from renting regularly or at a break-even level. Those that do rent depend on substantial charitable support, often underwriting losses, and none provide consistent, profitable lease income.

At 900 seats, the venue serves a limited market and makes profitability hard to achieve. Nearly half of recent lessees are national producers presenting single-night events—the least lucrative model—requiring higher volume to compensate for limited dates. Two of these producers, Live Nation and AEG, present additional long-term concerns for Portland's that remain largely unaddressed.

Taken together, current patterns suggest an increasing need for stronger management and more aggressive sales strategy at Portland's. And there is more yet to examine.

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Part VII - The Narrative and the Myth of Scarcity



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If you build it ... they still won't come

Part IV – Portland's Smallest Theaters Struggling

Northwest Examiner

by Kurt Misar

Mar 19, 2026



Even with frequent Stumptown Stages bookings, the Brunish Theater is empty more often than not.

With the city of Portland assuming management of Portland's in 2027, theater finances will no longer be supported by Metro's broader budget. Making them self-supporting will not be easy.

Winningstad Theater

Each theater in Hatfield Hall and its three theaters, serves a distinct niche. The Newmark is a traditional proscenium with little flexibility between stage, pit, and seating. The Winningstad, by contrast, was designed for adaptable use, including thrust staging with audience on three sides, though that flexibility is seldom used. It seats about 300—close to the 150–250 range most local companies prefer for economic viability. (The Armory Mainstage seats up to 560 but does not fill it consistently and Artist Repertory Theatre's proposed new mainstage would seat 178.)

The Winningstad, flexible or not, primarily serves local companies without permanent homes and small touring acts that don't require large revenue to break even. Local groups need this smaller venue due to their modest ticket sales and pricing.

In a 60-day sample, two single-performer events booked one day each, a traveling magician duo books two days, and Stumptown Stages ran a 23-day musical—for a total of 27 booked days out of 60, leaving more than half the dates unfilled. Only four rental days at the Winningstad were booked by national producers

Stumptown does not publish prior venue data but advertises Hatfield Hall as its home, implying anchor status. Assuming five shows running 25 days each in 2025–26, it booked 125 dates across the three stages (including Winningstad and Brunish). Without Stumptown's current 60-day Winningstad run, the theater would be dark 56 of 60 days. Without Stumptown, the stage would be effectively bankrupt.



The flex-space Winningstad Theatre rarely gets national bookings.

Brunish Theater

This theater is essentially a large box with seating akin to movable bleachers for about 145 seats, suitable only for flexible but limited-production events. It is the least expensive of the five to rent and generates the lowest gross sales by seat count.

In a 60-day sample, Stumptown Stages occupies roughly 30 days, and Portland Shakespeare Project rents one day. Both present small-cast, simple-set productions to control costs. Like the Winningstad, the Brunish is operating annually at under 50% capacity and is significantly under-rented.

Stumptown's rentals are split between two, possibly three, stages. Typically, Stumptown books 50–60 days per year in either the Newmark or Winningstad and 75–90 days in the Brunish. For the Winningstad and Brunish, their largest tenant occupies about 60 of 360 days in one theater and 90 in the other—by any measure, not enough to anchor their financial viability.

Currently, the financial stability of the aging Winningstad and Brunish theaters rests largely on local arts companies operating under substantial financial risk. At more than 50% annual vacancy rate, these stages cannot generate sufficient income for operations, maintenance, repairs and capital upgrades without city subsidy.

How long can this continue? The city's Performing Arts Venue Workgroup clearly recognized this dilemma in its stated management goals.

And wait 'til you hear the rest of the story.

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If you build it ... they still won't come

Part V: Two private theaters could change everything

by Kurt Misar
NW Examiner
Mar 21, 2026



Will Live Nation continue to rent from the city when it has its own Portland auditorium?

In 2025, METRO returned Portland's management to the city effective 2027—without emphasizing that theater finances will no longer be subsidized by Metro's broader budget. The city must now maximize rentals, retain earnings, and fund capital upgrades. The city's Workgroup stated goals—expanded usage, stronger arts partnerships, improved booking policies—ultimately depend on one thing: increasing rental revenue.

In this series, I withheld an important point so readers could first understand the operating realities of these five city-owned venues. I reviewed rental calendars over several months to assess vacancy, usage, and lease activity to determine whether each venue was maximizing income potential. I had no access to profit-and-loss statements, so this analysis addresses market demand—not accounting performance.

The question was simple: Is there sufficient producer demand to justify the city owning and operating five stages—let alone building a sixth?

The Keller (roughly 3,000 seats) appears to be the most utilized at 80-85% of rental capacity, almost entirely dependent on a single anchor tenant. With a minimum two-year retrofit closure looming, the city stands to lose that anchor to Portland State University, which is proposing its own 3,000-seat theater on its campus.

That proposal sidesteps an obvious option: transferring the anchor to the roughly 3,000-seat Schnitzer, which currently operates near 75% capacity. Of Schnitzer's remaining rentals, approximately 25% come from Live Nation and AEG, with another 25% from outside producers.

As for the three other Portland's stages next door in Hatfield Hall, the Newmark, currently near 50% capacity, relies on many of these same outside producers, along with short-term local rentals. The Winningstad and Brunish operate well under 50% capacity and remain heavily dependent on a single local anchor. These figures suggest insufficient market demand to support additional theater space. The objective appears less about expanding arts access and more about replacing The Keller during its closure.

I do not know why the Schnitzer cannot serve as a temporary home for Broadway Across America. The producers may object to logistics or technical limitations, but it is not the only alternative 3,000-seat venue in Portland—because two more are about to open.

Now for the withheld point. It matters because it reframes how the city presents its development strategy.

Live Nation and AEG

Live Nation is constructing a privately owned 1,250-3,500 seat venue on Southeast Water Avenue. AEG, partnering with Monqui Presents, is building a 2,000–4,250-seat venue at Lloyd Center. Both open before any potential Keller closure. Both will require aggressive booking to recoup construction costs. The city already struggles to fill its existing venues. Soon it will compete with two new private operators seeking many of the same touring acts.

Before speculating about long-term market fragmentation, consider the immediate impact. As producers developing touring acts, Live Nation and AEG are likely to shift many of their current Schnitzer and Newmark bookings into their own facilities. That accounts for roughly 25% of Schnitzer's current rental activity—potentially pushing annual vacancy there toward 50%—with similar effects at the Newmark. At that level, sustained profitability becomes doubtful.

Ironically, those losses could free space at the Schnitzer to absorb Broadway Across America dates displaced from the Keller.

Still, market behavior is never perfectly predictable. Private operators will first prioritize their own productions—primarily music and comedy—but they will also seek bookings from the same national and regional independent producers who historically rent the Schnitzer, Newmark and Winningstad. The city does not want to lose the Broadway Across America business, but is that likely?

Traditionally, BAA occupies municipal theaters designed for touring musicals. It is unclear whether they envision a future in privately owned venues primarily oriented toward pop, rock, country and national comics—but financial incentives can change preferences quickly. A sufficiently favorable deal from a new operator could undercut city pricing and shift the calculus overnight. And each will offer seating capacities in excess of The Keller Auditorium.

BAA maintains strong subscription sales and deep market presence in Portland. If the stage product remains identical, would a venue shift affect ticket demand? And if so, how would relocation to a PSU-based facility differ?

In the next article, we will examine this, including how government seems to distort and misrepresent market realities to achieve broader objectives.

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If you build it... they still won't come

Part VI – Room for 2? How about 5?

By Kurt Misar
March 25, 2025



The need to update Keller Auditorium led to a cascade of questionable propositions.

Before moving forward with the last two installments in this series, a correction is in order, based on the recent city-commissioned market feasibility study.

Our earlier sampling of Keller Auditorium usage was too optimistic. Hunden Partners reported the Keller has an average annual utilization rate of 58%. Our previous 120-day sampling suggested 80-85% utilization, allowing for move-in and move-out days. And that period didn't include the slower summer season.

Hunden was asked to assess whether Portland could sustain both a remodeled Keller and a new Portland State University auditorium and concluded that it could not. Assuming that is true, how will the market absorb two additional privately funded 3,000-seat houses now under construction?

The study acknowledges that an additional PSU venue would further fracture the market and reduce profitability for all operators. It also concedes, but ignores, that the coming privately funded auditoriums by AEG and Live Nation will complicate the competitive landscape. Nevertheless, it recommends expansion in the form of a new 3,000-seat venue on the PSU campus.

Closing the Keller two years for renovation could interrupt Broadway Across America performances there, but city-owned Schnitzer Auditorium could accommodate BAA, at least as a temporary measure. By this summer, the 3,000-plus-seat Live Nation venue should be in operation, followed by AEG's similarly sized facility in 2027.

The study claims local arts organizations would face hardship without a large-scale venue. Yet, if the Keller were temporarily shuttered for renovation, Portland would still have two large houses available within six months, and three within 12—long before PSU could possibly break ground. If Keller were retained post-retrofit, that number rises to four. With PSU, the total could reach five. This not only contradicts the report's conclusion that the market cannot sustain two venues—also shown in this series—but endorses a path that could produce four or five 3,000 seat venues that defy market logic.

While the booking sample of the Schnitzer suggests that it operates in the black, that is before the Live Nation and AEG bookings disappear into their own facilities. Once they stop booking, the Schnitzer will likely fall to 50% vacancy, making it more available for BAA events during Keller renovation.

Meanwhile, the Hatfield Hall trio of stages appear to operate below 50% occupancy. The Keller is barely 60% utilized, and the rest of the city's mid-sized inventory is significantly under-performing. Meanwhile, Portland Opera Association has paused its next season, needing to raise \$500,000 in charitable donations to resume. The POA has been retooling its seasons for at least a decade. Somehow, the public framing of the debate emphasizes protecting venue availability rather than confronting whether some resident companies can afford large houses at all.

This debate ultimately comes down to arithmetic rather than aspiration. When occupancy averages 45-58%, when mid-sized venues operate below half capacity, and when new competitors are entering the same finite marketplace, the rational question is not how to build more, but how to manage what already exists more responsibly. Before taxpayers commit hundreds of millions of dollars to another 3,000-seat hall, the city must come to grips with realities. The issue is not scarcity. It is stewardship.

The last installment examines what may be the most persistent fiction of all: the myth of scarcity.

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If you build it... they still won't come

Part VII - The Myth of Scarcity

by Kurt Misar

March 31, 2025



Hunden Partners has advised the city that two public performing arts auditoriums in Portland are not economically feasible and therefore the Keller Auditorium should be demolished and a new one built by Portland State University.

The problem with the Hunden report is not merely its conclusion, but the framing used to reach it. The document repeatedly presents possibility as probability, amplifies speculative risks and minimizes contradictions within its own market assumptions. Its language reveals a pattern:

- Worst-case scenarios are emphasized, competitive realities are deferred, and renovation is quietly dismissed in favor of replacement.

- It becomes difficult to wade through the joint city and PSU press release rhetoric without encountering statements that overreach or misdirect:

“Its (Keller Auditorium) closure could prevent performances from Broadway Across America for years and cause local arts organizations to face significant challenges without a large-scale performing venue. Portland State University’s proposed facility would be headlined by a 3,000-seat venue, capable of large-scale performances, but could hinder the long-term feasibility of the Portland’s venues, particularly as two new live entertainment facilities from AEG and Live Nation are to be opened in the coming years.”

These claims deserve careful parsing.

First, the suggestion that closure “could prevent performances... for years” implies permanence. A retrofit interruption might last two years. It also assumes that BAA would not relocate temporarily to the Schnitzer or to one of the two new private 3,000-plus-seat venues opening within the next year. An interruption of venue does not equal its disappearance.

Second, the study warns of “significant challenges without a large-scale performing venue.” Yet by summer 2026, there will be at least two 3,000-seat venues, and by early 2027, that reality contradicts the report’s assertion that the region cannot financially sustain two such facilities. With a Keller retrofit, Portland would have four. If PSU were added, five. The contradiction is self-evident.

Third, the study concedes that a new PSU theater “could hinder the long-term feasibility of the Portland’s venues.” On that point, the authors are refreshingly candid. Additional stage supply fragments the already finite demand. The report recognizes this, ignores it, dismisses it and yet still recommends building another venue.

Fourth, the competitive impact of AEG and Live Nation is framed as something occurring “in the coming years,” when in fact those facilities will be operating well before any Keller retrofit or PSU project breaks ground. The market effects will be immediate, not hypothetical.

The study’s most pointed claims appear in these summary bullet arguments:

- *“(Keller is a) ...very wide auditorium that creates many limited view seats, and it features outdated amenities, lowering customer experience.”* (“Many” is asserted without quantification, and no evidence is offered to demonstrate sales deterrence. Limited sightlines and dated amenities are conditions that can be addressed in renovation. They are not proof of terminal decline.)
- *“A multi-year closure of Keller risks eroding Portland’s Broadway Across America audience and forcing skilled labor to relocate from Portland to other cities.”* (Risk does not equal inevitability. Audience erosion presumes no temporary relocation strategy and no substitution venue.

Skilled labor displacement is assumed despite two major private venues under construction and announcing substantial hiring.)

- *“Private competition from new commercial venues could also siphon concerts and events from the Keller, which creates an additional commercial demand reduction if there were to be two large theater-style venues.”* (By early 2027, there will be at least three such venues regardless of Keller’s fate.)
- *“New venues in other markets have resulted in sustained audience and subscription growth, higher customer satisfaction and improved production capability.”* (Even if true elsewhere, that does not justify demolition here. Nor does it establish that modernization is equivalent to a new structure.)

Notice how frequently “possibility” is presented as “certain probability,” and how often conjecture substitutes for evidence.

Meanwhile, the study asserts that the greater Portland market cannot support two large venues like the Keller. Yet the city proposes constructing another 3,000-seat facility rather than renovating the one it owns. In a finite market, adding supply further fragments revenue streams.

For example, Portland Opera Association has recently paused moving forward with a new season, seeking \$500,000 in underwriting before proceeding. That is not a venue problem. It is a demand and cost-balance problem. The city is aware of these financial stresses, yet frames the discussion primarily around preserving access to the most expensive house in town.

We do not need more theaters. We need to ensure the long-term value of the ones we already possess. Whether government—or my own industry—has the skills and discipline to do that remains uncertain.

The full study is available on the city’s website. Make your own assessments and comment below so we can address them.

This is the last installment in the series. Read them all on this site.

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Part V – Live Nation and AEG

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Part VII - The Myth of Scarcity



Kurt Misar is a part-time theater artist who has worked in banking, commercial real estate management and development, commercial leasing and residential sales. He is an associate broker with Capstone Real Estate Services and a resident of Goose Hollow.

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Portland City Council, City Life Committee
July 28, 2026 - 2:00 p.m.
Testimony List 2026-270

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2	Be Marston	2026-270
3	Kimiko Matsuda	2026-270
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Portland City Council Meeting
September 3, 2026 - 2:00 pm
Testimony List

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2	Duke Castle	2026-270
3	Sarah Schwarz	2026-270
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9	Amy Donohue	2026-270
10	Chuck Dillard	2026-270
11	Christine Vernier	2026-270
12	Mark Raggett	2026-270
13	Helen Ying	2026-270
14	Charlene Hannibal	2026-270
15	Carole Morse	2026-270
16	Earl Blumenauer	2026-270
17	Jean Pierre Veillet	2026-270
18	Jenn Hartmann Luck	2026-270
19	Carl Abbott	2026-270
20	Rose Etta Venetucci	2026-270
21	Bob Naito	2026-270
22	Emily Horton	2026-270
23	Terry Goldman	2026-270
24	DIANA STUART	2026-270
25	LaJune Thorson	2026-270
26	Cynthia Hampton	2026-270
27	Tom Reichert	2026-270
28	John Russell	2026-270
29	Donna Bauer	2026-270
30	Jane Taylor	2026-270
31	Julie Bunker	2026-270
32	Dean Barnett	2026-270
33	Joel Thorson	2026-270
34	Chris Finks	2026-270
35	Erica Thompson	2026-270
36	Jesse Wolfe	2026-270
37	Kate Dickson	2026-270
38	Sarah Sopher	2026-270
39	Be Marston	2026-270
40	Andrew Colas	2026-270
41	Kyle Huth	2026-270

	Name	Document Number
42	Anjanet Banuelos Bolanos	2026-270
43	Andrew Smith	2026-270
44	Joyce Follingstad	2026-270
45	Ernest R Munch	2026-270
46	Anthony Samperio	2026-270
47	Russell Benton	2026-270
48	Dana West	2026-270